# Ven Anīgha Reddit Archive 2026

Ven Anīgha

2026

# Contents


Is progress possible while suicidal? . . . 1
Question about “The Arrow” vs. “The Abyss” suttas . . . 3
Training Rightly with Discomforts . . . 5
Question on Recent Video “Is Stream Entry an Event” . . . 7
Deconstructing the Non-Technique Fallacy: Why Neuroscience Proves Focused Attention Doesn’t “Corrupt” Background Awareness, and why Backround (peripheral) vs foreground attention is a false dichotomy (article) . . . 10
Right livelihood as a musician . . . 13
Fail to escape from sensuality . . . 13
Kosambiya Sutta and fostering harmony . . . 14
I Have A Request For Hillside . . . 16
Distinguishing between samvega and aversion . . . 23
Being surrounded by beautiful women . . . 23
Can I keep the precepts as a trial for a few months before committing to them for life? . . . 24
Where does my responsibility end? . . . 25
Just a couple of questions . . . 27
Questions on entertainment . . . 29
How do we know whether we’re uprooting suffering or merely managing it? 30
AN 6.44 directly opposes Bhikku Anigha’s claim that “Stream entry requires celibacy” . . . 30
About a recent post that has been deleted . . . 32
AN 8.54 - A layperson can develop liberating wisdom without 8 precepts, according to the buddha? Criticism of HH . . . 34
Repressing anger is inevitable for an ordinary person, in order to not act out. . . . 36
Do you need to be free from the 5 hindrances (i.e. get 1st jhana) to become a sotapanna (i.e. get right view)? . . . 36
The sense of self . . . 37
Questioning my views . . . 38
Metta to calm aversion, not get rid of pressure without fully developed virtue 43
What flaws do you see in my understanding of practice? . . . 44

Seemingly contradicting statements by Ajahn Nyanamoli and Bhikku Anigha on meditation (as far as I can tell) . . . 46
How to Interpret the Vinaya . . . 51
Venerable Anigha and Venerable Medhini please have pity on me () . . . 53
Is treating gender dysphoria through medical intervention acting out of craving? . . . 54
Question on the nature of HH's critique of other traditions . . . 57
Request: sequential series for beginners? . . . 59
"Doing Nothing" Meditation . . . 61
the right peace before stream entry . . . 61
I have created a free Sutta companion app - To implement Gradual training need review from hh . . . 62
Right Restraint or Wrong Restraint? . . . 64
Storage, items and Monks . . . 66
How do you practice tranquility? . . . 66
Question regarding interpretation and application of Pātimokkha rules . . . 68
Clarification of "no high and luxurious beds" precept? . . . 70
Building the foundations . . . 71
Intrusive thoughts () . . . 73
The Ultimate Choice . . . 74
"Or the memory that 'feeling is there' is established..." . . . 77
Questions on Sleep and fine Food as Obstacles in Practice . . . 78
An attempt to clarify HH's stance on the relationship between sotapatti and celibacy . . . 82
Right mindset to benefit from the confession server? . . . 86
Arahants laughing . . . 88
Wrong meditation as an aid for establishing virtue and sense restraint? . . . 90
Question about virtue, entertainment, and understanding the emphasis on celibacy . . . 91
Some thoughts and reflections on my difficulties with keeping the precepts 94
Chinese Parallel to Kālāma Sutta . . . 96
How to clearly see the first noble truth? . . . 97
How can one understand various fruitions through Ahjan's analogy? . . . 98
Two Questions on Paticcasamuppada . . . 99
practice question . . . 99
MN 43's Parato Ghoso Usage of right view, . . . 100
Beauty, Ugliness, Danger in the Body . . . 103
Questions on Contemplating . . . 105
Questioning Hillside Hermitage based on the Suttas: "All the Defilements", Sutta MN2 . . . 106
Essays in book format? . . . 111
Question on "Definitive Guide to Seeing Your Mind" Dhamma Talk . . . 112
Why is business/trading in meat & living beings Wrong Livelihood? . . . 116
Beautiful and Ugly () . . . 117
Practice advice . . . 118

Possibility and eventuality . . . . . 121
Mittasutta: satipaṭṭhāna practice for puthujjanas? . . . . . 123
Yoniso Manasikara in practice . . . . . 123
How Should Buddhist Cosmology be Interpreted? . . . . . 125
What should I do if I struggle to discern intentions of greed, aversion, or delusion? . . . . . 126
After Recognizing Sensuality as Bait for Hindrances : Right Effort to protect one from that sinking feeling. . . . . 128

**Archive notes**

**Generated:** 2026-11-01 05:45:04 UTC

**Saved records in this volume:** 70 discussions and 149 comments.

**Saved comment dates:** 2026-01-06 to 2026-10-02 (UTC).

Volumes are grouped by the year each discussion began; replies may be from later years. This edition contains the records saved in the local database at generation time. It is not a claim of complete Reddit coverage. Deleted, unavailable, or unfetched material may be absent. Comment timestamps are shown in UTC.

# Is progress possible while suicidal?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Pinglite *2026-09-30 07:07:40*

For the benefit of anyone who takes the time to read this, know that I'm not in some temporary depressive state in need of immediate encouragement to stay alive.

It's not my intention for anyone to feel pressured or responsible for my life so please be at ease.

# My Current Stage:

I've taken on the seven precepts, starting around two months ago.

I have currently limited myself to two mealtimes on the weekdays, eating only once on both days of the weekend. I have had some issues around indulgence in food (it's still within my allotted meal-time but I feel urged to eat more to extend the duration) which have sprung up and I still sometimes give in to.

Additionally I replaced both my old bed with a lower one with a firm mattress, and my old overly comfortable pillow with a basic one.

I had friends I would spend time with discussing all sorts of unbeneficial topics whom I've now limited contact with to being about important life events only.

I am living at home with one family member and monitor my participation in conversation to avoid the 3 types of wrong speech, and I try to minimize talk unrelated to necessary duties otherwise.

The hardest jump for me was with entertainment. While I don't see the danger in it, I will not be going back, since I've recognized that it's value for me was in forgetting that I exist without ever actually helping me.

# Problem:

I've been suicidal most of my life, do not recall a time beforehand. I'll exclude further detail since I don't believe it'd be helpful.

If it's needed I have no issue elaborating.

Basically, I've always viewed suicide as an option, and if it weren't for entertainment I would have taken it by now. Now that I'm going to be avoiding the aforementioned distractions for the rest of my life my only reason to stay alive is to see if this practice works.

I'm familiar enough with the content talks to have heard the point with regard to sensuality that you shouldn't rely on progress first to justify giving it up. I wonder if that applies in this situation?

If I am open to the possibility of committing suicide, does that in and of itself prevent the kind of progress that would encourage me to value continued practice over suicide?

While that last question was in general, more specifically does openness to suicide constitute a fault regarding the precept on abstaining from taking life? Would I be unable to understand what sense-restraint is until I've internally abandoned the possibility of suicide?

Assuming in advance the worst-case where I'm guaranteed to make no progress until suicide is abandoned, how would I go about abandoning it? The uncertainty regarding the outcome is why I became interested in the Dhamma given that supposedly verifiable certainty in this life is possible.

It's a direct upgrade for the goal of ending suffering permanently since if true it provides insurance against any after-life shenanigans.

However, my taking on of this practice is conditioned upon the idea that I'll see for myself that it's worthwhile, without which my response to possibility of future suffering would be suicide.

I'll cease my jabbering there.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-10-02 15:06:55

> I'm familiar enough with the content talks to have heard the point with regard to sensuality that you shouldn't rely on progress first to justify giving it up. I wonder if that applies in this situation?

Yes, it applies to whatever kind of emotional dependence you start with.

> If I am open to the possibility of committing suicide, does that in and of itself prevent the kind of progress that would encourage me to value continued practice over suicide?

Having a mind that inclines towards suicide is not by itself the obstruction. It's the extent to which you don't feel an acute need to overcome that inclination, i.e., that you justify it or downplay it (and the same applies for sensuality).

> While that last question was in general, more specifically does openness to suicide constitute a fault regarding the precept on abstaining from taking life?

No. It's not a precept breach strictly speaking, but the result is similar. Delighting in suicide is a coping mechanism in regard to suffering which you'll need to give up to be able to realize the true escape from it.

> Assuming in advance the worst-case where I'm guaranteed to make no progress until suicide is abandoned, how would I go about abandoning it?

Same as with sensuality: by enduring the pull of the mind. It's not about forcing the mind to stop wanting it; it's about not letting it have what it wants even as a hypothetical. So if you keep the context that you will never commit suicide no matter what, never welcoming that possibility even in thought, the mind will let go of it eventually.

## Question about "The Arrow" vs. "The Abyss" suttas

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: boredman_ny *2026-09-15 20:51:34*

I've been reading about the interpretation of the Arrow Sutta from HH and I'm having some doubts.

So, the interpretation of the Arrow sutta, as far as I understood reading the notes and comments from HH is that:

1. The Arrow sutta is talking about the difference between Sekha vs. Puthujjana, and not an Arahant vs. Puthujjana.
2. The Sekha is not strucked by the second arrow, which would be not knowing the escape from the unpleasant feeling by way of the body/kayika.
3. The Sekha only feels *one feeling*, kayika vedhana. So, for the sekha, there is suffering only on the account of the body: kayika dukkha vedana. They only feel *one* arrow.
4. The Arahant, however, feels no arrow at all. For them, feelings are not arrows or they don't feel feeling at all? Here, I understand that is something in line of what Nanavira was saying, although, less definitively: "There is, and there is not, contact in the case of the arahat, just as there is, and there is not, consciousness."

If the understanding above is somehow correct, this interpretation is based on two conceptions: kayika vedhana is not physical sensations, although it includes it, kayika dukkha vedana can be even mental suffering, referring to the mano: "The feeling arising from the death of a loved one or from an unpleasant mood would thus also be "bodily", i.e., pertaining to the five aggregates.", from a note to that

sutta. And, since there is no contact for the Arahant (Contacts contact dependent on ground / How should contacts contact a groundless one?)

So, a sekha being tortured, although they probably will feel immense pain from the six senses and even get mentally confused by the immense pain, their citta will not look for sensuality as an escape and get desperate because it cannot find escape, which is the second arrow. Am I thinking correctly?

Now, my maing doubt is regarding this:

> In the same way, bhikkhus, an unlearned ordinary person, when struck by unpleasant feeling, sorrows, wails, laments, beats their breast, and becomes disoriented. They feel two feelings: a bodily one as well as one pertaining to the citta.
>
> Struck by that same unpleasant feeling, they resist it. *Thus, the underlying tendency to resistance against unpleasant feeling underlies them.*
>
> Struck by unpleasant feeling, they delight in the pleasure of sensuality. Why is that? Because, bhikkhus, an unlearned ordinary person does not understand any escape from unpleasant feeling apart from the pleasure of sensuality. Since they delight in the pleasure of sensuality, *the underlying tendency to passion for pleasant feeling underlies them.*
>
> They do not understand as they are the origin, ending, gratification, peril, and escape from those feelings. Since they do not understand as they are the origin, ending, gratification, peril, and escape from those feelings, *the underlying tendency to ignorance with regard to neither-pleasant-nor-unpleasant feeling underlies them.*

So, here, the Buddha talks about that the ariya does not have an underlying tendency to patigha towards it (not aversion?), passion for pleasant feeling (greed?) and ignorance with regard to neutral feeling (delusion?) does not underlying them. How can this does not mean not-greed, not-aversion, not-delusion for a sekha? Which cannot be, since they still have it?

Hope someone can help me clarify these. I would appreciate an article on this sutta detailing these, since it goes against basically how everybody else interprets these.

Edit: Ignore the title of the post. I was gonna use that sutta because the Buddha uses saririka vedāna there in an equivalent manner as kayika vedana here, but I thought unnecessary, and forgot to change the title.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-09-17 14:17:13

> And, since there is no contact for the Arahant (Contacts contact dependent on ground / How should contacts contact a groundless one?)

Yes.

> So, a sekha being tortured, although they probably will feel immense pain from the six senses and even get mentally confused by the immense pain, their citta will not look for sensuality as an escape and get desperate because it cannot find escape, which is the second arrow. Am I thinking correctly?

Yes.

> So, here, the Buddha talks about that the ariya does not have an underlying tendency to patigha towards it (not aversion?), passion for pleasant feeling (greed?) and ignorance with regard to neutral feeling (delusion?) does not underlying them. How can this does not mean not-greed, not-aversion, not-delusion for a sekha? Which cannot be, since they still have it?

It does mean that. As you yourself noted, the Sutta is meant to illustrate the contrast between puthujjana and sekha (and thereby show the former what they have to do to become the latter). The statement "they still have greed, aversion, delusion" takes an Arahant for comparison instead of a puthujjana.

## Training Rightly with Discomforts

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Drevix645 *2026-09-12 17:13:46*

How does one distinguish bearing discomforts, on the level of things mentioned as "Influxes to be abandoned by bearing" in Sabbasava Sutta (MN2), enduring discomfort on the right level, even perhaps introducing them, versus doing so mechanically or not on the right level, like someone with no interest in Dhamma practice who can endure extreme conditions?

My answer would be that it comes down to discerning the mind. Rightly bearing discomforts means rightly bearing the mind experiencing discomforts, because abandoning the craving on the level of the mind is the point, not the discomforts themselves. Anything else is not the right bearing, which anyone can do with enough reason to do so.

I ask this question because I can (seem to) recognize instances where my mind has aversion towards discomforts like being hungry, being cold, etc. On one hand, I can make sense of an idea like "If I intentionally exposed the mind to some more of this (within reason and not exceeding my limits), that would be useful." But what does it mean from my point of view for it to be useful? So it does not complain, desire against those things does not arise, and this way it can be stronger and more peaceful when adversity comes its way. But then, could this be coming from my own aversion? Do I assume the complaining mind is the problem I need to solve, and not my attitude in regard to the mind with aversion? Do I assume the arising of desire itself is the problem I need to prevent from happening? Maybe that's not correct,

but I still feel somehow this kind of exposure can be useful if one's intentions are clear.

So I'm curious, what is the correct place from which to do this, if it is correct at all, and not done for obviously wrong reasons like conceit and ego and such?

This question comes from the context of keeping the 8 precepts for the last several months, and wondering if this could be additionally beneficial for my particular challenge, which is being quite concerned about not eating enough food, even at the right time. I've had times where whatever mental state felt too overwhelming in tandem with trying to eat a bit less, and would stress eat even though it was in the right time, which isn't in the spirit of the precept which of course only led to wanting to do that more, though not at the wrong time. So, it made me think about introducing learning to better endure some hunger/not eating as much as I would like to under more stable conditions, but I know these sort of things can become easily taken over by one's external sense of duty too.

Thank you!

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-09-14 15:19:32

> My answer would be that it comes down to discerning the mind. Rightly bearing discomforts means rightly bearing the mind experiencing discomforts, because abandoning the craving on the level of the mind is the point, not the discomforts themselves. Anything else is not the right bearing, which anyone can do with enough reason to do so.

Correct.

> But then, could this be coming from my own aversion?

It could be. It's usually aversion to the mind's dislikes—to it's nature of experiencing certain things as unpleasant (or pleasant for that matter). Not seeing that this nature is not craving in and of itself, assuming that you're training the mind just because something is unpleasant and you're enduring it, is how you fall into self-mortification.

It's not wrong to take on such restraints if you make sure the effort doesn't become linked to a specific object or situation but that, as you said, you always take them on chiefly in relation to the mind. So you're not eating less because you associate that with greater diligence and effort, but because you see that *for you, there and then*, it goes against the grain of *this* craving. There is no inference or hope involved.

Edit: fixed typo

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-09-17 13:46:54 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> So I guess one could estimate some general baseline of eating enough just to sustain one through the next day, but beyond that it sounds like something that just demands case-by-case judgement.

Yes.

> I've found it hard to know the right balance of this. I know it must be to some extent trial and error, and I lean on the side of caution due to my previous tendencies of yo-yoing between taking on lots at once and then backsliding, but I'd be curious to hear your perspective too.

In this example, see if there is anything in regard to the precepts and sense restraint that you're still stumbling with, and fix that before you start clamping down on food consumption. Do you still find yourself close to breaking precepts and having to hold yourself back? If not, then are your thoughts and intentions fully restrained in regard to coarser forms of sensuality and ill will? If not then leave the food issue for later.

## Question on Recent Video "Is Stream Entry an Event"

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: upasakatrainee *2026-09-03 16:33:25*

u/Bhikkhu_Anigha
Hello Bhante. Could I ask a couple of clarifications on your most recent video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BnQrGm/_Lxks)

**1. Regarding the memory of the "event of realization" (of the adze-handle having indeed worn out), and the analogy with understanding Calculus:**

With the Calculus analogy, is it not correct that one can know with certainty that one *now understands* something which one *previously did not understand*, while nevertheless being unable to identify the *precise point in time* at which the transition from not-understanding to understanding occurred?

If so, is the analogy intended to *apply fully* (as above) to the "event of realization" as well — i.e. that one can subsequently remember having realized, without that memory necessarily identifying a **definite crossover point** in time?

Or, is it the case that there is simply a limitation to the analogy here, such that the "event of realization" **is in fact** a phenomenologically identifiable **precise crossover point**, which one can remember as having occurred **at a particular time**, even though the Calculus analogy would not capture this?

In other words, I am wondering whether the uncertainty about *when* the transition occurred, is part of the phenomenology of realization itself, or merely a limitation

of the Calculus analogy.

**2. Regarding the Buddha's former teachers and other ascetics having "wrong practice":**

I was wondering about the precise sense in which you are using the word "wrong."

Is it meant in the **full and literal sense** that their practice was fundamentally misguided and wayward (to the same extent as the 6 ascetics with wrong views referred to by King Ajātasattu in DN2), despite whatever virtue, restraint, collectedness, etc. they had developed? Or is the point that their practice was "wrong" specifically because it lacked the **decisive element** of Right View, while **nevertheless containing substantial development** in other respects?

I ask because these seem like rather different possibilities which listeners might infer. Also, "ascetic practice" could easily be understood as referring to self-mortification of the sort practised by the Jains, whereas Āḷāra Kālāma and Uddaka Rāmaputta, for example, had developed very refined forms of samādhi (The Buddha's consideration of Āḷāra and Uddaka as having "little dust in their eyes" also seems relevant here).

And relatedly, isn't there a significant distinction here between those who had **not yet heard the Dhamma**, and practitioners today **who have access to it**, but nevertheless pursue practices incompatible with it?

Examples such as Koṇḍañña, Bāhiya, and Uruvelā Kassapa also come to mind, where they **did give up** their former practice once the Buddha pointed out where to look. Is it not reasonable to understand their prior development as having been an important condition for their ability to recognize and follow what the Buddha was pointing out (which would make it possible to say that they weren't **entirely** wrong).

So I was wondering whether you **intentionally meant** that their practice was simply "wrong" without such qualification, or is it again simply a semantic limitation of the word?

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-09-04 14:25:25

> If so, is the analogy intended to apply fully (as above) to the "event of realization" as well — i.e. that one can subsequently remember having realized, without that memory necessarily identifying a definite crossover point in time?

It does apply fully, and that was precisely the point of the analogy.

> the "event of realization" is in fact a phenomenologically identifiable precise crossover point

Certainly not. It's not like there is a "switch" that could have flipped without you noticing it (which is what the "precise crossover point" idea allows for), because the realization itself *is the noticing.* Stream-entry is *knowing that you know.*

Similarly, nothing along the lines of "my experience changed in such and such a way" can ever be a measure of stream-entry. Even "my suffering has uninterruptedly lessened to almost zero for the last X amount of years" is not *understanding*, and can certainly happen without it. You would be *inferring* that understanding occurred because of the change, and inference is diametrically opposed to *knowing that you know.*

> So I was wondering whether you intentionally meant that their practice was simply "wrong" without such qualification, or is it again simply a semantic limitation of the word?

If something misleads you regarding freedom from suffering then it is wrong. When you're comparing practices as an external observer then you can talk about "more wrong" and less "wrong." But internally, as an authentic individual who is committed to something for the sake of liberation—which was the context of my statement—that something is either correct or not, and you will give it up if you recognize it as the latter. You would not knowingly settle for "less wrong."

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-09-05 14:11:59 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> It is an "event" in the sense of a distinctly knowable occurrence, such that one can remember with certainty that "this happened; before this, I didn't know it; now I do," while the precise temporal coordinates and circumstantial details may later fade away like any other memory. Does that sound right?

There is no "this happened." One realizes that one's understanding is no longer subject to doubt by directly seeing that it is no longer subject to doubt; that certainty is not inferred from any kind of event or occurrence.

What one can remember is the occasion on which one first confirmed that one's understanding had overcome doubt: despite arousing a genuine sense of uncertainty by trying to doubt it, that uncertainty poses no threat at all to one's clarity.

It is not that no uncertainty arises and therefore one is certain. The absence of uncertainty merely means that one has *decided* to hold back on questioning.

# Deconstructing the Non-Technique Fallacy: Why Neuroscience Proves Focused Attention Doesn't "Corrupt" Background Awareness, and why Backround (peripheral) vs foreground attention is a false dichotomy (article)

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: EmptinessInForm *2026-08-30 12:04:30*

Hey,

Psychology student here.

First of all I want to say that I highly respect Hillside Hermitage. However, I believe some of their interpretations are based on a false dichotomy in regards to how the mind actually works to create reality, so I decided to write an article. I hope this might contribute to bring the meditation space forward towards higher understanding. Also, I hope I haven't misrepresented HH.

For years, a central dogma of the non-technique meditation movement—most aggressively championed by groups like Hillside Hermitage—has been that intentional focused attention is an artificial distortion that "corrupts" a pristine, unconstructed background awareness. But when scrutinized through modern cognitive neuroscience, this rigid separation between a foreground spotlight and a peripheral background collapses into a complete false dichotomy.

Your "background context" isn't a passive, unmanaged space—it is an actively manufactured product built millisecond-by-millisecond by the exact same sub-attentional machinery that powers focus.

Core Arguments Breakdown:

Visual and bodily neuroscience demonstrates that even during gaze fixation, the brain executes automatic, involuntary microsaccades (1–3 Hz) alongside covert spatial polling to constantly refresh your peripheral baseline. Without this underlying micro-attention, the subjective sense of an "enduring bodily background" completely collapses (as seen in clinical conditions like hemispatial neglect).

Single Computational Resource (Load Theory): Nilli Lavie's Load Theory shows that background awareness is simply spare processing capacity spilling over from your primary target. Foreground and background do not run on two separate engines; they share the same attentional pool.

Effort vs. Direction: What causes "attentional blinks" and cognitive tunneling isn't the *presence* of intentional focus, but the *intensity of cognitive effort*. A high-load vise-like focus blinds you to context, whereas a relaxed, low-effort anchor leaves ample processing capacity open to illuminate the broader background.

Ego-Suppression via Top-Down Control: Goal-directed focus recruits the Dorsal Attention Network (DAN), which actively down-regulates the Default Mode Network (DMN)—the brain's primary hub for self-referential narrative. Far from fabricating an artificial "doer," top-down low-load focus actually quiets the narrative self.

Because the brain relies on continuous, sub-attentional feature-sampling to generate the sensation of a bodily background in the first place, intentional focus does not introduce an artificial intruder into a pristine field. By intentionally holding a light, low-effort anchor, we harness the brain's natural mechanics to achieve both crystal-clear discernment and panoramic, contextual stillness.

https://medium.com/@EmptinessInForm/the-cognitive-mechanics-of-attention-in-meditation-an-attempt-to-reconcile-intentional-focus-with-40339c52fae0?sharedUserId=EmptinessInForm

TL;DR: Background awareness isn't a passive, unconstructed ground—it's actively maintained millisecond-by-millisecond by sub-conscious attentional sampling. Because foreground focus and peripheral context share the exact same cognitive engine, holding a low-effort anchor doesn't corrupt your awareness; it simply stabilizes the mind while leaving spare capacity open to illuminate the background.

Edit:

I definitely would drop words like pristine and unconstructed background if I were to write this up again; that's a mischaracterisation of HH. I think it would be better to say that the background that HH refers to is:

"The unchosen, structural dimension of experience that endures simultaneously alongside whatever is currently being directly attended to."

My article is an attempt to assess the fact that awareness of said background requires attention, thus discriminating it as strictly a "background" is a false dichotomy. Attending thus does not reduce the sight of this background, because attending is a necessary basis for the background to exist in the first place. You cannot separate foreground and background as 1. a place where attention exists, and 2. a place where attention does not exist, unless you make background into siimply a philosophical idea.

I hope this cleared up misunderstandings.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-30 14:41:40

There are two main issues with this:

1. As even mundane phenomenologists like Husserl and Sartre pointed out, phenomenology requires you to set aside the scientific outlook from the outset. You simply cannot expect science to "prove" anything about our phenomenological experience without already having abandoned the ability to understand experience on its own terms.

Understanding experience on their own terms—from the "inside" rather than through an external lens like that of science, or even Buddhist quasi-science like the Abhidhamma—is what the Dhamma is about. That is why no Arahant or noble disciple ever *could* turn to science to support his insights; that very attempt takes those insights outside of the only domain where they apply, and he would be thoroughly aware of that by that point.

2. Whatever "processes" were being observed in the subjects of the studies you refer to are not what we refer to as peripheral awareness (or *yoniso manasikāra*, more accurately). Quite unlike an "automatic proprioceptive sampling" that happens on its own, yoniso manasikāra requires a lot of work to achieve. It does not exist for most practitioners, let alone the completely worldly people that would've participated in those studies. It is possible to achieve only internally—i.e., phenomenologically—for those who have taken on the precepts, withdrawn from sensuality, contemplated the danger in it, abandoned modern wrong views about the practice, etc.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-30 15:45:39 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Cogsci is just phenomenology that also actually correlates with behavioural results that confirm said phenomenology.

Correlating with behavioral/experimental results means applying a third-person point of view over experience, so that can't be phenomenology by definition:

> Phenomenology is the study of structures of consciousness as experienced **from the first-person point of view.**.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-30 16:13:40 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> I didn't say cogsci is phenomenology - I said it is phenomenology + behavioural experiments.

And my point is that if you try to combine these two, there is no proper phenomenology anymore.

> In that case, I would be highly motivated to come to Samandipa to attempt some experiments.

I'm afraid we wouldn't consent to that, as it would only reinforce the misconception that science and the Dhamma can even speak about the same things, let alone "agree" with each other. That view needs to be given up in order to meet the Dhamma where it is.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-31 14:50:49 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

Nothing in a wrench makes it inherently necessary to put all screwdrivers aside, so that's a false analogy.

## Right livelihood as a musician

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: ApprehensiveWriter23 *2026-08-27 15:26:47*

I am a musician, a violinist. I have been living by the five precepts for three years, and for the past year, I have added celibacy (I am married, but my partner agrees). The purpose of my practice is freedom from suffering, or at least to develop my mind as much as possible in this lifetime. My question focuses on right livelihood: I mostly make a living by teaching music, and very occasionally by performing live. Generally, I reduce my consumption of recorded or live music to almost nothing, except for the occasional specific reference regarding the interpretation of a piece I need to teach a student. I know that in order to progress I should give up this activity. But I need help understanding the necessity, as it is not entirely obvious to me. Should I abandon this livelihood/profession, I would need to look for a job in cleaning, transportation, or some similar service. Personally, I am not afraid of that change, but I am afraid of the opinions of my family and wife, who would likely see it as something wrong.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-30 05:57:41

Whenever you willingly exposure yourself (or others) to music, even if with a relatively disinterested attitude initially, you have opened the door the possibility of passion, and that choice is by itself a defilement (a kind of delusion/non-clarity) even if no acute passion ends up materializing.

It is one of those cases where the thing in question does not appear like an inherent obstacle, but it becomes an obstacle when not given up simply due to the implications of the choice to maintain it (MN 66).

## Fail to escape from sensuality

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: HoldenVJ *2026-08-19 01:58:37*

I have watch a ton of videos of the teachig of Hillside. I have a lot of faith in Ajahn teaching. I have try my best to avoid sensuality. I know that it is beginning of the path. Unless one can keep 8 precepts there is no further development on Dhamma. I didnt manage to quit sensual desire yet but I try to keep it at minimum.

Yesterday we found out that my mother got ovariaon cancer. I am experiencing a lot of suffering. I know that I should't try to manage the suffering. I should endure it as Ajahn said. But I can't find a way out of this pain. I still rely on sensuality to cope with this pain. I know its just a distraction. But I dont have no where else to go to. I shouldnt use method like watching nostril or watching sensation to calm my self down either.

What is your advice in situation like this?

I figure the best answer might be something like "just endure it". But I really can't right now. I'm not that skillfull yet.

Thank you

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-20 05:20:54

> What is your advice in situation like this?

Keep your ways of managing the pain within the precepts. You won't realistically be able to not manage it at all from day one.

## Kosambiya Sutta and fostering harmony

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: titikshakshanti *2026-08-17 01:57:51*

Where the *Kosambiya Sutta* connects"Right View" and *harmony*, HH teachings are often interpreted as an introspective pursuit that minimizes the role of the positive actions that foster harmony and emphasise the role of avoiding the negative actions rooted in greed, aversion, and delusion.

The Buddha provides specific, actionable behavioral instructions (the six qualities) to resolve a conflict. The practice here is functional and relational. Even if imperfect, such a practice can be helpful even if the person has not attained right view, as long as it is done within the training with precepts and sense restraint.

Avoiding actions rooted in unwholesome intentions is one part of the training. Doing actions that aren't rooted in such intentions but rooted in opposite intentions should be another part of the training. The other part is not emphasised by Hillside Hermitage.

Buddha instructs Bhikkhus to treat others with bodily, verbal, and mental kindness and not just asks them to avoid actions of bodily, verbal and mental enmity.

Buddha says that these things are also essential along with living according to precepts and having right view.

I understand that like meditation and mindfulness, one's understanding of what counts as metta and karuna or friendliness and kindness will not be correct ini-

tially. But, one should strive towards that understanding in both ways: by avoiding certain actions and by doing certain actions.

Consider these quotes:

1. "… are you treating your spiritual companions with kindness by way of body, speech, and mind, both in public and in private?"
2. "Mendicants, these six warm-hearted qualities make for fondness and respect, conducing to inclusion, harmony, and unity, without quarreling"
3. "Furthermore, a mendicant shares without reservation any material things they have gained by legitimate means, even the food placed in the alms-bowl, using them in common with their ethical spiritual companions …"

My question is: Have I understood the teachings of this and similar suttas correctly? Do Hillside Hermitage also emphasise such teachings in their talks? Are such positive qualities should be cultivated while striving for the right view along with training with the precepts? Are there HH videos on this topic?

It would be great if a whole sutta study like talk is made on this topic.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-17 05:24:11

You seem to be reading into the Sutta something that it never says: that kind and "positive" actions are *part of the training*. They are not, and that's why we don't talk about them. Not because one should refrain from them altogether.

Plus, the friendly conduct that the Sutta describes naturally arises as a byproduct of having trained the mind away from intentions of ill-will, so it's not even like one has to make that into a "practice" of its own. Trying to do so only serves to indicate that one is not overcoming ill-will but instead artificially overriding it (and those are mutually exclusive).

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-17 14:18:32 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> There are many Vinaya rules and stories about such actions that foster harmony.

Sure. That still doesn't mean it's on par with the restraint of actions out of ill-will. Harmony is a mundane but still quite important concern especially in the context of the Saṅgha.

> I was not clear but underlying thought process was something like that: I will obey precepts against wrong speech and wrong actions and refrain from active kind and positive actions. It

That reasoning is the problem then. You shouldn't blindly try to avoid those actions as if they are bad in themselves. You should just not put them anywhere near on the same level as the precepts and sense restraint, because then you would exempt them from questioning and overlook when they are rooted in delight in company and similar.

# I Have A Request For Hillside

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: None *2026-08-14 14:49:55*

There's a lot of misconception and misunderstanding surrounding your perspectives of sense restraint and celibacy in relation to Sotapanna attainment. I think the Venerables should

*() Create an entire series strictly for laypeople in how to practice the Buddha's teachings.*

*() Clear up all misunderstandings and misconceptions.*

Apparently, many people are confused, and in some cases, become discouraged to practice due to the beliefs of how to practice as a layperson regarding Sotapatti attainment.

Can the Venerables accomplish this task?

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-14 15:38:13

> Create an entire series strictly for laypeople in how to practice the Buddha's teachings.

This is what all of the published talks are already geared towards.

> Apparently, many people are confused, and in some cases, become discouraged to practice due to the beliefs of how to practice as a layperson regarding Sotapatti attainment.

How do you propose preventing such discouragement?

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-14 17:21:15 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

I don't think we can make it any clearer that it's the former.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-15 05:33:37 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

The answer is B. It's a structural necessity rather than a pragmatic one.

What seems to confuse people (and make them think we're contradicting the Suttas) is that they hear "you won't get the Right View unless you've been celibate for a long time" when we say "celibacy is indispensable." But how long a person has been celibate does not by itself tell you anything about how they relate to sensuality internally (i.e., they might still not be striving to categorically break away from it).

Unconditional celibacy is simply the result of a person striving to categorically abandon sensuality and seeing the peril in it, and success in *that* is what makes insight possible (as the Suttas clearly show).

Now, how long it will take for that striving to succeed (for the mind to be free from the hindrances), you cannot say in advance. And *here* is where I would make a pragmatic rather than categorical statement: for most people it will probably take years of unconditional celibacy (and of the further restraints that only become possible within that).

And by the way, the reason why it has to be *unconditional* celibacy and not just "I'll be celibate until I get the Right View" is that the intention to return to sensuality after the right view, or at any point, is a categorical hindrance *in the present.* It means the danger is being altogether dismissed.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-15 15:37:43 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Because irrespective of my (and anyone's) personal opinion of whether right view is a tangible possibility without years of unbroken celibacy, I think greater separation being made between the structural requirement and the practical reality you have seen/believe in would serve to help the community and prevent discouragement.

If you think this separation would make the pill easier to swallow, you're underestimating what I mean by "unconditional celibacy" and the internal abandonment of sensuality. The massive gap between the number of stream-enterers and lifelong monks proves that being celibate for decades is a far more accessible achievement than true internal renunciation.

Said differently, if "I need to be celibate for years" causes discouragement, true internal renunciation will be even more unpalatable.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-16 05:37:08 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Did I misinterpret what Ajahn said?

Yes, if you understood it as "you can stop there and that'll be good enough." That would mean not actually accepting the situation as compromised (and sensuality as dangerous and painful) and so being fine with settling within it (and *not* doing this was in fact the whole point of the talk).

If you took the five precepts and occasional eight with the right outlook, you would still be seeing every bit of sensuality as something to be abandoned and actively striving towards that ideal (and eventually achieving it if you indeed get the Right View). Meaning, you would still feel very much compelled to achieve unbroken celibacy and sense restraint, and would be unable to be content with less than that.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-17 05:07:50 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Which I assume if someone manages to succeed in this disadvantaged position, then either by the end of one's life or in subsequent rebirth a celibate lifestyle must and willingly will be undertaken on account of attaining the right view.

The celibate lifestyle must be undertaken to attain the right view, not after it. That was the point of my earlier comment. All I conceded is that a person can *start* with five precepts and occasional eight, but it is impossible for one's mind to be freed from the hindrances (the prerequisite for the right view) unless one's mind has let go of sensuality categorically and unconditionally. The person who properly took on the practice towards right view would be aware of this from the beginning, and hence they would be working towards it even if gradually.

So just to reiterate, nothing has changed from my first answer in this thread. Without undertaking permanent celibacy and taming the mind to be content with that, one will not get the Right View.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-17 16:08:11 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Not in regards to doctrine or the general structure, but it seems primarily in regards to the possibility for a mind to be truly freed from the hindrances in a shorter duration of time and in more flexible of circumstances than you say.

This is most probably because we're not on the same page about what the hindrances are. Knowing them for what they are would show why any trace of non-

celibate intentions—even mere doubt about the unconditionality of one's celibate resolve—is inseparable from them.

> So in the future outside this thread, I'll keep this opinion off this sub since I don't want to place any undue conflict on your teachings.

That's not necessary. Even people who are in full agreement with our position and are already celibate can benefit from these discussions.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-17 19:59:49 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> So if I'm following this correctly, then you mean "hindrance" is defined broadly enough that any residual sensual intention counts, correct?

Yes. And even without explicit sensual intention, any elation or zeal toward the prospect of sense pleasures counts. It means the danger is not seen.

So freedom from the hindrance of sensuality is not "I have no thoughts about sensual pleasures at the moment", which anyone can achieve even without any real precepts through misguided practices. It's "No zeal arises even when I openly imagine the most alluring pleasures because the danger is clear."

> So by that metric, then "freedom from hindrances requires categorical celibacy" becomes true by definition, not by argument.

Exactly. Hence anyone demanding further argument or Sutta evidence is failing to see what freedom from the hindrances means.

> And that is why you would find it highly unlikely that anyone who hasn't been celibate for years could get there?

Yes, but again, the claim that celibacy is required has nothing to do with this pragmatic duration issue. It's because nothing short of permanent, unconditional celibacy and sense restraint is a sufficient condition for freedom from the hindrances. Without that, you remain settled in the infinitely more comfortable status quo of *some* sensuality compared to none at all, so the mind has no incentive to go past that—to internalize the danger and abandon sensuality at the fundamental level of the hindrances.

> The explanation then given for the suttas seeming counterexamples would be, as I believe you've said, that the Buddha (and noble disciples) remarkable and singular ability to see the mind of the person they are talking to and navigate it more skillfully than anyone could today.

Yes. Their minds let go far more quickly than usual once confined to permanent non-sensuality because the Buddha was able to directly convey to them the benefit of that total confinement—and the danger of trespassing it—purely through a well-tailored teaching (which obviously would've been much more lengthy and detailed

compared to what you find in the text). But whether the Buddha is teaching you or you are doing the work yourself, the confinement must be the same, and the mind must equally lose its desire to go out of it in order to be ready to understand. How long that takes and how difficult it is—and whether you're even able to get the Right View from one or even numerous conversations; countless people did not—depends on how dependent on sensuality you were.

On the subject of the extent of dependence, one thing I've pointed out in the past but is worth repeating is that none of those accounts actually prove what people who resist celibacy want them to. Whatever sensuality those people engaged in happened either before they even knew the path existed, or after they reaped its fruits and suspended it due to complacency. Thinking one is on the path while still allowing oneself to enjoy sensuality even as a prospect, *despite already hearing about its dangers extensively*, is a very different internal situation that indicates not just a greater dependence on sensuality, but also heedlessness, stubbornness, and lack of faith in the actual teaching.

That essentially sums up the categorical obstacles to growth in the Dhamma listed in MN 16.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-18 05:00:08 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Because it feels clear that a mind - once at least modestly weened off of sensuality and dispelled of a good number of wrong views - is still capable of letting go quickly, of rapidly letting go of intentions and all zeal for sensuality given the right environment.

This is again based on underestimating the hindrances. The attitude "I should be able to do it in X amount of time" automatically implies an end date to the confinement and thus dismantles its unconditionality. Unless returning to sensuality is altogether out of the question, the mind will not let go of it.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-18 19:32:13 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Still, I see it as underestimating the mind's ability to let go very deeply, very rapidly in the right conditions (imo, still wholly possible in the present).

It does seem you're overlooking that even the mildest intentions to return to sensuality at some point very much exist in the present (they can't be anywhere else). On the scale that matters, one's letting go remains superficial as long as those intentions remain.

> Please don't think I mean the superficial, isolated states of calm people can find on most kinds of retreats either.

I wasn't thinking that. That's only the very tip of the iceberg when it comes to underestimating the hindrances.

> I'm speaking to sincere practitioners in compromised life circumstances.

I would also recommend considering how much your hesitation is being influenced by a gut feeling that surely, such people must be able to succeed without abandoning those compromises because the alternative would be too grim.

If you're not emotionally prepared to accept a scenario, distrust whatever reasoning you find to reject it, since the weight of that reasoning will absolutely be inflated in a way that you don't realize.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-19 20:34:56 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> But if your argument is that it's highly improbable that someone in a compromised cannot fully, completely, let go unless their external situation changes - that's fair.

Not quite. My point is that remaining in the compromised situation is a choice the person makes with full volition—that it is hard not to make it cannot remove that fact—and that choice it itself attachment. No letting go within that choice can override its significance, namely that one continues to perceive a charcoal pit as other than that (it's the only way to accept staying in it).

It's not that one needs to take on permanent celibacy all at once or there is no hope. One can certainly build it up gradually, which was the point of that video we discussed earlier. But you need to be aware that making the compromise *is* being under the hindrances, and so you're practicing to make your mind strong and confident enough to *actually stop making the compromise.* Only then is stream-entry possible, but the efforts one makes within the compromise obviously still count.

> Instead, it comes across to me like an ad hominem argument.

An ad hominem is not automatically invalid in a Dhamma discussion. The Dhamma is to be realized (and craving/suffering overcome) in relation to one's personal situation, not in abstraction.

So if anything, failing to address the listener's personal circumstances makes any exchange less accurate and less likely to land deep enough, and I should've brought up that angle from the beginning.

> Though secondly, this is something I've seen here and I feel is not really a fair way to engage with someone because it's unfalsifiable

It's not unfair because this was never a competition, and the point I made is directly relevant in conveying what I've been trying to convey all along.

> emotionally accepting a scenario is different than pragmatically choosing one on account of the perceived harm you'd cause.

Taking the perception of harm caused to another as sufficient reason to not abandon sensuality is still an emotional decision rooted in one's own attachment, shown by how one wouldn't hesitate nearly as much if the "harmed" person was a complete stranger (and in that less invested scenario, causing displeasure would be more clearly seen as separate from causing harm).

The distortion of perspective is not just in full blown lust and sensual addiction. It's in accepting the charcoal pit for *any* reason.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-20 05:12:54 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Where we ultimately differ comes down to how we interpret the early texts regarding the minimum baseline required for stream-entry versus the higher training. Not by lowering its structural requirements, which as you've said is what you think I'm subtly doing, but by making those internal requirements more externally demanding than I find the early texts to warrant. Namely, from the oft referenced suttas I immediately think of: An 5.179, Mn 73, An 4.55, An 6.44, etc.

As I've noted before, all that these oft referenced examples show is that someone who's already entered the stream (or who hasn't even started the path) won't always be celibate. They cannot prove anything about the path itself.

On the other hand, the Buddha does speak decisively and in structural terms about what is required for insight and progress in the Dhamma (e.g., SN 45.24, MN 36, MN 16, AN 4.5).

> Namely, that complete celibacy, or more generally a total lack of circumstantial compromises in favor of an ideal practice/renunciation environment, isn't an absolute, categorical prerequisite for stream-entry.

We've never said one needs to obtain an "ideal practice/renunciation environment" in order to succeed. All that can be applied to every individual is the celibacy part, due to sexuality being the one thing that must always be sensual. From then on, it's up each individual to honestly question themselves as to the sensual intentions, emotional pressures, and attachments behind whatever they do and choose to maintain within celibacy.

# Distinguishing between samvega and aversion

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: cryptocraft *2026-07-29 03:32:47*

Often renunciation is presented as a sacrifice, but what should one do when they experience craving towards it? For example, what if one feels aversion towards being in the company of others, or the burden of acquiring and maintaining family and material possessions? Though the inclination away from these things seem to be directionally inline with the Dhamma, what if the impulse behind it is aversion towards pressure?

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-31 15:43:20

> what if the impulse behind it is aversion towards pressure?

It will be to some extent. The whole path is based on “aversion” if you define it as simply not wanting something (i.e., suffering).

What you then have to make sure is that avoiding company and acquisitions doesn’t become a goal in itself: that the extent of that avoidance remains fully determined by what you personally need to keep your mind away from to subdue its craving, rather than blindly shunning this or that thing per se.

# Being surrounded by beautiful women

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Representative-Age18 *2026-07-28 08:34:51*

I will start a new degree this fall in a class where 75% are women. I will have to interact with a lot of attractive women on a daily basis. I would guess a lot of people here also live in cities or work in places where they see attractive women every day.

Is this a major hindrance even if one refrains from the pressure to engage in sex, flirt, seek it out, masturbate or act in any way that relieves the pressure?

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-28 14:50:20

> Is this a major hindrance even if one refrains from the pressure to engage in sex, flirt, seek it out, masturbate or act in any way that relieves the pressure?

You can keep the precepts and so on, even avoid speaking to them, but since you’re already not sure to what extent it would be a hindrance, the chance that you will be giving in to the pressure at least mentally—i.e., fall prey to the hindrance—is basically 100% (see the AN quote in that other comment). And for as long as that’s

the case, you can't take for granted that you won't act out in coarser ways when the opportunity arises.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-02 06:34:42 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

It applies universally only to the third precept.

## Can I keep the precepts as a trial for a few months before committing to them for life?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Agreeable_Range_8732 *2026-07-27 18:48:47*

I have committed to the 5 precepts for life, but I'm hesitating committing to celibacy and non-entertainment for life. I know it's the right thing to do, and I've tried to convince myself with tons of HH videos and contemplation, but to no avail. I need to see the benefits first hand. And to do that, I need to progress in the practice, but is there any progression whatsoever without having made the clear intention to keep the 8 precepts forever?

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-28 14:38:54

What's more important than committing for X amount of time is to change your view regarding the precepts: the point is not to figure out why you must keep them, but to confine your mind within them. No matter how clear and confident about your determination you were initially, that will fade once the mind starts feeling the confinement and trying to get out again. You have to be able to withstand even the most convincing feeling of "this is pointless" in order to succeed, because that's how much influence over your perception an untamed mind has.

If that's clear then sure, you can start out with a few months (but still unconditionally) before taking on the precepts for life.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-28 18:29:25 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> It can be helpful to recognize the other side of it, that the "confinement" of renunciation, of keeping the precepts, is in fact a joy, a bliss, a gift, a medicine, for the mind that sees rightly.

That will remain on the level of wishful thinking when the mind is obsessed with getting out of the confinement, and emphasizing it out of a sense that "renunciation

shouldn't be unpleasant" will realistically result in compromising the confinement. The unpleasantness is not something you get to decide; it depends on how wild the mind is.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-28 18:52:47 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Won't my mind get an escape route if I don't intend to keep them forever?

If you're preemptively making plans to break them during the few months then yes, that would be the escape route. So you just don't give the mind any confirmation that you will break the precepts at any point until the period is over (and that keeps fully open the possibility that the confinement will continue beyond that). That's also how the Uposatha should be kept.

> The ideal scenario in my mind was to keep the precepts for a while, and progress enough in the practice for me to want to keep the precepts for life, instead of forcing myself to. I mean, I would still be forcing myself, but having seen enough of the drawbacks of sensuality, have enough sense to naturally not give in. Is that possible?

Not quite. Until the mind is fully tamed you will always be forcing the restraint to some degree, which is why the Dhamma goes "against the grain." What diminishes is how much the mind kicks back at you in response.

But if you commit steadfastly for a long-ish period in the above way then it is very possible that the worst of the mind's rebellions will over by the end of it.

## Where does my responsibility end?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Seekfinderin *2026-07-26 09:56:08*

I am reading the text about authority by Sister Medhini. It stresses how we should be very clear about what we are responsible for and what we aren't responsible for. Like the stoic philosophy basically. But I am very confused about where my responsibility ends and how this whole responsibility thing works in case of mutual influence.

In our everyday life we are influencing others. Sometimes consciously, sometimes unconsciously. E.g. if I am a teacher of children, then I have to influence them. Educate them. I take measures.

Sometimes what I do has the desired effect and leads to e.g. the child learning what I want to teach it or behaving as I would like it to behave. Sometimes my actions may not work out and have the opposite effect, e.g. I raise my voice and try to educate it about a particular behaviour that e.g. is hurtful against others, but instead of it

changing that behaviour it may rebel and show more of it and my intervention simply wasn't successful.

Now, where does my responsibility begin or end here? If I am a parent or a teacher I cannot simply say: Everyone is only responsible for oneself so I shouldn't influence the child in any way as it is responsible for his own actions solely. I have some responsibility here, it seems. Depending (in parts) on what I do, the child behaves in some way. Sometimes contrary to what I wanted. But nonetheless his action or reaction was (in parts) triggered by my action, by my attempt to influence it, so is not the reaction of the child a part of my responsibility?

If I scream at someone and he slaps my face as a reaction to it, then of course he is responsible for hitting me, but am I not ALSO (in parts) responsible for his action, because it happened as a reaction to what I did? If it wouldn't have happened if I didn't scream, how then can it not be within my responsibility?

In case of the child: Due to my influence it may make some decisions that I then regret. If it wouldn't have made those decisions if I had spoken to the child in a different manner or tone or used different words, is it then not clear that it is within my responsibility? And where does it end then?

To me it seems that my responsibility in fact is almost endless. I think that I cannot even fathom the extent of what I may be responsible for in this world. My influence, no matter how small it may be in the grand scheme, may have impact on generations. So I see no end of my responsibility. And I cannot "not" act, not even as a monk in solitude, but certainly not when I e.g. am a parent or a teacher, a husband or a wife or in any other way living in an exchange with others.

So how can I take responsibility, if my responsibility seems so endless, if I cannot control what my actions may cause in others and what they may cause others to do in consequence of it?

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-28 14:19:32

All of the "responsibilities" you refer to are real from a worldly standpoint but irrelevant when it comes to the Dhamma. What you're responsible for in that context is your own suffering, which is due to the craving that you are here and now either fueling or undercutting.

Putting first your failure to meet the worldly responsibilities will distract you from that internal responsibility (which is worth prioritizing because it's precisely due to suffering that you care about everything else).

# Just a couple of questions

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Objective-Work-3133 *2026-07-24 01:49:42*

1. If i am not successfully keeping the precepts, is there any point of abiding in non-activity, or is it wasted effort? The precept i struggle with the most is the fifth. I consume caffeine and vape. Celibacy is difficult but i did go a month.
2. I have back pain. I went three months without being able to sit at all. Is it ok if i am changing my position every 20 minutes or so, when trying to be non-active? Getting up to get a pillow or towel for my back, adjusting the recliner, stretching, switching to lying down, etc.

I would also like to request some clarification for what i actually should be doing when i “sit”. I know i am not supposed to be sensation watching or trying to think of nothing. I am supposed to neither accept nor deny my thoughts rooted in greed, hatred, or distraction. Is acceptance or denial of the thoughts more about the attitude with which i regard them, as opposed to what i do with them when they arise? So, i am sitting. I think about someone who is *making me angry. Then, i recognize the thought, which is itself another thought. Do i go back to thinking about the person making me angry, so that i can patiently endure the anger? Or do i just think about something else, making the patient endurance not so much the endurance of the unwholesome thoughts’ contents and their concomitant feelings, so much as the endurance of the process whereby the unwholesome thoughts repeatedly assault me and i choose to think about something else. But if that is the case, isn’t that denying them? I am saying no to them, which is what denial is. The only thing that makes sense to me so far is what i suggested earlier; acceptance or denial is in the attitude with which i regard the thoughts, not so much what i do with them when they arise. I think the way Ven. Nanamoli phrased it is “not putting out the welcome mat.”

*not literally. i make me angry. or, “anger happens”.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-28 13:48:39

> If i am not successfully keeping the precepts, is there any point of abiding in non-activity, or is it wasted effort?

It is highly inefficient and potentially counterproductive effort. It implies you still have coarser things to deal with, and thus you won’t have the experience of taming your own mind that is required to properly understand what non-activity means.

A lot of people hear the talks on “non-activity” and take it as some kind of “HH-approved sitting practice” that can be done instead of mainstream forms, but you actually need to abandon that whole attitude of wanting something to perform, however subtle, in order to understand what is even meant with “non-activity”. Otherwise you’ll be maintaining precisely the activities that need to be abandoned

because you don't even see them. And you can forget about successfully abandoning the subtle attitude of depending on activity if the coarser attitude of non-virtue is still there.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-30 05:44:36 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

At least caffeine is not sensuality nor a precept violation in itself; the issue might just be the attitude with which you resort to it (and the amount is a byproduct of that).

> whose abandonment is a necessary prerequisite for my being able to reasonably expect any understanding of what even needs to be done as far as non-activity is concerned.

The precepts are just the very beginning. "Non-activity" is quite far ahead of that. It's basically abandoning the hindrances (which, it's worth emphasizing, has nothing to do with sitting motionless).

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-08-01 20:21:30 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

Caffeine cannot make you more inclined towards sensuality; it just puts you in an energetic state of mind which, when the mind is ignorant of the danger in sensuality and is not sufficiently trained in sense restraint, becomes a basis for sensual proliferation. In the same way as being excited leads a dog *that's not trained* to start knocking things over.

Even actual intoxicants like alcohol can't induce defilements. It's just that you lose the perspective necessary to notice and restrain the defilements that were already there. Caffeine still leaves you with plenty of opportunity to do that.

> It seems to me that the main reason I would drink it is because I don't want to endure the unpleasant feeling that's already there.

That's not automatically the case just because lack of energy is unpleasant and caffeine removes it. That logic would make virtually every choice to sleep or eat unwholesome.

If you are resisting the lack of energy on the mental level already (you need to see this first and foremost, independently of any particular action) and the prospect of drinking coffee arises *in that light*, then you would be acting out of resistance by drinking coffee. You then wouldn't do it until the action presents itself to the mind in a different light.

That said, don't worry about resistance to lethargy when the mind is still in a sensual orientation. In fact, drinking coffee at that point might even be beneficial so that

it's harder to confuse training the mind with controlling its moods.

## Questions on entertainment

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: nanassaka *2026-07-23 14:41:04*

According to Bhante Anigha, trying to spend too much time in non-activity can itself become another form of distraction when one is still at the preliminary stage of establishing the precepts. Likewise, even listening to the Dhamma should be regarded as an optional mundane activity, since doing so with the wrong intention can obscure where the real work lies. One might mistakenly think that listening to the Dhamma is itself the practice, when in fact the essential work consists in simply not breaking the precepts at the time

Having some form of activity, while also allowing oneself a reasonable amount of leisure, might actually provide the opportunity to experiment with activities that are not necessarily rooted in wrong intention, rather than pouring one's all in restraining one's mind, which would otherwise be taking them further. Some hobbies are also acceptable for as long as they are done in solitude. My questions are therefore these:

1. Is reading literature necessarily contrary to the entertainment precept? For example, could one read *The Brothers Karamazov* instead of spending time in non-activity, if, at one's present stage, non-activity is actually more likely to become rooted in distraction than the reading itself?
2. Likewise, is watching YouTube videos with the intention of learning new subjects—such as astronomy, biology, or other worthwhile topics—more likely to be contrary to the entertainment precept? If reading Wikipedia articles is not necessarily considered entertainment, would the same apply to watching carefully selected YouTube videos, provided one is mindful of what one is watching and the intention behind it?

One could take these activities as a form of containing one's own mind within a consistent and disciplinized form of activity. Rather than trying to sit in non-activity for 8 hours a day and missing that *thats* where one's wrong intentions are, one could choose an alternatively mundane activity, but to check whether it is rooted in compulsion here and then. *That* would have more chances of revealing one's own intentions and whether they are rooted in a desire to distract oneself or not, rather than trying to deny everything

Likewise, what advice would you have for a student in the summer break who has all the free time in the world? What should I preoccupy my time and efforts with? Should I learn a new hobby? Should I spend more time doing nothing? I have also been trying to not listen to too much instruction so I dont de-value it through over-repetition and over-saturation, but without that I am left without any forms of activity. Is it important that I find something to do that allows me to sketch out

some basic routine or discipline, or not so necessarily? Thank you in advance

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-23 16:56:49

It's true that you shouldn't force yourself to do nothing the whole day, but there's a world of difference between doing things that you have to do or will benefit from doing regardless of any passion—like chores and duties—and the type of activities you listed.

If you don't have any chores to do then pick up something that you don't enjoy but that you know is good for you, and don't lose sight of the mind's attitude towards it in case it starts to develop passion.

## How do we know whether we're uprooting suffering or merely managing it?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: None *2026-07-23 01:05:22*

[removed]

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-23 07:54:22

> Is the liability being uprooted when painful feeling can remain without resistance, appropriation, or the urge to escape? Or could "enduring without reacting" itself become another subtle way of managing the experience?

Prior to attaining the right view, you *will* be conflating those two to some extent. You don't clearly understand feelings as they are yet.

So the "clearest" and only reliable sign is that you became a sotāpanna: you're free from the second arrow whether you practice or not, you're beyond doubt about how that came about and how to develop it further, and by extension, you're incapable of seeing any value in a practice other than that one.

## AN 6.44 directly opposes Bhikku Anigha's claim that "Stream entry requires celibacy"

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Representative-Age18 *2026-07-21 16:09:32*

In this sutta Ven. Ananda is approached by laywoman Migsala.

She is confused because the Buddha has recently declared two individuals once-returners; one of them was celibate and the other was implied to be sexually active, living with his wife. Presented as chaste vs unchaste.

So she ask ven. Ananda how this could be. He goes back to the Buddha for answers.

The Buddha essentially says that you cannot know a person's mind based on superficial actions unless you are the Tathagata.

This sutta strongly proves that you do not have to be celibate to attain a degree of enlightenment.

What my claim is not: That celibacy isn't helpful, it surely is helpful for the path.

What I may claim: That one should be careful with throwing around absolute statements such as "Stream entry is IMPOSSIBLE without celibacy" or "This is absolutely required for this".

The laywoman thought she knew the conditions for enlightenment, and thought she could predict a practicioner's attainment based on their celibacy or non-celibacy. The Buddha quickly corrected her conceit.

The key takeaway and moral of this sutta that the Buddha is trying to convey is that one should not think one knows, and one should have epistemic humility.

Edit: Hey, sorry I meant Sakadagami, not Anagami. My bad. Corrected now.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-22 07:29:14

We've discussed this Sutta many times before and refuted the strawmans presented along with it.

> What my claim is not: That celibacy isn't helpful, it surely is helpful for the path.

What defines the *puthujjana* is not that they utterly abhor celibacy and withdrawal from sensuality. It's that, at minimum, they see it as merely "helpful" rather than *necessarily* part of the path. Not seeing the four noble truths, they deep down feel that some amount of craving can be had and acted out of without automatically hurting themselves.

So that's why, as we've repeatedly clarified, our position is not "you will never get the right view unless your celibacy has been perfect for years" (that *would* be refuted by plenty of Suttas). It's also not "someone with right view will never engage in sensuality." Rather, it's "the path begins with (and remains based on) abandoning sensuality; anything outside of that is not the path." There's a huge gap between those.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-22 13:51:38 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> No I fully agree that sensuality is hurtful

Well, there is no (right) path at all and no deeper realization of that insight unless you *live* that view instead of simply "agreeing" with it—which means taking on celibacy/non-sensuality, AKA right intention. That's why it's not enough to merely "not deny" the usefulness of celibacy.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-23 07:02:52 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

It doesn't matter whether you're actually celibate or not. The mere view that sensuality is not automatically an obstruction to the path is by itself a bigger obstruction than seeing celibacy as indispensable and taking it on, yet stumbling from time to time.

That's because the whole point of the practice (no matter what stage you're in) is to train your mind so that it can't *return* to sensuality and craving, not just to not have it in the moment. If your view sees it as not inherently a problem—for yourself here and now, not just an arms-length "yes, eventually sensuality must be given up to become an *anāgāmi*"— then you're already not trying to abandon it as a possibility. Hence the Buddha rebuked Ariṭṭha so strongly despite the fact that, as a bhikkhu, he was not engaging in sensuality himself.

## About a recent post that has been deleted

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: noobknoob *2026-07-21 11:34:34*

I saw a post here recently in which the OP was presenting the idea that "the HH way" of trying to establish the virtue might be partially flawed. OP was saying something along the lines of "HH has a tendency to subtly/indirectly/maybe unintentionally shame the people who are failing to develop the precepts. Which might ultimately be non-conducive to developing them".

I myself has felt that sometimes and thought that discussion might be useful. Can anyone explain why that post was deleted?

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-22 05:49:19

I must have been deleted either by the OP or by Reddit, not by a mod.

As for the argument itself: it may appear "non-conducive" if one assumes that precept-observance is the end goal—in which case a "gentler" approach might

indeed produce the desired external behavior in more people. But that misses the point. The goal is not the precepts by themselves but precisely to develop shame regarding unwholesome states.

A person who is anchored in that sense of shame will be progressing at some rate even if they keep stumbling in their precepts until the day they die, whereas one whose behavior is utterly pure from day one but does not develop shame is not practicing at all. They'll remain at the level of an infant.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-23 16:48:48 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Would you say that even for a puthujjunna, there's wrong shame and less wrong shame?

Yes, but it's shame about having actually broken the precepts—rather than not meeting some projected standard beyond that—then it's universally right enough and should not be covered up.

> I heard in one of your discussions that the way to distinguish between these two is to see if your conduct improves over time. If it does, then it's the right type of shame.

Yes, but the timeframe will generally be longer than you expect it to be. It could take years, weeks, or days from the point that you start feeling ashamed of misconduct to the point that you finally give it up. And even that will not be a permanent abandonment until non-return, which is why shame remains one of the faculties driving a noble disciple's progress.

> Would you say that the goal is to feel healthy shame in regards to misconduct?

Not quite. Shame is shame, and it's not healthy or unhealthy in itself. The unhealthiness comes from what the person decides to do with the impetus born out of shame (i.e., further unwholesome things like revolving around self-hatred or even abandoning restraint altogether).

> And what are your thoughts on using psychoanalysis insights to help with addictions and to improve overall well-being in general?

It should be seen as a compromise rather than as an aid to the real practice.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-23 16:50:07 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

No, as long as it's still used to commit to restraint in the future.

# AN 8.54 - A layperson can develop liberating wisdom without 8 precepts, according to the buddha? Criticism of HH

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Representative-Age18 *2026-07-20 10:17:22*

In this sutta the Buddha instucts a layperson to develop liberating wisdom without any mention of the 8 precepts or the typical monastic sense restraint formula. I noticed something interesting about this sutta that I'd like to see discussed.

I'll skip to the part where he gives advice on "(...) the four things that lead to the welfare and happiness of a gentleman in this life."

He mentions:

"What four? Accomplishment in faith, ethics, generosity, and wisdom."

Faith: faith in the buddha

Ethics: the five precepts

Generosity: he instructs the layperson in developing acts of geneorsity

Wisdom: "And what is accomplishment in wisdom? It's when a gentleman is wise. He has the wisdom of arising and passing away which is noble, penetrative, and leads to the complete ending of suffering. This is called accomplishment in wisdom."

I'd like to put emphasis on the Wisdom part.

Here the Buddha is telling a layperson to develop wisdom that may cultivate in the complete ending of suffering with ONLY THE FIVE PRECEPTS as the basis.

This seems to undermine the HH position that any attempt at cultivating wisdom is redundant and only a form of management before the mind is fully tamed.

Btw, I'm closer alligned to the HH position than the other schools, and believe sense restraint to be alpha omega, but this sutta does really seem to soften the position that 8 precepts/ celibacy is a hard cutoff for right view.

HH is a breath of fresh air in the Dhamma community, because bypassing is like the foundation of most dhamma nowadays. However, their position can cause a lot of tension in householder follower's hearts, as HH has a very strict 8 precepts cutoff for gaining noble wisdom, making the dhamma essentially impossible to develop for laypeople and all attempts at developing becomes "A managment technique, escape" or similar. This is why I find it important to push back.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-20 14:22:10

> Here the Buddha is telling a layperson to develop wisdom that may cultivate in the complete ending of suffering with ONLY THE FIVE PRECEPTS as the basis.

The discourse doesn't say "wisdom can be developed based on these other three things"; it says "these four things are very beneficial." We know that it *cannot* be saying the former because in other Suttas (MN 16, MN 36) the Buddha says that simply harboring desire for sensuality internally is an obstruction to development in the Dhamma. The Chinese version of MN 41 makes it even more explicit:

> "If one wishes to cut off the three fetters and attain the fruits of stream-entry, once-returning, and non-returning, the unlimited supernormal powers, the divine ear, the knowledge of others' minds, the knowledge of past lives, the knowledge of death and rebirth, and the knowledge of the destruction of the contaminants, they will all obtain them. Why is that? Because of Dharma practice and right practice, **maintaining virtue and being free from desire,** what is wished for will certainly be obtained." —SĀ 1042

Only a person who sees noble wisdom as something other than the abandonment of craving—i.e., who is headed in a completely different trajectory than Nibbāna—would think that engaging with sensuality can coexist with attempts to develop wisdom.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-20 14:53:43 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Why would he teach this layperson 4 things, but only 3 of them are actually relevant to him?

It's not irrelevant to him, because he (and every other householder) *can* develop wisdom if they start striving for the cessation of craving—which begins with the most obvious one, namely sensuality.

> Notice he is telling this layperson in the same breath as he is telling him to keep FIVE precepts, to develop wisdom that is "noble".

Sure. That doesn't mean the Buddha thinks he will be able to do that *with* five precepts.

You can tell someone "get a degree and become an astronaut." Does that imply that the degree is all they need? Of course not, and unless they were seriously deluded about what being an astronaut requires, it would be obvious to them as well.

> But he also does not deny that NOBLE WISDOM IS POSSIBLE for someone who isn't fully seperated from sensuality.

He very much does in the Suttas I cited above.

> Sensuality and wisdom are opposites, but they exist on spectrums.

Yes, and nobody denies this. That's why we advise people who struggle with celibacy to start with the five precepts and build gradually towards the eight. But it's quite something else to say that while having settled on one end of the spectrum, one can nevertheless arrive at the other.

## Repressing anger is inevitable for an ordinary person, in order to not act out.

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Particular-Review-65 *2026-07-20 09:20:59*

I might be wrong. But sometimes when anger gets too strong, it feels almost impossible to just let go. First I might repress it, to keep my precept, then I might channel the anger into more productive activities, albeit worldly ones, like exercising, reading books, or even contemplating anger.
Am I doing it wrong? Please give me advice to deal with anger? Maybe more sense restraint? Stay in seclusin? Manage my environment? Patiently endure? I am a puthujanna, I still don't know how to endure without resisting/repressing it at all.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-20 14:45:05

The fact that anger arises and doesn't go away is not at all "wrong." It's what supposed to happen. By not acting out of that anger that stays nor managing it—which is what any "letting go" that a puthujjana can wrap their head around will be—you will eventually be able to understand it and thus uproot it (by removing the resistance to unpleasant feeling, not the feeling itself).

## Do you need to be free from the 5 hindrances (i.e. get 1st jhana) to become a sotapanna (i.e. get right view)?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: ToLazyToPickName *2026-07-18 09:21:34*

I read some posts on this subreddit (Post #1 & Post #2), but I don't think this was answered clearly. Bhikkhu Anigha seems to say one must be free from the 5 hindrances to get right view in this essay.

But if one needs to be free from the 5 hindrances to get right view, doesn't that mean one must get the 1st jhana to get right view, since the 1st jhana is being free from the 5 hindrances?

It seems like Anigha's answer on Post #2 is saying that one can be free from the hindrances temporarily but still not be in 1st jhana, because 1st jhana would involve being good at abandoning hindrances.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-18 14:45:39

> But if one needs to be free from the 5 hindrances to get right view, doesn't that mean one must get the 1st jhana to get right view, since the 1st jhana is being free from the 5 hindrances?

No, because the first jhāna is one of the things that a mind without hindrances can realize; it's not the freedom from hindrances itself. The first jhāna always comes *after* freedom from hindrances in the Suttas, and sometimes the monk doesn't enter jhāna but other states like the brahmavihāras. But this is often overlooked due to the prevalent misconception that jhāna/samādhi is some sort of absorbed or concentrated state, and that that's what removes the hindrances.

## The sense of self

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Ok_Watercress_4596 *2026-07-12 06:34:08*

I started wondering recently why certain contemplations that are related to the sense of "I am" are never mentioned and I haven't found them in the suttas. The sense of self is a clear and obvious phenomena that often appears in the periphery as well as experientially in the body, covering up the feelings and so any pointer to it reveals suffering yet nobody ever mentions this aspect of the experience as a whole

Contemplations such as: "Who is writing?" "To whom does this issue concern?" "Who is speaking?", "Who am I?", "Who am I then?" and plenty of other questions that pop up to anybody investigating their experience

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-12 16:39:27

Because all those questions are pointless speculations that treat the sense of self as if it's some sort of illusory appearance instead of a pernicious attitude. They are even explicitly called out as *ayoniso manasikāra* in MN 2.

Rather than asking such questions, ask yourself why you suffer when you can't get pleasure or avoid pain. That's where the actual sense of self (i.e., assumption of ownership) is.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-17 06:44:49 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> So as a puthujjana my sense of self experiences pleasure and pain, but if that sense of self diminishes then so does the ability to experience pleasure and pain?

No, what diminishes is your suffering on account of not experiencing pleasure or experiencing pain (the second arrow).

## Questioning my views

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Embarrassed-Box6857 *2026-07-08 14:50:33*

Hi everyone, i have been restrained/ practicing deeply for a while now and have some views and assumptions that i would like to question. I am comfortable spending most of my day enduring craving and contemplating, and now have subtler questions arising. I'm not looking for reassurance or speculation but for corrections wherever I'm wrong. I would especially request those who are very sure about their views to help me out.

All these reflections are based on direct experience in my practice along with some intellectualisation but still mostly experiential. I have also not structured the post much and left it more "raw"- I think when left like this it conveys my views in an honest and undistorted way. Apologies for the length and rambling in advance..

Q1- What exactly is the extent to which one needs to understand dukkha. Is it about dukkhas all pervasiveness? its subtlety? I'm able to tell in most cases whether there is suffering or not, however there are times when suffering is subtle so i question- is this situation actually dukkha? I guess it sounds weird but sometimes i genuinely am not sure if I'm suffering, i assume this is what one needs to clarify?

Q2- Previously I thought that with the deepening of practice I would eventually find craving as an object or a "thing"(no matter how ambiguous or vague ) but then i came across the line from mn 44
-"That assumption is not the same as the five assumption-aggregates. Nor is assumption one thing and the five assumption-aggregates another. It is the desire-and-passion for the five assumption-aggregates that is the assumption there"
and this of course made me realise that craving can never be "found" no matter how vague because it's always in the attitude towards any object. so i guess that's why the Buddha dosent say "understand craving" but abandon it- only dukkha is to be understood. Is that because craving cannot be "understood" like dukkha can? I guess dukkha is the only doorway to the dhamma? Then is the only duty with regards to craving to endure it?

Q3- For a stream enter who has confirmed knowledge that nibbana is the cessation

of bhava(SN 12.68) how does one actually get that knowledge? I see repeatedly how cessation of craving is the cessation of suffering, not to the extent necessary for stream entry yet but, enough that I am quite confident in that recognition and can understand how a stream enterer could develop unshakable faith in that. but as for the cessation of bhava I'm confused? I do see how restraint and endurance has definitely reduced the proliferation of my "existence" so to speak, is this what they mean? How the mind establishes itself in existence or leans towards any direction for refuge/relief?

Q4. What does the convincingness of an experience have to do with craving? I have had times when i subtly crave something (not much pressure) yet it is more believable and the "this matters" significance is high which makes it harder to endure when compared to even some very gross cravings/ pressures which are easier to endure. Why would this be? I guess i could say that even though there is less pressure the fact that it is believable is itself more suffering even if its felt less oppressively? This makes me think craving and suffering are not necessarily 100% proportional or linear in that sense?

Q5. Why does hh translate phassa as pressure? i clearly see that phassa has "significances" (me, mine, good,bad etc) built into the perception itself however none of these significances-no matter how significant- can pressure me in and of themselves unless there is a pressuring feeling. what i mean is when i endure cravings i have experienced the same objects without craving/emotional pull or "pressure " so the whole experience is pressureless. from what i understand the pressure would only come from craving- i guess one could say that even feelings pressure one- but the actual felt emotional signifcance of things one is experienced with craving otherwise things are just things....

Q6. I'm quite confused with whether what i call feelings are actually feelings. i clearly understand(intellectually and sometimes experientially) that feelings are not bodily sensations, yet i can't help but wonder is "this" feeling when it might just be a bodily sensation. How do i improve this recognition? When there is craving i immediately feel unpleasant in my body(unpleasant feeling mixed with body sensation- sometimes positive otherwise painful) and i cant seem to "seperate" feeling or confidently say "yes thats feeling!"... Am i mistaking trying to isolate it?

Q7. Can i ever have unpleasant feeling without craving as a puttujana?
As i understand according to pattisamupada and hhs view no- then how can i ever understand what is suffering and what is not? because if i can never see "ahh this feeling isn't a problem " then how does one truly break through?

I do see -time and time again- that when i am craving and i endure i literally experience craving and suffering cease, but if i always have craving then what i am discerning that is ceasing? Is it just slightly less unpleasant but craving still there? It genuinely feels like that craving and suffering ceases for the time being

Q8. i have also had cravings when i was overall calm, but im confused because the Buddha clearly said one can only feel one feeling at a time. yet im perfectly calm-

but there is craving. what am i misunderstanding?

Q9. I understand the connection between understanding the 4nts and removing doubt, silabataparamasa. but i don't see the connection between the 4nt and sakaya ditthi. Is that because craving maintains sakaya, so in that case the undoing of sakaya would be proportional to the undoing of your craving? Is that why understanding the 4nt removes sakaya ditthi? What is the threshold for that understanding?

Q10. Why is the knowledge of a sottapana "whatever has the nature to arise has the nature to cease" , given more importance than understanding of the 4nts in terms of the standard phrase? Is that just textual bias, or does this line just show the universality of the their recognition?

Q11. How does one practically contemplate the arrow sutta since a puttujana can never experience the first arrow without the second? How does one even recognise either in that case? It seems impossible to me, you only have "this" which is either both arrows or none...

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-09 07:55:22

1. What exactly is the extent to which one needs to understand dukkha.

To the extent that you no longer look past it and expect it to find it where it isn't. For example, if you can't see any suffering but you're not sure if you're actually suffering, that vague uncertainty is already suffering. You need to get used to seeing it on that level without it feeling "insufficient" and needing something coarsee and more particular.

2. so i guess that's why the Buddha dosent say "understand craving" but abandon it- only dukkha is to be understood. Is that because craving cannot be "understood" like dukkha can?

Yes. You can't "understand" craving because craving can only exist in the dark. It can't be there while you're actually seeing it. Hence the whole mass of suffering begins with ignorance, not with craving.

3. For a stream enter who has confirmed knowledge that nibbana is the cessation of bhava(SN 12.68) how does one actually get that knowledge?

By understanding craving and its cessation. Being is the inseparable byproduct of craving, not something that exists on its own. And yes, being is the result of the mind (not you volitionally) assuming certain things as refuge/safety in the broadest sense. That's why you have different types of bhava.

4.

"Convincingness" is a suitable basis for craving to become established, but it's not craving per se (see AN 6.55). Craving is the mind taking the convincingness at face value and not fully seeing it as a bait.

5.

> but the actual felt emotional signifcance of things one is experienced with craving otherwise things are just things....

Not really. See the above.

Also, what you're describing as a "pressureless" experience is not genuine absence of pressure; it's an absence of pleasant and unpleasant pressure, i.e. neutrality, which is the third kind of *phassa.* That too is pressuring you, just not as coarsely.

6. Yes, trying to "isolate" it is bound to lead you astray, because a feeling will always be more general and undefined compared to things that you can neatly pinpoint with your senses and intellect. So for example, when you find yourself being unsure of what a feeling is and not being able to pinpoint it, how does that *whole experience* feel? That's what the feeling is; not whatever you're expecting to find with your direct attention.

7. You can have *less* craving in regard to an unpleasant feeling as a puthujjana. That's in fact the natural result of keeping the precepts and so on. But that's not going to free you by itself because as I already wrote, ignorance, not craving per se, is the root of the whole thing. So even if your craving factually lessens, you are not free for as long as your understanding overlooks the true extent of craving.

8. You might be misjudging what calm is by only considering very coarse forms of agitation. But even if you were factually calm, craving is still going to be there because as I said, neutrality too is a kind of pressure, and the ignorant mind is going to be dragged into craving by that pressure too.

9. *Sakkāyadiṭṭhi* is the byproduct of not understanding suffering and craving. By not seeing the extent of their own feelings and their mental attitudes in regard to those (i.e., craving), they automatically assume (inadvertently obviously) some part their experience as a whole to be independent of both of those things. And that's where they assume a self, no matter how strong their conviction is that there isn't one.

That's why one should think in terms of "I inadvertently assume a self for as long as I'm not a sotāpanna" rather than "there is no self because the Buddha said so," as if it was ever a matter of what you believe to be the case.

10. Both descriptions point to the same thing, although the "whatever has the nature of arising . . ." one highlights more directly what the puthujjana's blind spot is. It's not that they have absolutely no concept of what suffering and craving are, but that they don't see the true extent of certain aspects of their experience (their feelings for instance). Thus, they don't see how those aspects

> are actually liable to arise and cease on their own, which means they are automatically "trapped" in acting out of their feelings, dealing with and managing them one way or the other.

11. As the Arrow Sutta describes, the puthujjana is struck by the second arrow due to their ignorance of feelings. So you don't become a sotāpanna by learning to prevent the second arrow as some people believe—which is really just management of the first one—but by understanding the experience of suffering. And you can only do that if, as we often say, you don't automatically try to get rid of *any* of iti—ncluding what you would wrongly take to be the second arrow—in the name of "practice."

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-12 08:03:43 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> According to PS a puttujana is always suffering?

Yes, just to different extents.

> This makes alot of sense. What exactly do you mean by when one is actually seeing it? Do you mean that through repeated restraint/endurance one is already seeing it, or do you mean that it is only fully "seen" at the moment one becomes an ariya?

An ariya is defined by the ability to discern craving correctly. Craving cannot exist while it is discerned (which doesn't mean that an ariya discerns it constantly).

There is no "moment" of becoming an ariya in the sense of a some novel dimension suddenly opening up. Stream-entry means recognizing beyond doubt that you now have the right view, in the same way as you would recognize after a period of training that you have rightly understood something that you didn't understand before.

> How do you not overlook the extent of craving, is it similar to not overlooking suffering?

By not taking for granted your notion of what craving is until you're a sotāpanna. That entire notion is really the issue, not that you see "only a part" of craving's manifestation.

> Im confused with feelings— Can there be multiple feelings at the same time- one general and many particular?

No.

Hunger is not unpleasant if being hungry is giving you something you're very happy about. The sensations of hunger or even damage to the body are not unpleasant in themselves.

> So this is the reason why the more restrained one is the deeper one can understand the Dhamma? Because what one has to understand can only be “visible” after restraining?

Yes, you need to contain your ways of acting out of suffering because those are what perpetuates your non-seeing of that very suffering, let alone its origin, etc.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-07-13 13:35:20 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

Yes, I am aware of that. I now see that there is a reason why the Buddha described it as he did in MN 74. It’s a more precise description because it stays purely at the level where suffering actually is.

## Metta to calm aversion, not get rid of pressure without fully developed virtue

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Representative-Age18 *2026-06-28 11:24:36*

My question is essentially whether it would be wrong to cultivate generosity, kindness and a mind of friendliness if I’m still not yet fully developed in restraint. (Not yet fully celibate). Will it help me towards deepening renunciation and understanding, or will it just be another escape from pressure.

Assuming I’m not doing it when pressured to do so, but with the right intention of calming aversion to pressure, instead of getting rid of pressure thru sensuality.

Btw, I understand metta better as friendly (non illwill) bodily, verbal and mental action, not just repeating phrases in my head.

Should I make it a serious focus of my practice to not only never harm, but also do kind acts to other beings, charity and generosity and train the mind in friendly attitude?

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-06-28 14:22:54

You can practice generosity, but don’t think that you are calming aversion and developing *mettā* if you don’t have the right view yet (even if you were keeping all the precepts perfectly).

In order to cultivate a friendly mind, you need to see your mind first, i.e., have the right view (for which virtue is necessary). If you don’t, whatever friendliness you commit to will be tainted by a mind that wants to get rid of unpleasant pressures (aversion) even if you think that’s not what you’re aiming for.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-06-29 06:57:35 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> So generosity and kindness is pointless before sottapatti and won't help you develop right view?

No, it's not pointless. It can indirectly contribute to right view provided one is doing everything else properly, i.e., virtue, sense restraint, and having enough faith and urgency to be ready to question all of one's views.

> In this video, Ajahn also says that Metta won't take deep roots until the mind is tamed BUT he says that one should still practice metta meditation with an untamed mind

A mind that hasn't been sufficiently tamed by virtue is not the same as a mind that is *bypassing* virtue. It sounds like the latter is what you're going for, and that will inevitably be superficial management of discomfort while actual defilements are left unchecked.

## What flaws do you see in my understanding of practice?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: spiffyhandle *2026-06-26 12:20:47*

Hi practitioners,

I have made several misunderstandings of HH teachings on core topics in the past. I am not talking about finer points like the jhanas or satipatthana. I mean mistakes about what the fundamental practice of virtue is. Instead of going into my history (what I used to think and why it was wrong) what follows is my current understanding. Do you see any flaws in it?

My current goal is keeping the 7 precepts. My next goal will be keeping the 8 precepts, then avoiding unwholesome speech, then not doing unwholesome things that don't break the precepts, then sense restraint, then moderation in eating. At the moment, I'm not too concerned with what sense restraint and moderation in eating are. I just want to develop the foundation of virtue.

I understand my current practice to be, just keep the precepts I've undertaken with a minimum of management. I've taken the precepts in a broad sense; what's given in the suttas are examples to exemplify the essence of them. At this level, if something doesn't break a precept, then I shouldn't bother scrutinizing it.

I understand the next levels of practice to be the same, but with more precepts (7 -> 8, then no unwholesome speech).

Following this, there are no more precepts to undertake. The training is now done at the level of mental intentions. If I detect an *intention* of greed, aversion, or dis-

traction, don't do it. I understand the intention to manifest more as an emotional reaction and not an intellectual justification. Perfecting understanding and restraint of unwholesome intention might be sotapatti and then I won't need further clarification on sense restraint and moderation in eating.

If I did need further clarification, I figure I should wait until I am more developed in virtue and closer to the next step to clarify what to do. I have read Bhante Anigha's essay on sense restraint.

# Questions

Once I can keep the 7 precepts well, should I move to watching intentions? Or should I move to 8 precepts then 8 precepts with no unwholesome speech then watching intentions?

Is focusing all my effort on precepts, the right approach or too narrow?

# Practice

My practice within the 7 precepts is basically focused around celibacy. It's the precept I struggle with the most. I'm not asking for a method or a cookie cutter technique. I'm figuring out for myself what will help me be celibate. Do you see anything that is obviously wrong?

Things I'm doing or have tried or might try:

- Journaling about precepts, sensuality, celibacy, sexuality, and so on.
- Contemplating my faith. What do I have faith in and why?
- Trying to cultivate hiri ottappa, but I'm not really sure how to do this. Figuring it out.
- 5 recollections, and especially death recollection
- Noticing that lack of lust feels good and lust feels bad.
- Thinking about the value of renunciation.
- Trying to see sensuality like burning coals.
- When unagitated and in a safe environment, imagining scenarios that might tempt me to break precepts then contemplating the drawbacks and why I should still keep the precepts.
- Management techniques
- Trying to do the basics of anapanasati rightly so I endure more. When done wrongly, it seems like a management technique which is still better than breaking precepts.
- Reflecting on Dhamma talks, essays, suttas, etc.

EDIT: Maybe it would be helpful to share my history of major misunderstandings.

1. Years ago, I thought I should just sit in a chair and not do anything for hours a day because anything I did would be out of craving.
2. Thought I should keep the precepts, but also never do anything that had an unwholesome state behind. Virtue wiki explicitly says this is wrong. So I was keeping my practice tighter than it should be.

3. Today - ???

EDIT 2: **My main concern is having the appropriate sub-goals and goals.** If that is off, then practice is wrongly directed.

The things I've tried, are just my attempts at what might help with the sub-goal of keeping the precepts. I don't know what works, but you can probably infer a rationale behind them.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-06-28 14:13:13

It seems like you think you need a strategy that diminishes the challenge of keeping the precepts in order to reliably keep them. That attitude is going to make your virtue conditional (and thus not a proper container for training the mind).

It's not inherently wrong to make some effort to diminish the difficulty, such as changing your environment to reduce overwhelming temptations (though as we've said before, management techniques distract you too much from where the actual work happens in order to be useful). But in the end, you will keep falling off the wagon unless you are ready to not give in even when it's most challenging, because the strong pressure to act out will always return eventually.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-06-30 07:46:39 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Basically, **I am trying to find the reasons that will cause me to always choose celibacy and to not forget those reasons.**

Sure, developing that clarity is part of the picture. But my point is that the "bedrock" is not that clarity, but rather the resolve that you will not act out even when you completely forget those reasons (which will happen no matter how hard you try to prevent it, because the strength and clarity of the context will not be permanent).

## Seemingly contradicting statements by Ajahn Nyanamoli and Bhikku Anigha on meditation (as far as I can tell)

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Agreeable_Range_8732 *2026-06-21 17:29:17*

**From Bhikku Anigha**:

"Under that Buddha's own definition, meditation (bhāvanā), be it Anapanasati or anything else is the cultivation of the 7 enlightenment factors, and these exist only for a stream-enterer.

So in the end, the problem is not ***what*** a person is practicing per se. The point is not that if you do AN's "method" instead, you will be practicing properly. If only it were that easy.

Meditation is the further development of the cessation of suffering that person has already understood. Thus, if they don't see the cessation of suffering, it follows that whatever meditation they're doing will be about something else (managing*,* running away from suffering, or getting a separate pleasure to cancel it out). Whether or not they regard it to be in line with the Four Noble Truths or not is not a valid criterion, because the point is that they haven't seen those truths yet to begin with. In fact, an attempt to cultivate the 7 enlightenment factors when one still hasn't understood what enlightenment entails taking one's current idea of what enlightenment and suffering are for granted."

**From Ajahn**:

"If a person wants to do his meditation in a "formal" manner,

such as sit for an hour a few times a day, that is fine. As long as it

is not done for the purpose of developing some sort of "experience of

absorption" out of it. Like trying to watch one's breath hoping for

some novelty energy release or pleasures. The point of meditation

is to remain aware as much as possible. Aware or mindful of whatever

is already there enduring (feeling, perception, intentions). Not

interfere with it, or deny it, or try to replace it. Just discerning the

enduring presence of the arisen experience. Emotionally, perceptually

and intentionally. That kind of composure can then be "spread

out" over one's entire day, even when a person is not sitting down

to meditate. "

The book I got Ajahn's quote from is Dhamma Within Reach, which was what was recommended to me by Sister Medhini when I first discovered HH and was starting out. So, I assume that this book is applicable to beginners as well. So, why does it have any mention of meditation at all if it is aimed at beginners?

Bhikku Anigha claims that meditation is for sottapannas and above, that if we were to try to meditate, try to cultivate the 7 enlightenment factors (one of them being mindfulness, the practice of which is clearly explained in the excerpt I gave), that it would not work. If I'm not mistaken, he mentions in another post that this would lead to Wrong Liberation.

So, if Ajahn's book is not only for sotapannas, why is meditation mentioned at all if HH doesn't want us to practice it at this stage? And if that part is solely mentioned

for sotapannas only, and puthujannas need to ignore that part and follow the rest of the book, then the book should mention that.

Why did Sister Medhini even recommend me a book that may be to advanced for me?

Here is another quote from Ajahn, where he mentions in the same book that is, mind you, **for beginners**:

"One needs to find that kind of

composure that one can maintain in different circumstances. The

way to do this is by establishing the general mindfulness. Not the

particular observation and adherence to the prescribed steps of a

"meditation" technique, that results in one being absorbed in it. But

the opposite: awareness of one's general situation as a whole (e.g.

an enduring mood, state of mind, persisting feeling etc.). Common

practice of "absorption" can then be seen as the complete opposite

of this type of general mindfulness."

While Bhikku Anigha says, "Under that Buddha's own definition, meditation (bhāvanā), be it Anapanasati or anything else is the cultivation of the 7 enlightenment factors, and these exist only for a stream-enterer."

Mindfulness or awareness is one of the seven enlightenment factors, and he says they are only for a stream-enterer, while Ajahn tells us to establish general mindfulness, in as soon as the 3rd chapter of a beginner's book.

Another comment by Bhikku Anigha: "Any type of meditation that promises itself to be right while one is a puthujjana is intrinsically wrong, whether it's noting, watching your breath, loving-kindness mantras, or even **"choiceless awareness"/"open awareness"**, simply because it won't push you to become aware of your intentions, which is where craving, the defilements, and everything you actually need to understand lies. Your mind is still subject to greed, aversion, and delusion not because you don't spend enough time"noting" or because the noting hasn't given rise to some special fruition experience, but because you don't sufficiently recognize the degree to which your own intentions, including the intention to practice noting, as well as anything else you do, say, or think, is affected with those defilements."

So Bhikku Anigha denies that any kind of "meditation technique" works, even if it's something like some sort of awareness practice, or trying to be aware of your intentions when sitting in solitude.

While u/kyklon_anarchon says this for open awareness: "in the way i see it, open awareness properly understood [and carried through as both an on cushion and off cushion attitude] is the functional equivalent of guarding the sense doors. [only two

monastics that i ve read explicitly see it in these terms though – Bhikkhu Analayo and Bhikkhu Aggacitta, who, incidentally, is a student of Sayadaw U Tejaniya, and has talks about this on youtube – examining how what he considers open awareness is the sense restraint in the gradual training].

[so, what you are doing both in open awareness if you don t mystify it and in guarding your sense doors is that] you notice you dwell on something with lust or aversion in the background, and you unhook yourself from dwelling on that object / topic through explicitly including / recognizing *something else* that is co-present. one question that both Ajahn Nyanamoli and Joan Tollifson use to this effect is "what else is there?" – and the question leads the mind in the direction of *finding something else, co-present*. for me, the main "thing" that is there regardless of what else is there – and acts as a condition of possibility for *anything else* being there – is the body. in becoming aware of the body as present – which is not the same thing as "feeling the body", but also *does not exclude* feeling the body, one becomes unhooked from that which was absorbing, and can dwell in a way that is aware of the basic situation one is in, which includes the body *and everything else correlated with its presence*. one can use any satipatthana as this kind of place to return. it seems to me that, in his own practice, judging by old videos, Ajahn Nyanamoli was prioritizing vedana; at other points – kaya."

Everyone seems to be contradicting each other, as far as I can tell.

And I personally don't really see what's wrong with trying to set up peripheral awareness or mindfulness when I sit in solitude. How can that be unbeneficial or unwholesome? Seems like the fastest way to progress to me, since mindfulness is the endgame.

If I am missing something, I'm happy to be corrected. I want to reconcile everything here, I am very confused. I also apologize for the very messy format, the questions are all over the place.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-06-22 05:18:58

> How can that be unbeneficial or unwholesome?

Not seeing how it could be unwholesome is what will make it unwholesome. It means you will be assuming a certain practice (whatever that is) to be correct because of *what* it is, independently of whether you're doing it out of longing, aversion, restlessness, etc. And that's precisely why a puthujjana cannot simply dedicate themselves to "practicing mindfulness." The definition of being a puthujjana is not clearly seeing those unwholesome states in their own mind, which means their attempts to purify their mind are guaranteed to be informed by tradition, hearsay, reasoning, etc., rather than on the actual decrease of their defilements.

That doesn't mean that a puthujjana is automatically doing something wrong if they try to develop wholesome states (unless they are doing so on the basis of incom-

plete precepts and sense restraint). But if they are ever to cease to be a puthujjana, that effort should be centered on understanding what wholesome states are in the first place, not developing whatever impression of wholesome states they currently have (which, again, will inevitably be based on external standpoints). That automatically rules out every single "method" you could ever come across, including anything you could try to extract from HH teachings.

So there isn't a contradiction in the different statements you quoted; you will even find plenty of instances AN saying similar things as what I wrote, and vice versa. That's because both angles need to be incorporated simultaneously: "I don't see what the right effort is, but I will inevitably be making some sort of effort. Thus, within that effort, let me try and understand what makes certain efforts right and others wrong."

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-06-23 14:17:15 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> My primary intention of even doing this practice is to simply be aware of unwholesome intentions in my mind, so that I can be rid of them. Ajahn even mentions in the same excerpt I gave, that you can carry this practice off the cushion as well, spreading it out over your entire day.

That's fine in principle. The point to remember is that not having the ability to discern unwholesome intentions is why you're not a *sotāpanna*. Then you won't be assuming that you found the way to "abandon unwholesome intentions," and you will be more focused on learning what that actually means than on doing what you think it means (some extent of the latter is inevitable, but the priority remains on the former).

As I already said, you will have to be doing *something* in the name of practice, and whatever it is (including complete abstinence from practice) will be tainted with ignorance until you're a *sotāpanna*. The hindrance is not to merely *be* in the wrong, but rather to not acknowledge the initial wrongness (which is the same attitude that would stop you from gaining true expertise in anything, not just the Dhamma).

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-06-24 05:23:47 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> So always intending to upgrade to a superior version of the practice. Is this right, or have I misunderstood?

In essence, yes. But there needs to be a sense of genuine urgency and doubt behind that, through seeing how you continue to be liable to suffering one way or the other, despite your best attempts to overcome that liability. Not just an arms-length intention for improvement that virtually every practitioner has while ultimately continuing to take their core views for granted.

# How to Interpret the Vinaya

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Formal_Breath_2026 *2026-06-15 04:44:52*

This question is mostly directed towards u/Sister_Medhini and u/Bhikkhu_Anigha since they are the ones most qualified to answer it. I am unsure how exactly to work with the conflict between what I see as three overlapping categories: the Vinaya, the traditional interpretation of the Vinaya, and the practice itself. I'll give a few examples. Pācittiya 35 states that once a bhikkhu has turned down an offer of more food, he cannot then go and eat more food. The background story to this rule makes it clear that it is mostly about having concluded a meal with one donor, and then going and taking food from another donor anyway. However, the Commentary (which my tradition follows) interprets this as meaning that, having refused any offer of food during a meal, one cannot accept any more food and must finish their portion without even leaving their seat. Obviously this interpretation is silly; I should be able to turn down one kind of food and accept another kind during a meal, or be able to get up. It even leads monks to frustration in trying to somehow signal to people that they don't want the food they're being offered without formally refusing it so they can continue to take food. Nevertheless, at least this example is fairly simple to work around — if I followed the Commentary here, it would be just so I don't get told off by my tradition, but I would know that if I didn't follow the Commentary, I wouldn't be doing anything wrong per se. It does show that you have to double check everything you hear people say about the Vinaya, though.

My problem is that, despite the fact that the Commentarial interpretations of the Vinaya are often overtly ridiculous, that doesn't change the fact that even an 'EBT interpretation' of the Vinaya still has to be an interpretation. For example, Ven. Ṭhānissaro's BMC states:

> [...] in the West we are left with a somewhat zigzag line separating what are and are not staple foods for the purposes of the rules: Meal pounded from grain is a staple; flour ground from grain is not. Bread made with oat meal, corn meal, wheat germ, etc., would thus be a staple; bread made without any grain meal or eggs would not. The same holds true for pastries, noodles, and pasta.

I feel like someone who is faithful to the spirit of the Vinaya could reasonably either try to preserve the original definition of a staple food here, or rather re-define it such that it includes anything that would be a staple food in the West. But by what criteria should one make such a decision? My problem is that many of the rules in the Vinaya are not relevant to the actual practice of training the mind, and therefore that an attempt to adequately interpret every rule in the Vinaya becomes more of a scholarly endeavour than a practical one. As we know, the Buddha himself said the minor rules could be abolished. We also don't know for certain that the Vibhaṅga is accurate in preserving the original purpose of a rule. Additionally, the interpre-

tation of the specifics of the Vinaya differs within Theravāda Buddhism so much that one cannot even claim that interpreting these rules is important for social harmony either. By following that criteria, one would instead often have to go along with the Commentarial interpretation followed by one's monastery (as indeed I do, in order to avoid any criticism). If EBT monastics were to start ignoring the traditional rule of having food placed directly in their hands, it would most likely cause more disruption than it's worth, for example.

So if many of these rules are basically historical fossils, and they are not directly relevant to the practice (as is hinted at in the Suttas and the Vinaya itself many times), how should Westerners who are concerned about authenticity interpret them? For example, it is not uncommon for me to be offered small things like garlic, berries, chocolate, etc. in the evening. My guess would be that by a strictly academic reading of the Vinaya, these would not be allowable. But why would I go through the social awkwardness of turning these offers down and risking a discussion about the Vinaya if I know it isn't even unwholesome for me to accept it? Trying to draw strict lines here creates many silly results, such as debating at what point milk turns into buttermilk, or not being allowed by your monastery to drink milk in the afternoon but still being allowed to eat some solid foods. I feel like even a faithful EBT reading of the Vinaya could fall into the same trap of ridiculous legalism that the Commentaries fell into many times. It feels to me like dealing with these boundaries is more unrelated to the actual intentions present in one's mind than practicing with the boundaries of the 8 precepts as a householder. Obviously I would take the 10 precepts as fundamental to the life of a monastic (if vikāla bhojana is defined as not eating a proper meal after noon, in order to avoid all the nitpicking I mentioned before), but I am unsure how to deal with the minor rules. Thank you!

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-06-16 18:28:30

> My problem is that many of the rules in the Vinaya are not relevant to the actual practice of training the mind

True, but the fact is that you will often be more inconvenienced by dismissing them than by simply keeping them, as even in the West you will still often be perceived in a bad light by those with EBT knowledge if you dismiss even minor rules. And those rules certainly don't *interfere* with the training of the mind either.

So you end up in basically the same situation as the elders in the same council: the Buddha did say the minor rules could be dismissed, but trying to implement that allowance will just create unnecessary criticism from laity and arguments within the Sangha.

That also means that it's not terribly relevant for you as an individual whether a certain rule or custom is "EBT-based," or developed through commentaries or Asian culture. Back then they had to do things to cater to people's arbitrary expectations. Nowadays it's the same, just that the ones holding the expectations happen to be

Buddhist.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-06-17 18:34:02 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> But does that mean that when I am offered small pieces of food in the evening like chocolate or garlic, or the five tonics even when I'm not sick — things that I know would probably not be acceptable under the original framework of the Vinaya but are for some reason considered so by my tradition now — it is okay to accept them for the sake of non-conflict?

If greed is the motivation (i.e., the arisen state of your mind at the time, not a theoretical inference) then you shouldn't accept the tonics even if they are fully allowable. As long as you never compromise on that, everything else is secondary. And you will be distracted from that criterion if you put the technicalities first and think that you are "more pure" simply by following "the original framework" (which is an easy trap to fall into).

## Venerable Anigha and Venerable Medhini please have pity on me ()

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: None *2026-05-26 17:56:59*

[removed]

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-28 17:36:46

> In my doubt, last night, I decided to see what it would feel like to have that pressure endure. So I thought up some lustful images, and started masturbating to the point where I was close to ejaculation, and I had to absorb myself in the fantasies to keep going. I stopped and observed what would happen in my mind. There was an urge to keep going, and as soon as I stopped willfully ignoring it, it stopped pressuring me. I went to bed without trouble.

Enduring the pressure on the right level means not thinking up the lustful images to begin with, let alone masturbating. Whatever change of course happens after those choices is really just containing the defeat, not victory.

So it sounds like you just have to take the precepts and celibacy more seriously. From where you are standing, that will undoubtedly lead to covering up/suppressing things less, and there is no point in worrying about subtler cover ups until that's sorted.

# Is treating gender dysphoria through medical intervention acting out of craving?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Emergency_Win_3698 *2026-05-26 15:33:38*

Side note: I'm making another post specifically for this question because the last one was supposed to be about monastic options for a person that stays on HRT and gets some surgeries to address their body dysphoria, and it sort of went off track. I have also discussed this question with others (including privately) and I don't feel that a consensus was ever reached. I would appreciate any insight into this issue.

Description of my situation: I experience intense dread when I imagine indefinitely ceasing the medications I currently take that suppress my androgen levels (and raise estradiol) in order to prevent further masculinization from occurring. I also experience dread when I imagine indefinitely foregoing surgeries and trying to accept my body as it is.

On top of that dread, there is a baseline of wrongness/unpleasantness, escalating sometimes to a considerable level of distress (though it is not a constant) that is amplified when I focus on a given feature that is male/masculine. But it is always palpable as a baseline unpleasant quality of experience that is present the second I wake up. This is worse for secondary sex characteristics like bone and cartilage development, increased upper body musculature, balding, facial and body hair (rather than genitalia for which my aversion tends to be comparatively weaker). Social situations tend to amplify this issue by increasing hypervigilant attention to a cluster of traits (e.g., shoulder width, height, face, skull, hands, feet, etc.), usually resulting in more intense distress than when I am alone, though it depends on the circumstances.

Detransitioning *feels* like it would be self-mortification because of the distress that I expect it would result in. But I also acknowledge that the fact I feel so much dread and aversion toward this issue is potentially evidence that I am incredibly attached–perhaps more so than to anything else. Why, for example, do I even take the HRT? I do so because I feel a lot of anxiety and dread around masculinizing any more. So, there is clearly aversion toward that present.

Also, no matter how I justify it to myself, medically transitioning feels like a diversion/distraction from the path and from nibbana, as I am essentially trying to make the body be the way I want it to be and hold the belief that I cannot achieve peace (or even successfully practice) otherwise. I realize that I had the belief that I "just need to fix this" and *then* I can take the practice off the backburner and dedicate my life to fully uprooting suffering. But that's not really logical, is it?

At present I am working a job in order to cover the surgeries I would need to make a dent in my dysphoria. So, the stakes are genuinely high and deciding to call the whole thing off would be a huge decision for which I would need substantial justi-

fication.

Questions I have (apart from post title):

1. Do you think that going through with surgeries and such to modify the body will permanently increase attachment to it in the long run and/or obstruct the right view?
2. If medical transition is a poor idea because of the above, what should I do instead (keeping in mind that this isn't an identity issue of "I feel like [preferred gender]." It manifests as often intense distress that has in the past compelled me to desire death)?

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-26 20:06:15

There is no doubt that these interventions constitute acting out of craving (and the intense dread you experience at the prospect of stopping them only proves it further). Pursuing them is reinforcing the deep-seated assumption that the escape from suffering lies in changing the circumstances.

The thing is that, going by what you describe, it's likely not realistic to stop it all at once. It may be too much pressure for you to withstand at this point, and you may well end up in a worse position in the aftermath of quitting too rapidly.

The more realistic course of action is to gradually cut back on the interventions, while also starting to challenge all the emotional attitudes driving you to them rather than taking them for granted and justifying them.

The fact that there could be a minimum degree of treatment necessary to prevent yourself from falling apart—at this time, due to insufficient training of the mind—doesn't mean that you have to accept other measures that build on top of that. And it is almost certain that you are currently doing more than that bare minimum.

By going closer to that minimum, the aversion will come up in a more manageable degree, and that will create some basis for training and going against the grain. Up until you can finally abandon the whole thing when the aversion in regard to *that* isn't strong enough to completely overwhelm you as it might now.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-27 14:51:37 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Why is that diagnostic? Are you saying that the severity of the condition is what justifies withdrawing the treatment?

The severity of suffering shows the extent of craving (that's how it works across the board).

> Couldn't this charge be leveled at any form of medicine that is treating a condition that causes suffering?

Not in the same way. The crucial difference is that most conditions can exist independently of craving and suffering, whereas gender dysphoria cannot. That means that treating it externally can never be a neutral choice from a Dhamma perspective.

> Is there any way that I could continue to intervene without acting out of it/fueling the craving, like how one could take pain medication with a mind of craving without the intention being itself rooted in craving?

Therefore, no.

But just to repeat, this doesn't mean that you must stop the interventions overnight if that has a high risk of overwhelming you. The point is to start valuing and moving in the opposite direction, not to immediately arrive at its end.

> I'm not sure how exactly to go about doing this.

Reflecting on the condition as objectively as you can until you see with more certainty that it is directly tied to unwholesome states of mind, and is not something you can simply accept and try to develop wholesome states on top of. Essentially, getting to the point where intellectually at least, you see that abandoning the treatments is what is in your ultimate welfare.

Then, weaning off the treatments will still be unpleasant and doubts about the decision might still arise from time to time, but you will have grounds for sticking to it regardless.

> I am looking into getting some surgeries, which would likely put a dent in it (but not get rid of all the aversion either per se, as some things cannot be easily fixed or at all).

That could be a way of going beyond the bare minimum. It's definitely going beyond what you currently have, which will only make reversing direction more difficult.

> But I would say that it's not very manageable right now because I am in constant pain and discomfort over it and it causes significant dysfunction.

What I mean with "manageable" can still be quite unpleasant. If you can sustain it without having a mental breakdown then it's manageable.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-28 04:52:15 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> What makes gender dysphoria special in this regard?

The fact that the condition itself (rather than a consequence of it) is called "dysphoria"—meaning unease/dissatisfaction/unhappiness—highlights what makes it different.

> but could not there be a baseline of pre-cognitive disagreeableness (like the disturbance of the six sense bases) or a kind of perceptual mismatch that would persist even in an arahant with it?

No, because such disagreeableness would require the mind still having concern for the body.

> So, it seems like the only reason it is manageable at present is the fact that I am working toward surgeries, and ceasing those efforts would therefore increase the likelihood of having a mental breakdown and of the suicidal thoughts returning full force.

That's possible. But you have to realize that no amount of displeasure produces those reactions by itself. In other words, you have to take full responsibility for them.

See how that goes before deciding to go for the surgeries.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-28 17:43:49 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

You cease to see yourself as a victim in despair and renounce the bittersweet gratification that comes from that attitude (which is the direction every mind tends to go whenever something is highly unpleasant). You maintain the context that despairing is a choice, and that it only worsens the displeasure.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-29 04:09:45 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Are you saying that arahants don't feel any sense of disagreability?

No. A dislike for the given body's male/female features and a desire for the opposite is not just a neutral and unavoidable disagreeability on the level of hunger or physical illness. It's a symptom of mental affinity towards the body, similar to what this Sutta describes.

## Question on the nature of HH's critique of other traditions

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: account-7 *2026-05-21 16:26:43*

Hello! Just a brief question to understand what the Hillside Hermitage stance is on this. I have heard - most of which I agree with - many thoughtful and useful critiques on almost every other tradition's pedagogy and presentation of the Dhamma.

However, I want to better understand the scope of this critique as I, potentially intentionally, haven't heard a direct answer in all I've seen the past couple years here. Though I think it would be useful to hear if offered.

I will not name names as to put anyone answering in the awkward (and probably useless/impossible) position of naming specific individuals who do or do not teach the Dhamma, but is the HH position that alternative frameworks are structurally incapable of producing liberation because they operate on a fundamental misconception? Such as prominent Thai Forest teachers, Chan/Zen, or veering a bit into perennialism but even non-Buddhist contemplative traditions like Advaita? And in this case, would their "attainments" just be chalked up to maintaining refined states of samadhi?

Or is it more just a generalized concern for the preservation of the dhamma in its most efficient, canonically accurate form. Dismissing not the potential validity of those paths to lead to fruitions, but their efficacy and the massive traps/potential pitfalls that is seen as mitigated within HH instructions; while leaving room for the possibility that individuals could make their way into right view despite a flawed framework?

Thank you for your time!

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-22 04:34:40

> HH position that alternative frameworks are structurally incapable of producing liberation because they operate on a fundamental misconception?

Yes, it's a structural issue whereby those frameworks cannot lead to *anything but* pitfalls. Becoming accomplished in them puts one in a worse position than one started in (see below).

A less ideal or efficient framework leading the same goal would not warrant dismissal.

> And in this case, would their "attainments" just be chalked up to maintaining refined states of samadhi?

Wrong samādhi, wrong knowledge, and wrong liberation. In simple terms that means: not experiencing (perceptible) dukkha because the circumstances that trigger it have been altered, not because craving in regard to all possible circumstances has diminished. And that is what delusion, the most insidious of the three defilements, boils down to.

Of course, this need not be the stated mechanism of operation of a certain practice in order to be the actual mechanism. That mechanism can be embedded in an endless array of different narratives and descriptions.

# Request: sequential series for beginners?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: tejveeer *2026-05-15 02:33:15*

I have been in conversation with an old friend for some time about the dhamma - at least my understanding of it.

I had spent some time uncovering some views he had tacitly due to the scientific culture we were bought up in. Since they were challenged, he seems more open to consider the possibility of future birth, the weight of which he seems to be realizing to some degree now.

Because of this he showed some interest in HH's teachings, except I had nowhere I could point for starters. The slovenian videos? The sri lankan videos?

Unfortunately, HH's teachings now, even though they seem more targetted towards beginners, feel even more difficult to enter than they were before. It feels almost as if someone needs the context accumulated across all 500 videos and years of trying to make sense of the suttas and their pali to really begin making any sense of the new videos.

I think this is because of the following reasons:

1. The format of the videos. They are conversations between the venerables themselves, in which there is a questioner and answerer. The questioner assumes the place of an abstract viewer, rather than actual live viewers.
2. The content of the videos. The content is often a part of the whole of HH's teachings, where how that part fits into the whole is only sometimes mentioned, or when it is, it is overriden by the multiplicity of topics covered.
3. The lack of hierarchy in the videos. The videos seem like a bunch of topics concatenated together: A B C D E F ..., which is natural since IRL conversations flow without hierarchy; as new questions come up, the topics change. But this is extremely costly on the viewers because, in my estimate, every video has at least 15-20 topics changes. Viewers have to hold context of the discussion, see how it might be related to the multiple changes that previously occurred, process incoming discussions, remember very important bits. The same video may go from talking about sati, to yoniso manasikara, to a sutta, to sense restraint, to avijja, to another sutta, to meditation techniques, etc. This means the very important parts of the video, say topic B, F, H, are lost since the video is so linear.

This may be compared in contrast to a pre-planned video on a subject that has an explicit hierarchy.

Say there is a doctor who is giving an update on the medication plan to their patient over a 20 minute video. They plan that the starting 5 minutes are for introducing the purpose of this new plan; how it fits into the overall plan of recovery. The next 5 are for addressing existing medication. The next 10 are for new medication.

In the new medication, they will have 5 minutes for what the new medication is, why it's needed, and its sides effects. The next 5 for how to use it.

There is a clear hierarchy here. Three top-level topics: context, current medication, new medication. And the 3rd has two sub-topics: Introduction, application.

Compare this to if the doctor made a 1 hour video in conversation with another doctor. They begin by introducing the new medication, then the research paper that supports this, then the research papers that don't support this medication and the issues with them, then the context of the new medication, then some new research papers, then the application of the new medication, then the side effects, then its purpose, etc.

Of course, it is completely up to the venerables on whether this is of any benefit. But I think it would be very beneficial to existing members and to others outside the community willing to learn to have a course-like presentation of the core of the dhamma by HH, that builds from ground up.

The whole of HH's teachings can be divided into positive and negative parts. The positive is concerned with their own views, the negative with addressing views that will obstruct others from understanding/considering HH's positive views.

The positive part is concerned centrally with the HH's aim: to teach for the uprooting not management of suffering. Then this would be split off into two branches that elaborate on this distinction: on management and on uprooting.

In order for newcomers to understand why management is problematic, they must understand how HH understands the actual uprooting of suffering. So it is possible to start off from the uprooting branch and address that as its own topic in a video.

This branch would address what the root of the problem is (craving), what the solution is (removing craving), and how that solution is implemented (i.e., it would introduce the notions of the four noble truths and the five aggregates).

Then it's possible to more easily make sense of what management is (namely, everything that is not addressing the root), and why it's problematic (it doesn't address the root).

Then one could exit the positive branch and address the negative branch. Chiefly, meditation techniques.

The course/series could be divided in 3/4th part to the positive part, and 1/4th to the negative. In the positive, 1/2 is spent on uprooting, 1/2 on management. And the same hierarchical division goes down more and more, and every video would itself be just another hierarchical division.

This would just be one among many ways of presenting HH's central views. But I personally think this would help save much time on both HH's part as well as on the viewers' part due to the clarity it can bring.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-15 14:30:31

I'm sure we will continue to refine our approach to teaching, but the lack of a "course-like structure"—and the lack of hand-holding of the listener in general—is deliberate and will continue to be that way. It's the least we can do for an distant audience to keep them on the side of seeing (or at least trying to see) for themselves the experiential truths that our material is grounded in, rather than being distracted by intellectual connections with ideas they've heard before (including from us).

Giving in to the hunger for neatly presented information that newcomers will naturally have is a misstep rooted in yourself not understanding what the Dhamma is and how it is realized. What that actually achieves is helping people fall into the trap of thinking that they understand what they don't. They start to feel that the teachings "make sense" to them while their life and mental habits continue in the same trajectory as before, and that's a worse position than not having heard the teachings at all.

Merely making our teachings publicly available inevitably allows a number of people to fall into this trap, and we wouldn't want to increase that number.

## "Doing Nothing" Meditation

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: nubuda *2026-05-13 15:55:09*

If you sit or lie down with eyes closed and just rest for long enough, eventually the thoughts begin to slow down and the mind settles on effortless awareness of the body breathing. The clarity of the mind increases significantly if you practice it regularly. I think this is how Buddha experienced jhana when he was still a kid chilling under a tree.

Does Hillside Hermitage support such meditation? In my experience it

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-14 04:21:42

> Does Hillside Hermitage support such meditation?

No. Such practices play no role whatsoever on the path, and we have extensively explained why (as well as what samādhi actually is) in our teachings.

## the right peace before stream entry

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: bodily_heartfulness *2026-05-05 22:55:56*

I sometimes reflect upon the downsides of relationships, the dangers of sexuality, and so on. Sometimes, as a result of these reflections, there will be a sense of *unencumberedness*, a sense of the mind being more free and open, not weighed down by the stickiness, the weight, the insecurities, the desires, of it all.

I have a few questions regarding this.

1. Is this type of peace dangerous? Is it to be cultivated?
2. Is this “cheating”? In that, if this is practiced alongside of restraint, then restraint becomes easier because the mind, on occasions, will have a decreased level of thirst towards sensuality. Does this impact the training, because part of the goal of the precepts and virtue is to train the mind *in regards to* the pressure, not to not have pressure at all.
3. Continuing that train of thought, in general, if certain contemplations reduce the pressure, is that bad?

(Note that this is all pre-stream-entry, when one doesn’t have the right reference.)

My own answer to some of these questions would be:

The purpose of these types of contemplations is to develop the right context, so that one does not act out in body, speech, or mind when one is pressured by sensuality. If these reflections lead to a temporary reduction in the pressure, or some temporary sense of freedom, that is fine, but that is not the point. Trying to decrease the pressure, or even trying to increase the pressure, is besides the point - the goal is not management, but the fundamental change in view, which means putting things in the right order, so that sensuality is first seen as dangerous and *never* worth engaging in.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-07 05:18:35

> Continuing that train of thought, in general, if certain contemplations reduce the pressure, is that bad?

What is bad is to develop an association that restraint ought to be supported by peace, rather than being non-negotiable regardless of how painful it becomes.

That association will obstruct right view even if the peace you’re describing is along the right lines because it means you continue to ignore the true nature of craving (which applies regardless of how you currently feel).

## I have created a free Sutta companion app - To implement Gradual training need review from hh

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: True-Grape2605 *2026-05-05 13:11:26*

Bhante and friends,

I have built a free, offline sutta reading app called Sutta Companion — primarily for laypeople who want to study the Pāli Nikāyas and implement a daily practice based on the gradual training.

The app uses Bhikkhu Sujato's translations from the SuttaCentral database. It is free, ad-free, and fully offline. It is currently live on Android.

I am writing here specifically because I have recently added a practice module built around the gradual training as described in DN 2, MN 27, and MN 53 — from dāna and sīla through indriya saṃvara, sati-sampajañña, the five hindrances, paññā, brahmavihārā, samādhi, and vipassanā. Each stage in the app references the canonical source and uses short passages from Bhikkhu Sujato's translations to describe what is being tracked and why it appears at that point in the sequence.

I am a layperson and a software developer. I am not a monastic, not a scholar, and not trained in Pāli beyond basic reading. I have done my best to represent the gradual training faithfully but I am certain there are gaps, misrepresentations, or errors I am not qualified to catch myself.

Specifically I would welcome review on:

— Whether the sequence I have used (dāna → sīla → akushala kamma-patha → indriya saṃvara → sati-sampajañña → pañca nīvaraṇa → paññā → brahmavihārā → samādhi → vipassanā) accurately reflects the canonical gradual training or introduces distortions, although it is not hardcore sequence we need to follow there since lot of things can works parallel and helping each other parts .

— Whether the descriptions of each stage, which I have tried to draw from the suttas directly rather than from secondary sources, are faithful to the texts

— Whether the framing of samādhi as something that arises naturally from the preceding stages rather than as a technique to be practised is correctly represented — I relied primarily on the stock gradual training formula in DN 2 and the rose-apple tree recollection in MN 36

— Whether anything in the practice module, particularly around the hindrances and vipassanā sections, risks misleading a practitioner or giving the wrong impression of what the practice involves

I have tried to be honest with users about the limits of what an app can track.I have also included a note in the path module saying I am a layperson, that there may be errors, and inviting corrections.

If any of you have the time and inclination to look at this and tell me what is wrong, I would be genuinely grateful. The app is available on the Play Store — I can also share screenshots of the practice module and path descriptions specifically if that is easier.

I built this for my own practice and for laypeople like me who want something grounded in the early texts rather than in modern mindfulness repackaging. If the Dhamma parts are not right, the app does not serve that purpose regardless of how well the software works.

With respect, Kapil

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-07 05:47:04

The app looks great software-wise, although there some issues with the "Practice settings" section:

(1) In the first step of the Gradual Training, the third precept is celibacy, not just abstaining from sensual misconduct.

(2) Pinpointing the specific sense base in the sense restraint section is unnecessary and will likely lead to overthinking.

(3) In the Samādhi section, it shows the suggestion "30 min ānāpanasati, aiming for first jhāna," clearly reflecting the common wrong view that jhāna is an absorbed state that "comes to you" after a certain period of some attentional exercise.

More generally, the act of logging per se—for anything beyond the precepts, which *are* clear-cut— is a strong indicator that a person is approaching the practice as just another technique/mechanical performance, and that means they are certainly not doing any of the right work on the mental level.

## Right Restraint or Wrong Restraint?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: EggplantNumerous8026 *2026-04-30 21:10:34*

I have trouble keeping restraint and not breaking the precepts.
For example i get a lustful/sexual thought, in the moment i comprehend that this thought is dangerous and against the goal/virtue (Dhamma practice), not the thought itself but its implications, its leading me a certain way (pressure), and in the moment even though i know logically that this way is leading to danger and suffering and not ultimate satisfaction. I still get hooked by the prospect of pleasure and relief, which builds up more internal conflict and resistance to the idea of acting out until i completely lose perspective and become an animal/beast and act out.

and when i try to understand where i went wrong after breaking the virtue (HH and SH youtube channels) its many different answers that are correct but i feel they don't solve the problem. Such as you dont understand the danger enough, or

you didn't endure on the right level, or you are not developed in the body, you chose to give in.

ive watched pretty much all the videos of HH and SH and many multiple times even up to 10 times some of them, and i've contemplated the teachings, all this over a time span of multiple years, and it all makes sense to me logically, i believe/have faith it is right. ive been long past the dunning-kruger effect, i know also logically that i dont understand truly what they are talking about because im not a sotapanna.

i feel like ive had more than enough information about how to practice the Dhamma, its just that im not restraint enough. and they say you have to purify bodily and verbal conduct before you can purify or even see the mind and start to purify that (simile of purifying gold). and i get that to a degree, but in my experience its the mind/mental states and the thought that pressure me to seek relief (yes from that greater underlying pain of suffering), so if these things originate at the mind and it presents me with the mental thoughts it want me to act out from (like Ajahn said the mind has a mind of its own) why do i have to stop my bodily behavior, which is way down the line of giving in and acting out of craving, like the mind gets a sensual desire first but i am told that as a puthujhana i cant see my mind thus focus on "impeccable virtue". isnt it just better to stop the craving in its emerging domain first, before it spills out into other domains because yes in a fundamental level you cant handle the pressure or endure on the right level when you have lost your perspective (because i got careless). and somehow i have to balance this with training gradually also, so not doing to much at once? but not too little as well? How to determine what pressure to prioritize to not act out from, when all pressure shouldn't be acted out from? Just how do i get to the actual goal and understand the dhamma? any ideas? In one video on SH bhante Anigha said that "when you want to act out, just dont" (very close to this atleast), and like this is stating the obvious. and its correct but its not that helpfull, is he implaying that we have ultimate control/choice? so a fully addicted drug addict for >10 years or other type of addict can just stop when he decides?
its like yeah its his choice that frees him but that doesnt mean he wont relapse, like at the same time tha wild animal gets compared to a strong animal like a wild bull elephant while we are the weaker animal that has to tame it smart. like we cannot just overpower it by sheer will, or can we? is the ability to consciously choose just a muscle that has to be trained as much a possible, so that when unwholesome desire arises we can stay clear from acting out? if so how to prevent burning out and relapse?

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-03 04:04:45

> why do i have to stop my bodily behavior, which is way down the line of giving in and acting out of craving,

Because intentional bodily actions are the coarsest mental actions you can do.

> so a fully addicted drug addict for >10 years or other type of addict can just stop when he decides?

Yes, because his body simply can't take the drug on its own; he has to mentally choose that.

Each time he takes the drug again, he is deciding that stopping the pains of withdrawal is more important than eventually being free from the addiction. So, he must abstain from making that decision no matter what (which is very straightforward, just not easy in the beginning).

## Storage, items and Monks

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Hard_Tack4 *2026-04-26 17:06:42*

What degree of personal items is allowable or a good idea for someone who is considering becoming a monk? The HH monks seem to have phones, maybe even laptops, cameras, audio equipment, have presumably used tickets, probably have medicines etc. What is reasonable? I have read that the rules about personal possession of even medicine like frankincense is very restricted, you couldn't have 200 grams on your person it seems without breaking a rule. Ofc many monks even use money which is unambiguously bad. What should I get for myself? Can I get a tent and a nice backpack? An e-ink-tablet? A small camera? Some pens? An Mp3/4?

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-27 04:49:50

> I have read that the rules about personal possession of even medicine like frankincense is very restricted, you couldn't have 200 grams on your person it seems without breaking a rule.

There is no such rule in the Vinaya. Every monk is personally responsible for checking his motivations for possessing things.

With certain things, no matter how externally "luxurious", you can harbor no internal desire and not be significantly bothered if they are lost, whereas there can be "modest" and inexpensive things (and living beings as well) that you would passionately protect even though they are not strictly necessary to survive and to practice. That passion, not the things, is the problem, and you will be unable to address that problem if your focus is on the level of what and how much you have.

## How do you practice tranquility?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: nubuda *2026-04-20 09:06:42*

If I understand correctly, Ajahn N. does not consider any kind of relaxing meditation part of dhamma practice. I was listening to one of his dhamma talks and he mentioned that instead of calming meditation, people should instead practice sitting quietly and contemplating certain dhamma topics. This is of course great but it has limitations. There is a sutta (MN19) which clearly explains that there is no danger in skillful thinking but too much of even skillful thinking will tire the body and stress the mind. So how do you practice tranquility according to Hillside Hermitage teachings? My definition of relaxing meditation is very flexible. I believe even sweeping floors or picking berries or laying in bed with resting awareness qualifies as relaxing meditation.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-20 13:48:06

> So how do you practice tranquility according to Hillside Hermitage teachings?

The first, non-negotiable step is giving up sensuality. Whatever a person who hasn't done this can achieve is not tranquility—the absence of craving—but is merely shifting their substantial mass of craving onto something else (e.g., the sensual bliss obtained in a state of absorption, often mistaken for tranquility).

From then onwards, you progress in the Gradual Training up until you reach the level of purifying your mind from the hindrances, which is done by understanding them as mental activities that are harmful, not by any attentional technique or focusing effort whatsoever.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-21 04:56:26 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

The pleasure that comes from what is generally mistaken as samādhi today. Pleasure that comes from engagement with a sense object rather than from withdrawal.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-21 05:15:37 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Just like the sutta I referenced says, too much thinking of dhamma topics can cause stress despite it being skillful thoughts.

It doesn't say that you simply decide to engage in a calming practice out of a view that skillful thoughts are tiresome. You develop the skillful thoughts until those have become the mind's natural inclination and unwholesome thoughts have subsided.

If that's actually completed, you won't need a special practice to calm yourself down. You removed the greatest source of disturbance by undoing the

unwholesome thoughts, and now with the wholesome thoughts, recognizing that the subtle burden they entail is no longer necessary will be enough for the mind to become internally calm (meaning it's preoccupied with neither wholesome nor unwholesome thoughts).

Whereas before that point, you only have two options apart from the wholesome thoughts: the blatant unwholesome thoughts, and distractions such as "relaxing meditation." Both are stressful compared to actual samādhi, where you don't have to do anything at all in order to be calm.

## Question regarding interpretation and application of Pātimokkha rules

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Sa_Mahe_ri *2026-04-10 13:02:08*

Dear Venerables,

I am a sāmaṇerī in training to become a bhikkhunī. I would very much welcome input not only from the monks who have already undertaken higher ordination or are going to in the future, but also from nuns who have not—since I imagine that you have reflected on these questions as well.

I find myself struggling to understand how to relate properly to my future Pātimokkha rules—especially those that are not/ no longer directly connected to unwholesome behavior, and where the interpretation is not clear-cut.

The most obvious rule that is difficult for a modern bhikkhunī is Saṅghādisesa 3:

> If a nun walks to the next inhabited area by herself (Bhante Brahmali) / goes among villages alone (Ajahn Thanissaro), or crosses a river by herself, or spends the night apart by herself, or lags behind her companions by herself, then that nun has committed an immediate offense entailing formal probation and suspension.
> Yā pana bhikkhunī ekā vā gāmantaraṁ gaccheyya, ekā vā nadīpāraṁ gaccheyya, ekā vā rattiṁ vippavaseyya, ekā vā gaṇamhā ohiyeyya, ayampi bhikkhunī paṭhamāpattikaṁ dhammaṁ āpannā nissāraṇīyaṁ saṅghādisesaṁ.

This is especially challenging because it is a serious offense. Interpretations of what exactly is prohibited and what is allowed vary greatly, and when I reflect on how I might interpret this rule for myself (as I have considerable freedom in this regard in my monastery), I cannot come to a clear conclusion.

So I am not necessarily looking for a definitive answer on how to interpret this specific rule (but if you have any thoughts on that, please go ahead). Rather, I would appreciate any guidance on how to approach rules that are not entirely clear or

that allow for multiple interpretations—how one might arrive at a well-grounded decision in such cases.

At the same time, I would also welcome input from those familiar with Pāli regarding which translation is more accurate. One version seems to suggest that I could still spend the day in seclusion in the forest, as long as I am not intending to travel to another village (which would align with suttas depicting bhikkhunīs being alone in the forest). The other interpretation, however, sounds more like one is not allowed to leave one's village by oneself at all.

And regarding precepts that are not necessarily unwholesome in themselves, but are nowadays commonly interpreted in a different way than the literal wording suggests—does one simply go along with such established interpretations, or is there a more principled way to approach them?

> For example:
> Confession 85: traveling in a vehicle (for bhikkhunīs, in contrast to bhikkhus, in the Pātimokkha)
> If a nun who is not ill travels in a vehicle, she commits an offense entailing confession.
>
> According to Ajahn Thanissaro:
> "In modern times, 'ill' is interpreted here as meaning too weak to reach one's destination on foot within the available time."

Any further reflections on how to put the Pātimokkha rules into practice are very welcome.

With respectful regards

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-12 13:09:13

> how to approach rules that are not entirely clear or that allow for multiple interpretations—how one might arrive at a well-grounded decision in such cases.

Reading the origin story to see what exactly the rule is meant to prevent, and how it connects either to the restraint of defilements or to avoiding unnecessary trouble and criticism.

Not having that perspective leads to the absurd attitudes you see with certain rules in a lot of monasteries. A common one is obsessing over a few technicalities to (supposedly) avoid an offense while ignoring how the overall nature of the action clearly violates the spirit of a rule and the training in general.

> One version seems to suggest that I could still spend the day in seclusion in the forest, as long as I am not intending to travel to another village

I would read it simply as “going into a village.” The phrasing of the Pāli is by itself somewhat ambiguous, but this reading aligns both with the event in the origin story and the Chinese parallels of that rule.

> And regarding precepts that are not necessarily unwholesome in themselves, but are nowadays commonly interpreted in a different way than the literal wording suggests—does one simply go along with such established interpretations

Yes, as long as the established interpretations are reasonable.

Bhikkhuni Pāc. 85 is clearly one of the rules that was entirely based on cultural perceptions of the time. The takeaway is to not travel in ways that would draw the same criticism of “being like laywomen who enjoy sensual pleasures.”

Ironically, in modern times all the vehicles that under that rule are allowed for an ill bhikkhuni would generally draw worse criticism than just “being indulgent.” That shows how you have to exercise your own judgement in interpreting such rules.

## Clarification of “no high and luxurious beds” precept?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: spiffyhandle *2026-04-08 11:50:42*

Is the 8th precept only about what I deliberately use for sleeping at night and deliberate naps during the day? Or would it also prohibit using comfortable couches and recliners during the day? Would it prohibit laying awake on a high or luxurious bed but NOT sleeping on it?

**I don’t understand the intent of the precept so I can’t gauge its particulars.** I’ve looked at references to sleep in the vinaya and suttas and I’m not discerning a universal principle.

I looked in the virtue wiki and all I saw was

> “If the seven precepts are your default, then on Uposatha days you would up the ante and keep the full eight precepts. This would add not sleeping on a high and comfortable bed and not eating past noon.”

In the talks to lay people the Buddha says you observe the 8 precepts because you’re emulating an arahant.

> As long as they live, the perfected ones give up high and luxurious beds. They sleep in a low place, either a cot or a straw mat. I, too, for this day and night will give up high and luxurious beds. I’ll sleep in a low place, either a cot or a straw mat. I will observe the sabbath by doing as the perfected ones do in this respect.’

The Vinaya, which goes beyond practice and takes into account social norms and maintaining good relationships with lay people, it prohibits having beds that with

legs that are too high and also stuffed benches and couches. The connection between a height of a bed and it's comfort makes no sense to me. If you had a plain bunk bed are you automatically breaking the precept just because it's tall? What does that have to do with dhamma?

https://suttacentral.net/pli-tv-bu-vb-pc87/en/brahmali?lang=en&layout=plain&reference=none&notes=asterisk&highlight=false&script=latin

https://suttacentral.net/pli-tv-bu-vb-pc88/en/brahmali?lang=en&layout=plain&reference=none&notes=asterisk&highlight=false&script=latin

> 'If a monk has a bed or a bench made upholstered with cotton down, it is to be stripped, and he commits an offense entailing confession.' "

So perhaps there is something about not possessing comfortable furniture, in general that is problematic? I am unsure.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-11 05:27:33

It's about not using furniture that is very likely to be misused. Namely, for indulging in the pleasure of lying down and giving in to mental laziness rather than resting the body when needed.

Secondarily, it's about avoiding ostentatiousness, which is another way of losing the context of what a bed/furniture is for.

## Building the foundations

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: baubleballs *2026-04-06 19:07:09*

hello. Stated simply, this is a question about whether seclusion is counterproductive without a strong foundation in virtue.

Looking back, I'm realizing I've neglected virtue during my last several months of lay practice in a secluded environment. I periodically make and lose progress. The daily meal is very brief and the time alone feels overwhelming. After time progressing or creating tension, I will sometimes do things as coarse on the level of the precepts, like: taking allowables only when others aren't around—in a way a fourth precept breach; tracking calories out of concern for my appearance—beautification breach; and so on.

The stress came to the point a while ago where I increasingly took sensual bait to the point of giving up and breaking several precepts. They were my (series of) choices. I confessed online but didn't tell others. I have recovered and been transparent since. I was pardoned and, for the first time since I arrived, I feel calm. I'm still stressed, because my daily gratification is limited to the meal, but I am not breaking precepts. Still, I am often tempted. I am not "steady".

The progress I did make in renunciation, I think, was not pleasurable or stable because it was not based on a steady moral character. I wonder if my difficulties have been owed to not having developed much in lay life. I came here without much experience in keeping the 8 precepts. In fact, I even occasionally broke the 5 at home. As a result, it feels like practice here has been mostly painfully giving up everything with periods of indulgence.

It strikes me that while understanding can be genuine, consistently aligning one's choices with it is not easy. Danger frequently and personally becomes apparent to me, but my actions revert to worldliness. Are these two different things—understanding and true training in making good choices? Is the latter more important? Can I not rely on my understanding to do the work for me? Should virtue, by willpower, come first?

I have a sincere sense of urgency and desire to practice but feel disoriented by my own struggles and inauthenticity in weathering the turbulence of this new lifestyle. Right now, for example, the urgency is apparent, but this isn't the first time.

I believed my breaches were overly problematic to stay, so I planned to leave, recover, and dedicate some time at home to truly becoming a virtuous person for the first time in my life. Having tasted the pleasure of renunciation, I wanted to be a lay person for a while, living alone, working a job, and practicing aloofness in regards to worldly pleasures, before going to another, "easier" secluded environment after a while.

However, when I opened up, some monks urged me to stay. I now feel at ease rather than remorseful. I'm determined to make the best choice rather than the most appealing one. As I currently conceive my situation, I have considered: a. remaining in an austere environment, striving to perfect my virtue, while not focusing on anything beyond that—bearing the solitude, hunger, and so on, or b. going home, relaxing, and focusing on committing to the precepts in an easier environment, in preparation for eventually leaving home again. I am leaning towards b. Now that I have tasted the relief of virtue, it would seem simpler to solidify it at my own pace. But I could push, and give it my all, I suppose. The only things holding me back are my own choices. Any input is appreciated. Thank you Bhantes and fellow renunciates.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-08 06:22:15

> Danger frequently and personally becomes apparent to me, but my actions revert to worldliness. Are these two different things—understanding and true training in making good choices? I

They are not different. If it doesn't change one's choices, it is not understanding yet. It hasn't "sunk in."

> Having tasted the pleasure of renunciation, I wanted to be a lay person

> for a while, living alone, working a job, and practicing aloofness in regards to worldly pleasures, before going to another, “easier” secluded environment after a while.

That’s not a bad outcome if it actually turns out that way, but you want to honestly reflect on why going back is more appealing. People who return home after living in a monastery very rarely uphold the same standards afterwards, despite convincing themselves that they would.

Perhaps the solitude and hunger are in themselves so bad that the mind is perfectly happy with abandoning just that and otherwise continuing the training unchanged. But more often than not, that choice is more appealing because although one will still be committed to the precepts on paper, accountability for breaking them will be significantly lower, and *that* is felt as relief. There could even be a concealed expectation of a quick “top up” of sensual indulgence before you take the precepts seriously again.

If the latter is the reason, then the mind is trying to seduce you into giving up the training and not just the austere environment—which you are of course free to do, but you’d better be honest to yourself about it.

## Intrusive thoughts ()

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: No_Fishing_3019 *2026-04-06 18:12:14*

This is just a short practice question and probably doesn’t deserve its own thread, but I didn’t know where else to put it.

Say I have a desire to go on bike rides with a romantic partner, but I can’t do that because I don’t have a romantic partner, so that frustrated desire will present as aversion. At random times during the day, a thought like “I can’t go on bike rides with a romantic partner” will come up, which is then immediately followed up by a feeling of aversion, and will soon be followed up by other related thoughts that will generate more aversion or desire, if I don’t consciously intervene. My reaction may go like this:

I notice that this thought is predicated on craving and will lead to further craving, so I stop myself from engaging with it. This basically amounts to forcefully cutting it off, because the citta really wants me to think that thought right now. When the thought is gone, I notice the aversion that the thought generated and make sure not to resist it. I stay peripherally aware of that aversion until it is gone.

Is that the right way to react?

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-08 06:00:23

> I notice that this thought is predicated on craving and will lead to further craving, so I stop myself from engaging with it. This basically amounts to forcefully cutting it off, because the citta really wants me to think that thought right now. When the thought is gone, I notice the aversion that the thought generated and make sure not to resist it. I stay peripherally aware of that aversion until it is gone.

Indeed. That's how you remove the fuel for the aversion, and it eventually subsides.

What you don't want to be "cutting off" is the underlying discomfort due to which the mind wants to think aversive thoughts (or any unwholesome thought). That's where people often go wrong, and it's essentially trying to stop Māra from presenting baits instead of holding the mind back from engaging with them.

## The Ultimate Choice

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: LessNeighborhood1257 *2026-04-06 04:21:04*

*Thank you in advance for your generosity in addressing this question, and forgive me for its length, but I feel it deserves special care in order to properly give you insight into the reflections of my mind. I am going to try to be as truthful as I can in my writing, so you can use your own wisdom to see any pitfalls I'm wandering into with my thinking. In this way, I hope to learn something from you and fill the glass of wisdom drop by drop.*

Dear Hillside Hermitage,

You've said before that the essence of the dhamma is choice, that we have the power to shape our thoughts, speech, and actions. With this in mind, the following question naturally arises: how should we exercise the power of our autonomy for our greatest benefit? As we look into the processes of our mind, we find that we're pressured towards the sights, sounds, smells, tastes, touches, and ideas of the world. But why are we pressured towards these things, and why do we find ourselves chasing after them? We wouldn't be seeking these things if, one, they didn't provide some amount of relief and, two, we weren't experiencing a fundamental lack in our experience. But do these worldly things really provide true happiness, a happiness that doesn't age, grow sick, and die? If they did, we wouldn't have to keep chasing after them; we'd already be fulfilled on account of obtaining their pleasure. I'll call upon a simile to illustrate this further. We all start out on express trains in this life. Perhaps it's the train headed towards the ideal career that we think will make us fulfilled, whereupon its completion, we will be satisfied that we've made our mark on the world. Or perhaps it's the train headed towards the ideal partner that we think will fill the emotional lack we feel within ourselves. Then we get all excited and

hop from train to train looking for the next big thing. Reflecting on the drawbacks of these behaviors, another question arises: is it worth it? And is there something more worthwhile to spend my time doing? These are the questions that you and the Buddha asked yourselves, and they're the very same questions I'm contemplating myself. As human beings with limited lifespans, it's impossible to not make choices in life. In fact, we make choices every second. And so, given the weight our choices have in shaping our lives, another question arises: what makes a good choice? As you've said before, this is the question that lies at the heart of wisdom. What, when I do it, will lead to my long-term welfare and happiness? I have seen how choices motivated by greed, hatred, worry and flurry, indolence, and anxious doubt have led to negative results. And I've seen how choices motivated by generosity, virtue, renunciation, wisdom, effort, endurance, truth, determination, goodwill, and equanimity have led to positive results. Having seen this for myself, I realize that the best way to spend my time in this life is to search for a happiness that doesn't age, doesn't grow ill, and doesn't die. However, in order to completely devote myself to this goal, the householder's life won't suffice. Using your simile, it's like a flower trying to grow through the cracks in the sidewalks of New York. With two years left of my college career, I have to make a choice. I can either wait to become a monk, finish my college education, and go forth. Or, I can drop everything like the Buddha did and start now. As the suttas remind us, for who knows? Tomorrow: death. There is no bargaining with death and his mighty horde. In other words, it's not realistic to rely on the perception that I'll be alive in two years to go forth. The Buddha asks us to be heedful in our reflections on death. In AN 6.19, the Maranassati Sutta, we see this most clearly:

" *... When this was said, the Blessed One addressed the monks. "Whoever develops mindfulness of death, thinking, 'O, that I might live for a day & night... for a day... for the interval that it takes to eat a meal... for the interval that it takes to swallow having chewed up four morsels of food, that I might attend to the Blessed One's instructions. I would have accomplished a great deal' — they are said to dwell heedlessly. They develop mindfulness of death slowly for the sake of ending the effluents.*
*"But whoever develops mindfulness of death, thinking, 'O, that I might live for the interval that it takes to swallow having chewed up one morsel of food... for the interval that it takes to breathe out after breathing in, or to breathe in after breathing out, that I might attend to the Blessed One's instructions. I would have accomplished a great deal' — they are said to dwell heedfully. They develop mindfulness of death acutely for the sake of ending the effluents.*

If my understanding is true, from the Buddha's point of view, the best choice is renunciation. That trading a lesser happiness for a greater happiness is a noble trade. However, I feel conflicted about this choice, and after some intense probing, I realize that the difficulty in this decision lies not in giving up the pursuit of the degree, but in how my family and relatives will respond to my decision. I know I will not use this degree to get a job, for if I graduate, my job will be to seek true happiness. So, the choice here is not about renouncing the degree but about renouncing the need to be understood and renouncing the fear of disappointing others. This

means that if I choose to delay my ordination, I'll have missed out on an opportunity to perfect renunciation. Am I contemplating this in the right way? That even if I do live to be ordained two years from now, I'd still have to perfect the quality of renunciation, and in making the choice to wait to be ordained, I'll have sown the seed of being liable to what others think of me. On the other hand, I am not one who abandons pursuits lightly, and I recognize the value of education and its benefits for our understanding of the world. If I wait to be ordained, I can still practice at Metta Forest Monastery on the weekends, giving me the best of both worlds while I wait to go forth. But isn't this a heedless thought? If I were to be diagnosed with a terminal illness tomorrow and told that I had a year left to live, the choice would be clear. If my relatives and family were all gone, I'd drop everything and ordain. So it seems that the root of all of this indecision is a fear of disappointing my family and relatives. Ultimately, only I can make this decision, so my purpose in writing this letter is not to ask you to make it for me, but to gain your perspective on my mind's contemplations. Thank you once again, and may you be well.

— Alex

P.S. Does samanadipa hermitage or hillside hermitage still ordain monks?

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-06 13:22:52

> This means that if I choose to delay my ordination, I'll have missed out on an opportunity to perfect renunciation.

Yes, but beyond that, the idea that finishing the degree will make a meaningful difference is false. Whenever you abandon the world, the reaction of people close to you will be the same, the displeasure will be the same, and the mind's fear in regard to it will be the same—and likely greater if you wait, since you give in to that fear and thus fuel it.

So, the real question is whether you would stick to your determination to leave the world, and use that renunciation to practice rightly no matter how unpleasant that turns out to be. And it will be at least as unpleasant as the disappointment you fear. The extent of the internal problem you carry is evidently that much at least.

If you're not entirely sure that you will stick to both of those, then it's better to wait and do your best with your current circumstances. Not because of anything related to the degree, but because it can be a major setback if you end up returning home. The mind develops a "been there, done that" attitude towards going forth that makes it much harder to take it on sincerely again.

> P.S. Does samanadipa hermitage or hillside hermitage still ordain monks?

Both places are operating at full capacity in terms of permanent residents for the foreseeable future.

# “Or the memory that ‘feeling is there’ is established…”

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: NoArm_Boss2627 *2026-04-05 23:07:47*

I have a question in regards to the Sattipatthana sutta. Particularly the line:

“Or the memory that ‘feeling is there’ is established for him just to the extent necessary for knowledge and recollectedness. He abides disengaged, not taking up anything in the world.”

I can understand how contemplating ‘feelings within feelings’ and the ‘factors of origination’ relates to yoniso manisakara, but simply discerning that feelings are there seems like it can be conflated with the direct observation-(ayoniso) type meditation. I do my best just to keep a general awareness of the feeling-tone that is underlying my experience without becoming absorbed into it, and just dwell on that.

I simply note my general state of feeling, either pleasant, unpleasant or neutral. In doing so, I notice how these feelings are (A) conditioned, since I had no choice in their making, and hence (B)impermanent and not ‘for me’ . Would that constitute a correct form of yoniso manisakara, discerning that my feeling state is just there, primordial, and conditioned, and keeping that knowledge in my background awareness as I focus directly on the feelings that are there? (For example, as I’m walking, I simply discern that there is unpleasant feeling present as a context for my experience)

Can I do the same thing with moods, just note whichever mood is present, discern it as the basis or womb for experience,and dwell on that fact alone (discern that the ‘mind is just there…’)?

Or must I always be contemplating the basis for feelings/moods such as contact, perception, etc?

I understand those things to be the factors of origination.

Though I imagine there’s a good reason that final line in the sutta is included just as it is for the other three factors of mindfulness.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-08 05:51:05

> but simply discerning that feelings are there seems like it can be conflated with the direct observation-(ayoniso) type meditation.

… If one has from the start misunderstood what feelings even are. Actual feelings structurally cannot be “observed” like that at all.

> Would that constitute a correct form of yoniso manisakara, discerning that my feeling state is just there, primordial, and conditioned, and keep-

> ing that knowledge in my background awareness as I focus directly on the feelings that are there?

Yes, but there is no need to intentionally "focus directly" on anything. When you discern feelings where they are, that perspective naturally carries over into whatever comes up on its own.

> Or must I always be contemplating the basis for feelings/moods such as contact, perception, etc?

Not always. Seeing a feeling as an arisen experience (not leaving it festering in the background unnoticed) is ideally enough for the mind to cease its engagements within it. You contemplate further only if that's not enough for disengagement to occur.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-14 05:23:19 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

Whatever an act of observation applies to is an object in the world, not a feeling. Feeling endures *in regard to* such an act, and it has to be ignored in order to be with the content of the observation.

The same goes for all the aggregates. They cannot be observed because they are the background of observation (and of any action).

## Questions on Sleep and fine Food as Obstacles in Practice

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Sa_Mahe_ri *2026-04-03 08:32:40*

If I understand it correctly, it is not recommended by the Venerables to set or reduce one's sleep to a fixed amount—at least not for the initial stages of the gradual training.

But how, in that case, should AN 6.17 be understood, where the Buddha criticizes junior monks for excessive sleeping?

> "But those mendicants who were junior, recently gone forth, newly come to this teaching and training slept until the sun came up, snoring. The Buddha saw them doing this, with his clairvoyance that is purified and superhuman. He went to the assembly hall, sat down on the seat spread out, and addressed the mendicants:
> "Mendicants, where is Sāriputta? Where are Mahāmoggallāna, Mahākassapa, Mahākaccāna, Mahākoṭṭhita, Mahācunda, Mahākappina, Anuruddha, Revata, and Ānanda? Where have these senior disciples gone?" "Soon after the Buddha left, those venerables each went to their

> own dwelling.”
> “So, mendicants, when the senior mendicants left, why did you sleep until the sun came up, snoring? What do you think, mendicants? Have you ever seen or heard of an anointed aristocratic king who rules his whole life, dear and beloved to the country, while indulging in the pleasures of sleeping, lying down, and drowsing as much as he likes?”

I think it has something to do with the wording of the last quoted sentence, but at the same time the criticism itself doesn’t seem to directly refer to sleeping without being tired, or to waking up and then deciding out of laziness to go back to sleep. But more in line of “you are wasting your time”.

—

And I have another question about food and MN 7:

> When a bhikkhu of such virtue, such qualities, and such understanding eats boiled fine rice with the dark grains removed and served with many soups and sauces, that is no obstacle for him. Compare this with cloth that is soiled and stained; it can be made pure and clean by pure water. Or with unrefined gold, which can be made pure and bright by a forge. In the same way, when a bhikkhu of such virtue, such qualities, and such understanding eats boiled fine rice with the dark grains removed and served with many soups and sauces, that is no obstacle for him.

I have often stumbled over this phrasing, because in my understanding it suggests that for someone who has not yet reached this level of virtue, it very well can more easily become an obstacle to consume such fine food. Would it accordingly be recommended, as a precaution to not agitate the mind, to choose—whenever possible—simpler food over more delicious options, even when the latter are not sought for their taste as such? Especially in light of the fact that the daily food served at my monastery today is probably closer to what kings ate back then than to the food one would have received on alms round in those times.

I’d be grateful for guidance on how to understand this in practice.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-05 04:38:20

> But how, in that case, should AN 6.17 be understood, where the Buddha criticizes junior monks for excessive sleeping?

Indulgence in sleep is a deliberate action that you simply abstain from, so if you feel the need to impose an external limit to prevent such indulgence, it’s because you don’t see what the work even is (and will most likely start indulging in however little sleep you get).

> it suggests that for someone who has not yet reached this level of virtue, it very well can more easily become an obstacle to consume such fine

> food.

Yes, because they could be eating such food with an indulgent *intention.* Not because the food will accidentally obstruct them despite the lack of such intentions.

> Would it accordingly be recommended, as a precaution to not agitate the mind, to choose—whenever possible—simpler food over more delicious options, even when the latter are not sought for their taste as such?

Definitely not. Inclining towards such a precaution implies a fundamental misunderstanding of what the mind is (namely, intention). Same as with sleep, due to tackling the problem at the wrong place, your actual mind will likely start indulging in the "simple" food you limited it to.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-05 07:23:37 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> So that they slept until the sun came up, snoring can be simply seen as an byproduct of their intention to indulge in sleep when they went to sleep

Yes. Neither of those things are themselves intentional.

> So there might be some translation error as well, which I can't figure out myself.

The Pāli does contain the expression *yāvadatthaṁ*, i.e., "as much as one wants." And *seyyasukhaṁ passasukhaṁ middhasukhaṁ anuyutto viharanto* means "dwelling *dedicated to* the pleasure of sleeping, lying down and drowsing."

When getting that pleasure is one's intention for sleeping, the action is indulgent no matter the duration of one's sleep. And the reverse when that is not the intention.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-14 07:19:23 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> But isn't the whole idea of sense-restraint that it is easier to develop the proper intention in regard to sensuality when things which make the untrained mind liable to indulge are restricted?

Not quite. It's a widespread misunderstanding that sense restraint means preventing yourself from perceiving this or that.

If you read the Suttas carefully, you see that sense restraint is always described in terms of what you don't do (on the mental level) *when* you perceive something. In this case, it's what you wouldn't do when eating even the most agreeable food so that the mind is not polluted.

Now, this obviously doesn't mean that you can eat whatever you crave for and then just practice sense restraint.

Sense restraint is preceded by establishment in virtue. Virtue in this context means that when the very act of eating something is infected with craving, you won't be eating it to begin with.

> According to my (very puthujjana) understanding, sex is prohibited not because it is necessarily impossible to engage in it without grasping and delight, but because no untrained mind could accomplish this practically

Nor would a trained mind. It is necessarily impossible to engage in sexual intercourse (to initiate it or consent to it) without grasping and delight. Hence celibacy is a fixed part of virtue.

> no doubt as a result of my mind's lack of conditioning, I find it impossible to eat, for instance, a grilled cheese sandwich without delighting in it and craving fatty food for days, but experience a fraction of this sensual delight in my oatmeal.

Right, so the problem is that craving, not the sandwiches. Conversely, the solution is to *abstain* from eating out of craving—which may or may not include abstaining from the sandwiches depending on the current state of the mind—rather than to perform the duty of only eating oatmeal.

Without a doubt, at any given time there will be foods apart from oatmeal that your mind does not crave for. By bundling it all into "oatmeal and the rest," you avoid the work of discerning what sensuality actually is, namely your *passionate intention* that is totally independent from the agreeability of things.

It's a less extreme form of the misguided practices of other ascetics mentioned in the Suttas, like eating only herbs and always being naked, so as to get around the need to see the current state of their mind and make choices based on that. Even if lustful states are factually avoided that way, wrong view and lack of clarity are directly fueled, and that is worse.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-15 12:31:24 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

If your mind is obsessively pulling you towards certain foods—meaning you see the threat of losing perspective and not being able to stop even before you begin—then you should definitely not go along with that pull.

Still, the particulars of a given food, be it richness or anything else, are completely irrelevant. The mind craves a certain food when it craves it, not when it's rich or light, and thus the state of the mind has to be the sole criterion.

Not seeing that is enough to set the whole effort in the wrong direction internally, despite externally abstaining from the same things as you would with the right perspective.

> even nuts, an uncomfortable quality immediately taints the thought which is identical to the feeling of being pulled into a fantasy based on doubt or lust

Also, some skepticism about that reaction is warranted because indeed, it could be the result of the diet itself. I wouldn't recommend ignoring the reaction and eating the food anyway, but don't take for granted that you will always have an issue with those foods.

## An attempt to clarify HH's stance on the relationship between sotapatti and celibacy

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: tejveeer *2026-04-01 18:23:51*

Due to some things that happened this week, I broke restraint with respect to social media, so I thought I may as well post this and then go back to restraint.

A few weeks ago, in order to substitute coarse entertainment with finer entertainment, I thought to clarify the debates around HH's position on celibacy and sotapatti. I've written and uploaded my understanding of the debate here, in case it is of use to others.

> My aim in this post is to attempt to clarify HH's stance on the relationship between sotapatti and celibacy. In a previous article, HH posited that sotapatti requires celibacy, but were faced with multiple objections from others. I believe that the majority, if not all, of those objections were not well founded because they didn't understand the exact relationship that exists between sotapatti and (non-)celibacy for HH. As a result, the objections targetted positions that did not address their central claim. In writing this post, I wish to introduce exactness to that relationship.
>
> In order to do so, I will begin by examining goals and what kinds of acts exist in the pursuit of goals. After having developed two goal-act taxonomies, I will apply them to the relationship between celibacy and the goal of sotapatti. This will allow me to express what I take to be HH's position in three claims. I will then present an analogy in an attempt to further clarify the sense of those three claims. After doing so, I'll address common objections to HH's initial position and argue that they don't address HH's claims. Lastly, I will present a summary of the three claims by unwrapping the special terms used therein and framing them in more contemporary expressions.
>
> As a side note, it's worth mentioning that I'm currently restraining myself from using youtube, reddit, and suttacentral as part of my larger restraint from entertainment. Because of this, I will not be able to offer sources of claims and objections and will instead have to rely on mem-

> ory. This does not contract much from the overall post, however, since the central objective here is just to help me make sense of HH's position.

Would be interested to hear any critiques on this.

It's worth noting that this is currently just the first draft. A lot of the wording here is quite awkward and was fixed in the Appendix. In the second objection, I also realized that to properly present it, I would've had to introduced things that I didn't have the time to introduce, as such it remains incomplete. Do note that this post is not concerned with *justifying* their position; only *clarifying it*, and in part showing that the objections I commonly saw failed to see the central point.

I had presented this to Ven. Anigha privately on discord, and bhante stated that it was correct for the most part. There was apparently an issue that existed with a noncentral part of the post, but I no longer recall what that issue was that bhante stated - I cannot currently go on discord as I've disabled my accounts for the week.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-02 16:36:17

The point can be expressed much more concisely: if your practice does not include celibacy, then either your view of the practice is wrong (i.e., it is not geared towards purifying your mind from craving), or your commitment to practicing along the right lines is still underdeveloped (lack of a sense of urgency). Both of these are obvious obstructions to stream entry.

For a *sotāpanna* the former is not possible, but the latter will still stop them from making further progress.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-03 05:07:33 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

You're essentially saying that it's necessary to cater to people who from the start are poised to not put the teachings into practice. With that I don't mean "investigation-oriented" people as a whole—using one's reasoning is not inherently wrong—but people who refuse to try to see what we are pointing at in their individual experience afflicted by suffering (which is what gives rise to faith).

That refusal is not going to end once enough justifications are given because it's an emotionally rooted habit. They will demand more rigor in some other respect, and meeting that demand will only help them procrastinate approaching the Dhamma at the level where it is (presently evident and verifiable).

It's the same principle that is described here.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-03 05:11:12 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> the Buddha did not consider this to be the case.

What is this belief based on?

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-04 04:19:52 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> even a noble disciple may still indulge in sensuality, and the life of a householder will not lose its significance for him.

Yes, and as I wrote in the second alternative above, that would come from being under-committed to the training.

The Buddha went on to give a long exposition to Mahānāma on the dangers of sensuality because not giving it up is precisely what was holding him back.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-04 07:09:59 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> They are constrained by this perception because don't know whether the cost of the practice (suffering from restraint), is worth the benefit (freedom from suffering). This is because they aren't able to perceive any appropriate initial grounds that may indicate to them that that benefit can indeed be received from the cost.

Yes, and my point is that they won't perceive those grounds through more rigorous argumentation, so it's a waste of time and effort for both parties.

The daunting difficulty of the practice will only be taken on if a person feels that the alternative is not only worse, but inescapable: "I am prey to suffering" is seen acutely and personally, as a necessary property of one's entire existence. Seeing that liability automatically makes theoretical justifications for the practice redundant, just as you don't need a logical proof to justify trying to remove an arrow from your chest.

If the problem does not manifest to one on that level, then one's commitment will not be sufficient to go "against the grain" of one's personal desires and obsessions. Thus, no matter how closely one follows the Suttas on paper, one will not be committed to the actual Dhamma but to something that merely sounds like it.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-04 11:54:43 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

You are conflating "being unable to return to sensuality" with practicing in line with the Dhamma.

Being celibate and withdrawn (which is what we have stated as a requirement) doesn't mean you are beyond sensual desire. It means you don't *give into it*, which is how you go against the stream and make progress towards the cessation of craving.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-04 13:03:48 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

That doesn't contradict the point at all.

Mahānāma was lacking in diligence, which as I mentioned in the first comment above, is possible for a noble disciple. Seeing that lack of diligence, the Buddha spoke about the dangers of sensuality hoping that Mahānāma would gain enough of a sense of urgency to fully give up wrong intention.

If his enjoyment of sensuality was not the cornerstone of his lack of diligence—and was instead a dismissable symptom of not developing something else—the Buddha would've given him a discourse on that other thing instead of on the dangers of sensuality.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-04 15:11:33 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

So, you're proposing that it's not a problem for a person to engage in sensuality, maintaining their reliance on that form of happiness, when they don't know a better form of happiness. They are free to continue to do so; they just need to train in "mindfulness"—an exercise that is clearly done at the expense of acknowledging that craving is the root of suffering, and that wrong intention must be abandoned.

That exercise will somehow lead to the same result as the mindfulness that the Suttas do teach—mindfulness which *is* geared towards abandoning craving, and would thus be along the lines of remembering to not give in to sensual urges whenever they arise. This "mindfulness" also bypasses the Buddha's statement that someone who still enjoys sensuality cannot abide in internal calm.

Does that not sound like magical thinking?

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-04 19:10:47 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> The idea that celibacy is a prerequisite for entering the stream does not come from the Buddha.

The idea that it isn't a prerequisite doesn't come from the Buddha either. Both are interpretations.

> In other words, what about the elimination of the ignorance?

Denying non-sensuality as a necessary part of the practice is undeniable ignorance of the four noble truths here and now: following the most blatant form of craving while trying to solve the problem means you ignore that craving is the origin of the problem.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-05 13:48:19 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> The prerequisites are explicitly listed by the Buddha in many suttas as the factors for the stream-entry, and celibacy is not listed among these factors, even once.

That's because for someone who rightly views practicing in line with the Dhamma (a factor for stream-entry) as practicing towards the cessation of craving, the need for celibacy will be obvious. Just as it was to the entire Saṅgha before any rules were laid down.

> A layperson who engages in sexual activity within the framework of observing the five precepts is not breaking any rules, whereas a monk who engages in a similar act commits a grave violation of the Vinaya—he commits a parajika offence.

That's secondary; both are engaging in wrong intention. The Vinaya is an impermanent framework that will one day be forgotten, but wrong intention will always be wrong intention and lead to the maintenance of craving no matter who you are.

Plus, that a monk receives the same penalty as murderer for such an act is no accident. See how the Buddha tells Sudinna that what he did was the direct opposite of the spirit of the Dhamma.

## Right mindset to benefit from the confession server?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: spiffyhandle *2026-04-01 11:39:31*

I was in the confession server for six weeks, but it didn't help me. Ironically, it made my practice worse. I wonder what I did wrong. Some people say they benefit a lot

from it.

First, I found it neurotic to keep a list of every instance of breaking a precept. I'd prefer to go by memory, but the instructions say that I must report every violation. I cannot remember every violation unless I write them down.

Second, is there a helpful mindset to approach the confession server with? I joined the server with a vague hope that it would be helpful. At first, I tried really hard to keep the precepts because I thought it was embarrassing to admit to others that I broke them. But after two weeks, I stopped being embarrassed. Then, I gradually slid into breaking precepts more and more because I started with a weak internal reference point **and** I lost my external reference point (embarrassment). Something about reading other people's confessions made me feel like my own violations were more acceptable.

Since leaving, I've found some improvement in precepts through Uposatha. I find I can keep the precepts for one day and then that has momentum into the rest of the week. And I'm starting to experience why the precepts are important and how they relate to my mind.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-01 15:13:00

> I'd prefer to go by memory, but the instructions say that I must report every violation.

The rule says:

> Make sure to list every transgression that you recall, and not only the ones you think are important.

The point being, *when* you recall something that is clearly a transgression, you confess it instead of giving yourself the chance to explain away the confession as not necessary in that particular instance. So the rule is "don't intentionally cover things up" and not "don't accidentally forget anything."

> At first, I tried really hard to keep the precepts because I thought it was embarrassing to admit to others that I broke them. But after two weeks, I stopped being embarrassed. Then, I gradually slid into breaking precepts more and more because I started with a weak internal reference point and I lost my external reference point (embarrassment). Something about reading other people's confessions made me feel like my own violations were more acceptable.

It's a common misconception that confession helps by producing an external sense of embarrassment. But that embarrassment is indeed quite ephemeral and won't take you very far.

The right shame (*hiriottappā*) comes from failing at something that you were sincerely devoted to (hence *saddhā* comes before *hiri* and *ottappā* in the list of five

powers). The external act of confessing cannot by itself ensure that you are sincerely devoted to purifying your conduct, nor that the right sense of shame and the resulting effort arise.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-03 06:53:23 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Is this hiriottappā then? I mostly wonder about the the anxiety there if it should be felt this way.

Potentially. The shame needs to come from feeling that you failed yourself by doing what unavoidably harms you, not from having failed in the eyes of someone or something external.

## Arahants laughing

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: craveminerals *2026-03-16 16:53:33*

Would an Arahant laugh?

Ñāṇavīra Thera wrote about humor and laughter, suggesting that laughter is closely bound up with fear or experienced threat—such as that arising from contradiction—and may appear when that threat is seen as harmless or passes.

He writes:

"We laugh, then, when fear passes; we laugh as a charm to make fear pass; and we entertain imaginary fears to make ourselves laugh."“Laughter, then, is not so much a reaction to fear as its counterpart … He [the sekha] is already leaving behind him both laughter and tears."

If an Arahant's mind is free from sorrow, anxiety, and tension (see SN 22.43), it is unclear whether laughter could still arise. (If it did, it would presumably be of a different kind than we usually express, or only as a smile)

Could it occur purely as a bodily reaction—like from an illness— or would laughter imply that there is some tension in the mind?

Edit: reworded for more accuracy

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-03-17 15:28:57

The Buddha said that *too much* laughter is regarded as childish in the noble one's discipline. Besides, notice that unlike dancing and singing, he does not speak of "destroying the bridge" in regard to even this childish laughter. In other words, it's not something you would categorically fall away because it's not intrinsically unwholesome, but you should try to avoid it because for people whose understanding

of the Dhamma is still shallow and who take you as an example, it can easily be interpreted as an allowance for laxity in regard to actually unwholesome things even when it's not unwholesome for you internally.

The Buddha himself supposedly never laughed, and that makes perfect sense given that he had refined his outward demeanor beyond the minimum threshold of an Arahant (who is only incapable of five specific actions.

That refinement was only natural given the weight that his image had to carry as the absolute highest authority on the Dhamma.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-03-17 19:27:05 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Being unable to take "a course of action influenced by desire, aversion, muddledness, or fear" wouldn't eliminate laughter, then.

Yes, and laughter isn't even an action many times. Action requires intention, and laughter can happen despite one's intention being actively set on the opposite.

> In reading some of Ñāṇavīra's thoughts on this, he seems to be saying something true. But there's also a possibility that what he describes is quite removed from "real life" and how things actually work.

Yes, he definitely had a philosophical bent, and that's often at odds with the Dhamma. Granted, he openly admitted that he was writing all those letters to pass the time, having lost the motivation to strive further due to his sickness. He himself likely didn't see those ideas as fundamental to the training.

> If I may ask another question, what do you make of the "laughing wisdom" in SN 55.24, that spiffyhandle mentioned in their comment, what does that mean?

*Hāsapaññā* is used for Ven. Sāriputta in SN 2.29 and elsewhere, so it can't be connected with Sarakāni's drinking habit.

It could simply mean "endowed with wisdom that brings happiness." But that would be strange according to Pāli convention, since it would be an outlier in a list of terms that all have very similar meanings.

Perhaps *hāsa* is derived from (or is a corruption of) *haṁsa,* which means swan. In the Suttas, the swan is sometimes used to convey swiftness, which fits with the other qualifiers in the SN 2.29 list.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-03-18 18:01:03 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> I wonder if that's the skill to bring about laughter and joy in others when giving dhamma talks.

No, it couldn't be a "skill" in a Dhamma context. It would at best remain as a habit built up from before, and a mostly counterproductive one at that. Hence the Buddha's own example.

## Wrong meditation as an aid for establishing virtue and sense restraint?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Financial-Wallaby316 *2026-03-06 16:11:58*

so a non stream enterer can't practice meditation in an actually correct way, but can one use a technically wrong practice as a tool to help establish the foundations of a right practice if they understand that that meditation technique isn't what will lead to right view? For example, if a meditation practice gives you a level of mundane mental clarity that helps you keep the 8 precepts, or it helps you stay recollected of the dhamma for the rest of the day after your practice which also aids in practicing virtue, or even just as a less destructive form of sensuality, that you can give in to before you know how to endure things at the right level, instead of giving in to things at the coarser levels of body and speech. Or if it helps you become more aware of your intentions and reasons for acting at least on the level someone without right view is capable of, and more peripherally aware of things like feelings and intentions and the body as peripherally enduring things that are the basis for anything you could ever conceive of doing, to the extent a non stream enterer can understand. Can a meditation technique be a sort of "last thing" that is abstained from, after coarser ways of acting out are abstained from?

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-03-07 04:25:33

What this common argument fails to see is that replacing lust and aversion with delusion is not progress at all. Delusion is the worst of the three defilements.

In other words, it's far better if you try and you fail to restrain your actions in the ordinary self-aware state than if you succeed in restraint thanks to a hypnotic state (which is not what *samādhi is).

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-03-09 04:16:30 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> This makes me think that maybe if I simply stopped deluding myself about these practices and their relationship to buddhist practice, they could remain in my life the same way as any other activity, as another thing I do whose intentions I need to interrogate and reflect on and avoid doing for the wrong reasons as best I can.

Yes, that's reasonable. Even if you already don't see them as part of the training though, keep in mind that the more you succeed in the actual training, the less you will resort to *anything* for the sake of managing dukkha.

## Question about virtue, entertainment, and understanding the emphasis on celibacy

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Global_Ad_7891 *2026-03-04 22:55:25*

Hello everyone,

I apologize in advance for the long winded post. Thank you to whoever reads the whole thing and provides feedback.

I've been reflecting recently on the precepts and my own conduct over the past several years, and I wanted to ask a question both about virtue and about the role of certain precepts.

I first came across Buddhism when I was around 19 or 20 (I am now 26). At that time I read the five precepts and essentially just agreed with them. But I didn't really understand them deeply or consciously "undertake" them in any formal sense. Looking back, I think I simply encountered them, thought they made sense, and continued living in accordance with them.

In many ways I was already following most of them before I even encountered Buddhism. I had a fairly sheltered life growing up and generally wasn't inclined toward things like stealing, lying, or harming others. I'd argue that my virtue was perfectly in line with the 5 precepts except for a 2-3 year bout of smoking a lot of weed in high school. That period ended when I was 19 years old, which was influenced by encountering Buddhist teachings. Since then — about 6–7 years — I haven't used drugs or alcohol at all despite many attempts to coerce me into taking them.

I was also already living fairly simply. I never cared much about appearance or beautification, and started becoming a loner in high school, so frivolous speech and socializing were never really a big part of my life. Also I dropped out of college at 19 years old, around the time I discovered Buddhism, and I started working in a warehouse and had no friends.

For work I mostly drive a truck and manage a few properties, which means my days are spent doing fairly simple tasks — driving, cleaning, fixing things, scheduling service calls, picking up supplies, etc. So I'm alone a large portion of the day. I also talk to myself in my head a lot.

About three years ago, I lost around 70 pounds and changed my relationship with food. I started eating once per day and have maintained that pattern since then. This is mainly due to reading about OMAD and its benefits in regards to eating a keto/carnivore diet, which is what I am currently on. The diet change also relieved a lot of my food addictions to various unhealthy foods and snacks.

In regards to celibacy, in the past I would abstain for long periods and then occasionally lapse, but over the past year I've been 100% celibate and find it extremely easy to maintain.

The one area where I clearly see weakness is **entertainment**. For many years I relied heavily on distractions like video games, movies, YouTube, and sports watching. Only in the past few months have I started reducing those things, and just recently I've decided to seriously try abandoning entertainment altogether.

This leads to two questions.

First, I'm curious about the **strong emphasis placed on celibacy** in many teachings. I understand that sexual desire is very coarse and powerful, but in my experience once abstinence becomes established the pull weakens dramatically. Even when encountering sexual imagery online or seeing attractive people in public, there's very little reaction compared to how things used to be.

By contrast, **entertainment feels much subtler but harder to deal with**. It doesn't feel like a strong addictive pull the way sex can, but there's a persistent tendency to fill boredom or discomfort with distraction. It seems easier to overlook and justify.

So I'm curious why celibacy is often emphasized as being "more important" than entertainment, when it seems possible that things like entertainment and distraction could themselves be a major obstacle to insight into the Four Noble Truths or stream entry.

My second question concerns virtue and progress on the path. Although I didn't consciously "undertake" most of the precepts with a clear understanding of their purpose at the time, I've ended up living in accordance with many of them for years. In most cases this happened simply because the opposite behavior felt unpleasant or emotionally disturbing. For example, lying tends to feel painful and emotionally driven, even if only subtly. The same goes for things like harsh speech, stealing, or acting out of strong craving. In that sense I feel that a certain degree of restraint developed somewhat naturally even before I understood the framework of Buddhist virtue.

Because of that, I sometimes wonder whether it's reasonable to think that a **fairly stable foundation of virtue** might already be present, even if my understanding

of it was initially incomplete. In my day-to-day life the only thing that still seems to exert a consistent pull is distraction through entertainment or the tendency to avoid boredom. Aside from that, the inclination to break the other precepts feels almost nonexistent. So I'm wondering whether this kind of situation would generally be considered a meaningful foundation of virtue, or whether without properly understanding the precepts from the start one would still need to essentially begin again from a more basic level.

Part of why I ask this is because it seems that in the Buddha's time many people were already living quite virtuous lives before encountering the Dhamma, and some attained stream entry upon hearing relatively brief teachings. So I'm curious whether virtue established in this kind of indirect or intuitive way could play a similar role, or whether proper understanding of why you are building virtue has to come, and THEN you start training in the 8 precepts, and THEN you can use that virtue as a basis for insight.

My other question concerns **understanding the mind more deeply**. Sometimes I find it difficult to imagine how seeing the "signs of the mind" could appear fundamentally different from how experience already presents itself now, aside from removing distractions like entertainment. At times I even feel unsure what further shift in understanding would actually look like. I've occasionally experienced states of seclusion from sensuality when abstaining from entertainment for extended periods, accompanied by a kind of steady and collected thinking, secluded from sensuality, which sometimes seems similar to how the suttas describe jhāna. But even with experiences like that, I'm not sure how they relate to genuine progress on the path.

So I suppose my underlying question is simply whether my perspective here is missing something important about the nature of virtue or about what insight into the Four Noble Truths actually involves.

I would very much appreciate any clarification or correction if my understanding here is mistaken.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-03-05 05:58:37

> So I'm curious why celibacy is often emphasized as being "more important" than entertainment, when it seems possible that things like entertainment and distraction could themselves be a major obstacle to insight into the Four Noble Truths or stream entry.

The fact that celibacy is more important than abstaining from entertainment doesn't make the latter unimportant. It just means that for the person starting with neither, celibacy should be the priority.

You can regard sexuality as the coarsest and most ensnaring form of entertainment.

> So I'm wondering whether this kind of situation would generally be considered a meaningful foundation of virtue, or whether without properly understanding the precepts from the start one would still need to essentially begin again from a more basic level.

It's a meaningful foundation if the abstinence comes from recognizing the peril of misconduct for yourself, such that you wouldn't engage in it even when there is an allure in it (you are not just jaded or depressed on a bodily level) and even when given full permission by every authority you follow.

> I'm curious whether virtue established in this kind of indirect or intuitive way could play a similar role, or whether proper understanding of why you are building virtue has to come, and THEN you start training in the 8 precepts, and THEN you can use that virtue as a basis for insight.

The understanding of the peril in non-virtue must become intuitive (the "charcoal pit" automatically *felt*). Otherwise it's just an idea that will not hold when it really matters.

> My other question concerns understanding the mind more deeply. Sometimes I find it difficult to imagine how seeing the "signs of the mind" could appear fundamentally different from how experience already presents itself now, aside from removing distractions like entertainment.

Look for anything that can still produce a sense of "drowning." One such thing might be not engaging with entertainment despite the pull to do so.

That sense of drowning arises because the fact that craving is the root of suffering has not been sufficiently understood, so whatever solution the mind expects is not truly a solution—it's inadvertently pandering to one craving or the other. Either craving to indulge in something specific, or the non-specific indulgence in distraction.

## Some thoughts and reflections on my difficulties with keeping the precepts

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: spiffyhandle *2026-03-04 16:24:27*

I see a few ways to learn to keep them. My goal is living by seven precepts plus watching intentions to see danger in the slightest fault.

The first way is jumping straight to keeping seven precepts all the time and watching intentions. A person is expected to fail a lot but this is the most ambitious standard. This is what I started with. I broke the precepts over and over and eventually it felt like I was lying to myself when I told myself that I will keep them.

The second is taking one's current level of precepts, which for me is the five, and adding on it incrementally. Take the smallest change one can do and let that stick.

When that is solid, add the next smallest change. Then, when one is keeping all seven precepts, add in virtue (danger in the slightest fault).

That approach is what I am trying now. And I am not sure it is easier than doing it all at once. The problem with doing it all at once, is I feel like I'm lying to myself because I'm breaking the precepts all the time. But, the advantage of the all at once approach is the system is self-reinforcing. Keeping celibacy, no entertainments, no beautification, time restricted eating, and watching intentions all support each other. If you can get it going.

When a person only keeps celibacy, misconduct increases in entertainments. When a person keeps celibacy and entertainments, misconduct increases in food. IME. So there is a natural benefit to keeping all the precepts at once, from the start.

One problem with with doing precepts little by little is there are large gaps in my conduct and I rely on willpower. When I don't practice seeing danger in the slightest fault and just work on obeying the rules, I am undermining my practice to a degree. I tried watching my intentions only in regards to the spirit of the rule I was keeping and that was not good. I was training myself to see craving but deliberately allow myself to act out if it. For example, I might gorge on ice cream because it's not against the rules I'd taken while at the same time noticing that I was choosing to act on greed. But then in a different situation I might tell myself with *this* precept, I need to not act of of greed, but it made things confusing and ambiguous.

Overall, it's quite discouraging by how difficult it is to take up the renunciant precepts. I've added in journaling and self-reflection (https://youtu.be/7gx5kArzdVI)..) And I'm making my environment more suitable by reducing electronics consumption. I think this second approach of just keeping one extra precept at a time, in my case, celibacy, and building gradually has potential. However, it is so slow. It's really quite surprising how difficult this is. If you had asked me, I wouldn't have thought of myself as a particularly horny person. I never did hookup apps, and was genuinely celibate for two years. But there is such a massive difference between being celibate while knowing there's an end date and doing it for life.

In the past, I was pretty successful with the no entertainment precept. I gave up video games, music, movies, TV, books, and so on. But, I did it in the wrong order as I wasn't celibate. So I am hopeful that if I can finally figure out celibacy, the rest of the precepts will be easier.

EDIT:

One thing that helped was this video by a former addict and former MMA fighter Bas Rutten - https://youtu.be/VFyN-2MW2FI

Any comments, observations, judgements, on my practice, or reflections on your own practice are welcome.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-03-05 06:33:19

> In the past, I was pretty successful with the no entertainment precept. I gave up video games, music, movies, TV, books, and so on. But, I did it in the wrong order as I wasn't celibate. So I am hopeful that if I can finally figure out celibacy, the rest of the precepts will be easier.

An approach that might work is seeing the danger in the slightest fault, but specifically within five precepts + celibacy. So for now, you wouldn't regard it as a fault to consume entertainment as long as it doesn't arouse any sexual intentions. But you have to remain watchful of your mental state and be ready to stop despite the pressure if those intentions ever come up from the content you are consuming (or from any activity in general).

## Chinese Parallel to Kālāma Sutta

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Formal_Breath_2026 *2026-02-27 23:25:44*

Has anyone mentioned this Chinese parallel to the Kālāma Sutta before? The first part of the sutta mentions how greed, aversion, and delusion cause one to break the 5 precepts, similar to the Pāli version. But in the section directly preceding the brahmavihāras, it mentions abandoning abrahmacariya (非梵行) alongside the standard grouping of killing, stealing, lying, and various other kinds of wrong speech. It also mentions purifying the mind of abrahmacariya, lust, and longing for the possessions of others. This passage is not in the Pāli, which goes straight to cultivating the brahmavihāras after greed, aversion, delusion and the 5 precepts. Perhaps an interesting basis for further research? I wonder if there are other Chinese suttas in which the Buddha talks about celibacy to lay-people, or in which celibacy is a standard pre-requisite for brahmavihāras.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-28 05:51:42

> Perhaps an interesting basis for further research? I wonder if there are other Chinese suttas in which the Buddha talks about celibacy to lay-people, or in which celibacy is a standard pre-requisite for brahmavihāras.

Yes, I've come across many similar instances. For instance the parallel of MN 97 (MĀ 27) mentions not only that brahmavihāra involves abandoning desire and sensual thoughts, but that the brahmin Dhanañjāni succeeded in it as part of a change of direction that began with renouncing his wife.

Another one is the parallel of MN 41 (SĀ 1042) which specifies "pure precepts" and "a mind free from desire" as requirements not only for all samādhi attainments but also all noble attainments.

# How to clearly see the first noble truth?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: MajesticPurpose5622 *2026-02-27 19:56:37*

///

Hello, it has been a few months since i started my practice. It has become, by far, the most important thing in my life and stays at least in the back of my mind at all times.

Im currently stablishing myself in virtue and practicing sense restraint, using my free time to contemplate on the nature of my existence and the teachings.

However, my mind constantly harasses me with questions and doubts about why am i doing this in the first place, i feel as if i constantly have to explain to it the purpose i have found on the practice.

I have seen the video talking exactly about how to deal with a doubtful mind and im currently taking those steps, but one thing keeps me confused.

When i question myself about my intentions with this practice, i dont see “freedom from suffering” as the first reason. Instead i think that i wish to find the best possible way to live my life, and that has happened to be in the buddhist practice.

Im beggining to understand the unsatisfactory nature of sense desires, hence i do not wish to rely on them for my satisfaction/hapinnes, and this has been the primary reason why im doing what im doing.

When i think of my main goal with this, i think about findind unconditioned and true satisfaction with my life, wich cannot be obtained through craving and satisfying my craving, but i have to make an repetitive effort to think about Dukkha.

I wonder if my practice is rooted in the right reasons. If not, how can i see things more clearly?

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-28 05:19:28

Whether you focus on wanting better satisfaction or not wanting dissatisfaction doesn’t really matter, since either way the need for striving is recognized.

What’s more important is to remain transparent about what is taking you away from the right satisfaction and toward suffering (i.e., your own actions), so that you don’t start thinking that you can get to the right satisfaction through some kind of shortcut.

# How can one understand various fruitions through Ahjan's analogy?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: account-7 *2026-02-27 18:26:45*

I found the video Don't open Mara's doors incredibly helpful and clarifying. Namely, the analogy of "opening the door" when there are people knocking outside in relation to acting out of pressure was incredibly useful to me.

I'm only wondering how one would define various levels of attainment relative to that image.

Would an arhat not even have the conception of a door anymore? Or is it more that the knocking on the door (avoiding or opening it) has absolutely no pull on them anymore?

Would a stream entrant never open the door and just feel intensely pressured to open it, or would they still occasionally open it if what was on the other side was particularly seductive? In the latter case, what would differentiate a stream entrant's relationship to the door from a puthujjanas?

Thank you for your time.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-28 05:37:34

> Would an arhat not even have the conception of a door anymore? Or is it more that the knocking on the door (avoiding or opening it) has absolutely no pull on them anymore?

The latter. Avoidance is its own door, so you could simply say that an Arahant has no inclination to open any door that is knocked on, having fully understood that *because* there is knocking, whatever is on the other side can only be a further nuisance.

Their citta has understood that all the way, so they don't need to make any effort to remember it.

> Would a stream entrant never open the door and just feel intensely pressured to open it, or would they still occasionally open it if what was on the other side was particularly seductive? In the latter case, what would differentiate a stream entrant's relationship to the door from a puthujjanas?

A sotāpanna has the same understanding, but it hasn't sunk in to the same degree. They cannot open the worst doors again, since that requires full-on delusion, but they still need to make effort to maintain what for the Arahant is effortless.

# Two Questions on Paticcasamuppada

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: thereof_be_silent *2026-02-26 02:58:44*

1. Does discerning the structure happen in a gradual way or in a sudden way?

It seems like it should be gradual because through the gradual training and restraint, i.e. as a basis is developed, one can see “more” of their craving, or rather see more of its scope. And thus one can see more of the dependency/simultaneity between the craving and the feeling it has as its basis.

But on the other hand, I suspect that **seeing** even a little of the dependence/ simultaneity necessarily entails seeing the entire structure concretely.

Relatedly:

2. After being settled in the precepts at the bodily and verbal level, should one try to discern the simultaneity on each ”instance“ of craving, while also generally aiming for mental purity?

Or should one hold off until one is settled at the mental level, where the mind is dry enough that a single sentence single is sufficient?

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-28 04:38:26

1. Gradually (AN 8.19).
2. If you’re keeping tabs on the mental states driving your actions (which implies not performing unwholesome ones) then you are already discerning the “structure” where it actually is.

# practice question

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Formal_Breath_2026 *2026-02-21 17:59:59*

Sometimes recently my mind has been trying to convince me that things which I have ascertained (to the best of my ability) are not motivated by an unwholesome intention are actually unwholesome, maybe by pointing to some surface-level grey area in which they may correspond to the boundaries set by the precepts. The problem here is not that the thought that accuses me of doing something unwholesome is unpleasant, which I know I just have to endure, but the fact that the thought appears is what makes me doubt whether I’m actually lying to myself or misjudging whether the action is unwholesome. Sort of like I feel if my actions were truly blameless, I wouldn’t have these thoughts blaming me in the first place. It disturbs my clarity about my intentions, because the doubt and anxiety upsets my composure, and then I worry that that loss of composure points to the action itself actually

being unwholesome. Is there any good way to know for certain that I'm not deceiving myself about whether something is unwholesome? The thing is that, when I first started practicing virtue, I feel like I actually had these doubtful thoughts less, and that they have actually ramped up since my virtue has improved and become more consistent. Like, since I have actually become less capable of lying to myself, my mind accuses me of lying to myself more, if that makes sense? I am not sure if the fact that my mind is still moved by doubt and fear about somehow 'accidentally' doing something unwholesome points to a lack of internal clarity about never breaking the precepts that still needs to be developed, or if it is just a separate stage of fear/doubt that needs to be overcome on its own. Is this over-questioning your own virtue just another way that Māra ramps up the difficulty of the practice? (only half-joking here). I hope this makes sense

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-22 11:21:20

> Sort of like I feel if my actions were truly blameless, I wouldn't have these thoughts blaming me in the first place.

That's a trap. Of course, the fact that those thoughts grip you means that *something* is off, but that doesn't mean that the mistake is what the thoughts are telling you it is. Those accusations can easily be baseless and irrational.

> Is there any good way to know for certain that I'm not deceiving myself about whether something is unwholesome? The thing is that, when I first started practicing virtue, I feel like I actually had these doubtful thoughts less, and that they have actually ramped up since my virtue has improved and become more consistent. Like, since I have actually become less capable of lying to myself, my mind accuses me of lying to myself more, if that makes sense?

First of all, ask yourself if you have broken a precept (i.e., did something aiming for one of those results even if it didn't actually happen). If you haven't, then the impurity there is the pressure of remorse, which blames the past to seek relief from the suffering that is there now.

If you have broken a precept, then still, you are suffering now because of craving you have now, but then you also have to recognize that you won't be able to abandon that present craving unless you abstain from such actions from now onwards.

## MN 43's Parato Ghoso Usage of right view,

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: upasakatrainee *2026-02-11 08:49:07*

Bhante u/Bhikkhu_Anigha, may I request some clarification on MN 43's reference to two conditions for the arising of right view: parato ghoso and yoniso manasikāra.

My current understanding (which may be mistaken) is that this refers to the arising of right view as a conditionally dependent factor, not yet the irreversible Dhamma-eye associated with stream entry. My observations are as follows:

MN 43 presents parato ghoso and yoniso manasikāra as *conditions* (paccayā) for the arising (uppādāya) of right view. This suggests something dependent and contingent (arisen), rather than something already structurally irreversible — which is what the opening of the Dhamma eye (i.e capitalized Right View is). I also noticed that in your translation you have used the un-capitalized 'right view', so perhaps this was intentional to refer to something apart from the supramundane attainment?

If these two were sufficient for the decisive and irreversible vision, then hearing correct Dhamma and attending appropriately would seem to guarantee noble entry "then and there." But the suttas elsewhere imply that right view can fail to arise even when the right Dhamma is heard AND yoniso manasikāra is present, due to resistance or remaining obstruction (e.g. The Buddha declaring that King Ajātasattu, had it not been for his patricide, would have in fact entered the stream)

Although verbs of "arising" (e.g., *cakkhum udapādi* in SN 56.11) are used for awakening itself, that alone doesn't seem to settle the issue. The decisive factor seems to be what is being described and how it functions structurally, rather than the morphology of the verb.

The suttas often speak of right view arising in a conditional sense prior to noble entry, whereas the Dhamma-eye or irreversible vision is described with additional language such as "fixed in destiny," "no longer liable," etc. MN 43 lacks that irreversible framing.

Based on these, it seems to me that MN 43 is pointing to the necessary conditions for right view to arise in a still-dependent sense, rather than directly describing the decisive and irreversible breakthrough. So in that sense, they are necessary but not sufficient conditions (sufficiency coming with the removal of what obstructs)

Is this distinction valid? Or should MN 43 instead be understood as referring directly to the irreversible establishment of Right View that marks entry into the noble individuals?

I would be grateful for correction if this framing is misguided. Thank you!

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-11 16:41:58

> I also noticed that in your translation you have used the un-capitalized 'right view', so perhaps this was intentional to refer to something apart from the supramundane attainment?

No, that wasn't intentional. I wouldn't make such a distinction on my own, nor try to find a justification for it the Suttas.

I don't see why right view having conditions implies that it is reversible. Arahantship depends on plenty of conditions, yet it is irreversible.

> If these two were sufficient for the decisive and irreversible vision, then hearing correct Dhamma and attending appropriately would seem to guarantee noble entry "then and there."

Yes, it would. The catch is that one has no stable internal reference point to distinguish *yoniso* from *ayoniso*, nor the accuracy of an utterance, until after right view. At the same time, what needs to be done is clear: establishing the mind in virtue and abandoning passion for sensuality is what makes one's attention *yoniso*. Hence the stock passage preceding the attainment of stream-entry.

> But the suttas elsewhere imply that right view can fail to arise even when the right Dhamma is heard AND yoniso manasikāra is present, due to resistance or remaining obstruction (e.g. The Buddha declaring that King Ajātasattu, had it not been for his patricide, would have in fact entered the stream)

Having killed his father meant that King Ajātasattu couldn't have *yoniso manasikāra*, at least not sufficiently. Extending the right utterance of another—that all actions based on defilements are unwholesome and unjustifiable—to the right level (where nothing is excluded) will evoke in such a person a level of remorse that is impossible to bear. He had to continue regarding what he did was to some extent excusable (wrong view) in order to maintain his sanity.

It's for the same reason that the mind needs to lose its passion for sensuality for right view to arise. While still being passionate for something, let alone pursuing it, the fact that one's passion is actually the very source of one's suffering cannot sink in. The mind will reject the right view because it has something against it that it needs to protect.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-12 07:57:02 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> I can extrapolate that this applies not only to sensuality (sensual passion) but to aversion as well — insofar as both are forms of passion toward feeling.

Yes, but not as a separate aspect. If you're truly undermining all your passions, aversion has no foothold whatsoever. Hence the Buddha often using the word "passion" (or "delight") to encompass every potential defilement.

> That makes yoniso far more existential and less technical than I had been subtly treating it.

Absolutely. Yoniso manasikāra is a result of the citta being tamed and pliable, not

something anyone can do by following a protocol. Passion structurally carries ignorance.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-12 08:02:14 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Since the “utterance of another”, i.e the right instructions have basically been heard countless times by this point I assume that one wouldn’t necessarily be actively “trying” to get the right view.

In the sense of reflecting on what one has heard, no, not always. But it’s also not something you can preemptively decide.

When clarity about the practice is fading, you have to revisit the right instructions (mentally at least).

## Beauty, Ugliness, Danger in the Body

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Seekfinderin *2026-02-09 23:38:53*

In the last weeks I was reading more and more Suttas and articles and listened to many talks and almost everything I read or listened to, and the more I did so, seemed to make sense and be very logical and convincing to me. But I have a very hard time to understand the way how you seem to look at the human body and why. I remember this Sutta, that is also quoted often in your talks, where apparently Buddha said about a princess or some girl that he would not touch her even with his feet, because, apparently that was so disgusting in his view, even though in the eyes of most others she was probably beautiful.

Then I hear you, when talking about the body, about it being that sack of flesh and blood and excrements and urine. I don’t understand that. It makes some sense to me and I am trying to reflect about it, that some things, actions, thoughts etc., that I consider desireable may not be so desireable from a more complete, neutral, clarified point of view. But in regard to this description of the body this feels to me as if you just try to look at it in this disgusted way for some reason by choice, and it seems to be very abstract to me. Because in fact and according to what I see this body is not that ugly, dirty, filthy thing. Yes, there is something like that within it, within its organs, but all that is quite in order, functions well, is surrounded by smooth skin, held together in that form, can move very elegantly and softly. When you talk about it, it sounds as if you are seeing a body when it is exploded on the floor like in a crime scene. When I reflect on this I don’t see why I should imagine something like that as it is so far away from how the body of a living human being is usually appearing?

Of course, if I would have such a negative view of the body, it would be much easier to restrain the senses and not desire to touch other bodies etc. But right now, to be

honest, and please correct me, if I am wrong, it seems to me as if you just consciously cultivate such a disgust for the body in order to get rid of sensuality/sexual urges, without this having a basis in regular experience of human bodies?

To get to the point: Maybe someone can explain to me how such a disgust for the body evolves and why? And why that may be necessary or a natural occurence on that path. I don't get it. While so many explanations convince me and help me withdrawing more and more, this particular area is very confusing to me.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-10 05:59:28

> But in regard to this description of the body this feels to me as if you just try to look at it in this disgusted way for some reason by choice, and it seems to be very abstract to me.

Emphasizing ugliness is certainly a choice, yet no less so than emphasizing beauty is. It's just because in the beginning one is so used to (and pressured towards making) the latter choice that it feels like it happens on its own.

> When I reflect on this I don't see why I should imagine something like that as it is so far away from how the body of a living human being is usually appearing?

You don't need to, and that's not what the Buddha described. He said you reflect on the organs of "this very body" as you would be reviewing a sack containing different types of grains and beans. So rather than an abstract "bodies can become like that", it's "*my* body *already is* like this." And that is undeniable. It may feel *unnecessary* to think about it, but that's something else (and it's the pull towards delusion).

> But right now, to be honest, and please correct me, if I am wrong, it seems to me as if you just consciously cultivate such a disgust for the body in order to get rid of sensuality/sexual urges, without this having a basis in regular experience of human bodies?

If you reflect properly as above (rather than taking asubha as a mechanical "meditation object") it does have a basis in your own experience all the time. And that is why it would *uproot* sensuality, not just push it aside.

Though you may not realize it, you (*choose to*) relate to your own body as an instrument for pleasure all the time. Particular sensual desires are just the byproduct of that. Asubha is meant to change that deeper relationship with the body. Replacing sensual thoughts with shock reactions changes nothing fundamental.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-10 16:42:36 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> But all of these things are things that were in one short moment or will happen at some point in the future etc.

The point is that asubha is not about future possibilities. The body can reach such levels of "shocking" unattractiveness in the first place because of the unattractive aspects (blood, flesh, waste-producing glands) that it already has *now,* while it is factually young, healthy, good-smelling, etc.

You need to recognize the unattractiveness *within* the beauty; otherwise you'll indeed just be covering up the good parts in order to fabricate a "dispassion" that is not even genuine and will not last.

## Questions on Contemplating

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: ConditionOwn3429 *2026-02-08 12:04:19*

Could you clarify what contemplating the danger in sensuality really means? I hear this flying around alot, but I have yet to fully grasp what it means. Does it require a prerequisite, like virtue and sense-restraint? And how do you actually, practically do it? It would be really helpful if you could also provide an example.

For context, I've been reading a section of The only way to jhana, chapter 8: The pleasure of boredom in this chapter, Ajahn says "Practically speaking, boredom is a good way to practise. People don't see boredom as an indicator, and certainly don't see delusion as an attitude that they cultivate, despite commitment to precepts, sutta study, and contemplation. " (p. 88) and "For example, if you decide to allow yourself to get bored: switch off your phone, close the doors and curtains, put away your books, switch off the television, don't do your meditation technique—then, it doesn't matter whether you sit, walk, stand or lay down—just abide in that non-activity. The mind will certainly be presenting you with something to do, which is fine—you don't need to try to get rid of those thoughts, you just don't act upon them" (p. 89). This is what I'm doing, and something that I've encountered along the way was that I impulsively daydream, and I can't control it. It's not that I can't resist the desire to daydream, the daydream in it of itself just appears without my consent.

Now how is this related to what I'm talking about? I've heard from one of the Hillside Hermitage videos that one should contemplate when pressured by "unwholesome states". So how I see it is that:

- My daydreams are to entertain me when I'm bored

- Daydreaming is an unwholesome act (it contains unwholesome thoughts of desire and pleasure)

- You should contemplate when you're pressured by unwholesome states

- You should contemplate on your daydreams.

So I understand now that I should contemplate when I unwillingly daydream, but how do I do that? In the same chapter, I read "all you need to do is to not entertain it (the mind) and establish the context of the danger, if what it offers is unwholesome and sensual." (p. 87) yes, but what does that mean? I don't understand. "You can develop the perception of danger or the perception of abandoning in regard to those thoughts (of sensuality, ill-will) so that while the mind is presenting those thoughts of sensuality, you are not wanting them, and are abandoning them because they are dangerous" (p. 87) I'm not sure where to go from here.

I would appreciate it if you could clarify my question, or debunk some of my thinking. Thanks in advance.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-09 06:02:36

> So I understand now that I should contemplate when I unwillingly daydream

If your bodily and verbal actions are contained by the precepts and not partaking in sensuality and ill-will anymore, then yes.

What you contemplate is the danger in any behaviors of sensual or hateful nature that your mind still delights in even though you have thoroughly given them up outwardly.

You don't try to deny the potential gratification of those actions; you're simply highlighting the drawbacks that the mind wants to look away from even though they are far greater in magnitude than the gratification.

The effect of that is not necessarily immediate. The momentum towards ignoring the danger (built up by careless behavior from before) has to wear away before the recognition of the danger feels palpable and the mind genuinely "accepts" it.

## Questioning Hillside Hermitage based on the Suttas: "All the Defilements", Sutta MN2

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Representative-Age18 *2026-01-27 19:10:50*

Foreword: I felt semi convinced after watching 20+ hours of HH videos, and I think they do have a lot of good points that deserve attention. There's obviously a lot of intelligence, dedication and knowledge to be found here. Therefore I decided to take a deep dive into the Suttas to clearify my position. Here's something I'd love to hear discussed:

In MN2: *All the defilements*, the buddha says: “Some defilements should be given up by seeing, some by restraint, some by using, some by enduring, some by avoiding, some by dispelling, and some by developing.”

It does not say “All defilements should be given up by restraint and endurance”.

Now, here is the sentence that I would assume HH followers would really stick to:

“Mendicants, I say that the ending of defilements is for one who knows and sees, not for one who does not know or see”.

HH states that this means you have to be a Sottapanna.

The Buddha always, in the rest of the suttas, describe Sottapannas with words such as: “for one who has entered the stream”, “for a noble disciple”, “for one with the noble right view”. When clearly describing a sottapanna, he is never vague about it. There is not one example about this. The Buddha, as the AMAZING teacher he was, NEVER clearly described a sottapanna without using EXPLICIT words. I repeat, there is not ONE example of this. He is either totally explicit, or using diagnostic criteria. The Buddha is always very clear and upright in the Suttas, so it confuses me as to why he would describe a Sottapanna with vague terms like “for one who knows and sees”, which is so much more vague than simply “for one with the noble right view” or “for one who was entered the stream”. In the video on this Sutta by HH, he justifies it using his logic, but never once questions why the Buddha in this exact sutta is using vague wording, while every other time he speaks of Sottapanna, he uses clear, exclusive wording. Nyanamoli Thero makes the exact mistake that he warns about himself: he gets into the details of the logic that pertains to what he think is mentioned, but he forgets the peripheral context: that the Buddha is always clear and straightforward in his speech, not cryptic.

Secondly, he says “Mendicants, I say that the ending of defilements is for one who knows and sees(...)“. He does not say”The continuation of the ending of defilements is for the one who knows and sees”. It is also kind of paradoxical - why would he exclude the removal of defilements to Sottapannas only. It’s a general statement. So a person who is not a Sottapanna cannot start to end their defilements? The way I would interpret it is that the startingpoint in the journey to begin ending your defilements begins with a rational mind, not swayed by emotions such as “I don’t want this to be true because of x,y,z”.

The common interpretation about “for one who knows and sees” (...) that application of irrational thoughts give rise to defilements (hope, prayer, not using logic, or just plain non-rational thinking), however, one who sees is someone who looks at reality rationally, logically and applying their mind in such a way. Ie. you are open to look at reality unbiased and logically. Not that you need to have supramundane insight into reality.

But let’s give HH the benefit of the doubt, and assume that what he really meant was that the prerequisite for removal of defilements using these 7 methods are only to

be attempted by Sottapannas. Or we can give them the benefit of the doubt, however to a slightly smaller degree and say that “one who knows and sees” does mean sottapanna, without that actually making this a clear prerequisite in the sutta. It could definitely still mean “the total destruction of defilement is only attained after sottapanna”, that does not read the same as “these following methods will only work for sottapannas”.

Problem 1. Assumption by HH: “You have to be a Sottapanna to practice”some by seeing, some by restraint, some by using, some by enduring, some by avoiding, some by dispelling, and some by developing” (MN2) ” So you already have to be a Sottapanna to practice restrain and endurance, the exact methods that HH teach is the way to Sottapanna itself? How do you become a Sottapanna if you cannot apply senserestraint until after you have become a Sottapanna? HH clearly state that a prerequisite for using these 7 methods as means to lessen defilements, is already being a Sottapanna - so how do you become a Sottapanna then, without restrain, seeing, or endurance?

Problem 2. At the end of the first method proposed by the Buddha to remove defilements (Seeing) we have this statement: And as they do so, they give up three fetters: substantialist view, doubt, and misapprehension of precepts and observance of rites and rituals. These are called the defilements that should be given up by seeing.

So a sutta aimed at only Sottapannas is an instruction of how you can become a Sottapanna? Ehm, what?

Now, you can discuss “wise attention” and what it really means all you want, but that doesn’t take away from the context that this whole sutta doesn’t make sense at all if it is only aimed at Sottapannas. That’s the first argument. The second one is that the Buddha was always abundantly clear when he talked about a Sottapanna, never vague.

Just to make sure; the sutta also is not a linear progression, like you should have use seeing first, then restraint, then using etc. This is obvious, as you can’t do one without the other. You can’t get rid of the defilements using the method of seeing very well, while not restraining yourself at least a little bit for example.

# What MN 2 actually recommends (if we give the benefit of the doubt and call “knowing and seeing”=sottapanna)

MN 2 teaches:

- **All practitioners** must learn:
  - what to attend to
  - what not to attend to
  - which method fits which defilement
- **Without right understanding**, practice is often misapplied
- **(With supramundane right view**, practice becomes fully effective and irreversible So the sutta is:

—not a gated manual usable only after awakening.

Please enlighten me

Edit: you guys keep saying there's right restraint (after sottapanna) and wrong restraint (befoe). However, it doesn't change the fact that the Buddha, in this very sutta, also recommends the methods of abandoning and developing alongside restraint and endurance, not seperating them. He doesn't say: do only restraint and endurance until you become sottapanna, then do the rest of the methods. He says: you use all the 7 methods here (including restraint and endurance, and including abandoning and dev), and you try your best, but none of them will work FULLY until you have right view. He DOES NOT tell you to only use restraint and endurance and that development can only be done after sottapanna.

Another good point:

By user: Edit: also, this part doesn't make sense to me: "And what are the influxes that should be abandoned by avoiding? Take a bhikkhu who, reflecting in light of the origin, avoids a wild elephant, a wild horse, a wild ox, a wild dog, a snake, a stump, thorny ground, a pit, a cliff, a swamp, and a sewer. Reflecting in light of the origin, he avoids sitting on inappropriate seats, walking in inappropriate neighborhoods, and mixing with bad friends—whatever wise fellow renunciates would take to be an unsuitable setting. For the influxes, trouble, and affliction that would arise in someone who abides without avoiding these things do not arise when they are avoided. These are called the influxes that should be abandoned by avoiding."

Why is either grasping of the sign of the mind or right view needed to avoid dangerous things? This seems like a part where yoniso as "rational" actually fits.

My view on this is that again, anything you do after yoniso will actually and effectively rid defilements - doesn't mean you should not practice before yoniso. So similar to how the buddha wants you to avoid a wild elephant, you should on the same level practice abandoning and developing. There's no prerequisite to avoid getting killed by elephant, and there's no prerequisite to practice abandonment and developing.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-28 05:09:15

The distinction is between practicing restraint and endurance, which anyone can do in theory, and successfully *abandoning defilements* by doing so. A puthujjana can and has to practice restraint, but that restraint will itself be tainted by defilements as long as they're a puthujjana, so cultivating it further will not lead to Nibbāna. Hence it's not what is being described in the Sutta.

So, rather than taking restraint as a "method" that is already correct, a puthujjana would keep continually questioning their ideas about what restraint is (and you can only meaningfully upgrade your understanding of something if you're also doing it). That's how they would move closer to *yoniso manasikāra.*

The same point is found in AN 2.11:

> "There are, bhikkhus, these two powers. What two? The power of reflection and the power of development. And what, bhikkhus, is the power of reflection? It's when someone reflects: 'Misconduct of body, speech, or mind has a bad, painful result in both the present and the future.' Reflecting like this, they give up misconduct of body, speech, and mind, and develop good conduct of body, speech, and mind, keeping themselves pure. This is called the power of reflection.
>
> And what, bhikkhus, is the power of development? In this context, the power of development is the power of the trainees. **For relying on the power of a trainee, one gives up passion, aversion, and delusion.** Having given up passion, aversion, and delusion, one doesn't do anything unwholesome, or engage in anything harmful. This is called the power of development. These are the two powers."

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-28 06:00:23 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> This sutta makes it abundantly clear that abandoning and developing is also recommended for puthujjana's.

It explicitly says that a puthujjana fails at practicing yoniso manasikāra.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-28 07:00:11 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> it also says you will fail at restraint and endurance, it doesn't say you don't do any of them.

We're not saying that either, as you have yourself noted.

> Regardless, you don't have a strong enough position here to tell me or anyone to stop practicing meditation (partly abandoning and developing)

You're misunderstanding the point. What you're describing as "meditation" is not abandoning and developing to begin with, neither before nor after right view. It's simply distraction. So the need to give up of meditation techniques has nothing to do with enforcing right view as a prerequisite. It's to do with at least *trying* to practice abandoning and developing, which is how you could eventually attain right view.

> Also, regarding avoiding: does avoiding a wild elephant to not get killed also ONLY work and is it only supposed to be applies after right view?

As a means of abandoning defilements, it does.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-28 07:33:36 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Anyways, I've said all my points and I've said more than enough on this. It's taking too much time away from my life now, and I gotta put the computer away, so I'll leave it at this: thank you engaging in discussion with the lay community. I highly appreciate and regard the effort to actually speak to us directly. And thank you for the discussion. May you all be well, peaceful and attain true happiness, with metta - Erik

Sure, I also don't think this is going anywhere.

> none of these methods will rid defilements completely unless done with yoniso, but that doesnMt mean you shouldnt do it.

For the record, our point is that you are describing as "wholesome" *is* ayoniso in its very nature, whether one is a puthujjana or not. So "doing it with yoniso" is an inherent contradiction.

## Essays in book format?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: ghfph *2026-01-25 06:21:28*

I read awhile ago that Bhikkhu Anigha's essays may be published in a paper book format.

Is there any news on this? I'm planning to rid myself of unnecessary technology (laptop and ereader), for kusala reasons, but would still like to re-read Venerable Anigha's essays.

Can I provide any help in proofreading or editing while I still have a laptop?

Thanks, 🙏

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-26 05:17:13

I'm working on the book currently.

As for getting rid of technology, it's worth questioning your reasons for doing that. If it's because you can't control yourself and keep breaking the precepts when you have access to it, then it's fine to get rid of it until that's no longer the case. But if it's not that, it might be rooted in trying to avoid the practice in the name of "peace" (not having to face doubt regarding your intentions for using technology).

# Question on “Definitive Guide to Seeing Your Mind” Dhamma Talk

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: CutnSkratch317 *2026-01-22 21:28:22*

Venerables and HH community,

Thank you for sharing this video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Hd9WZzxqAkE ()). I found it extremely informative and clarifying for my practice.

I have a question regarding Ajahn’s point that one must first understand the signs of the mind by enduring, and that only once the mind is understood can “the King be fed” — otherwise, one is simply acting out of aversion or greed for a different mind state.

Here is how I currently understand this, and I would appreciate correction if I am mistaken:

Suppose an angry mind has arisen. I recognize that anger is present, and through practice I understand the dangers and consequences of an angry mind. In that case, is it appropriate to intentionally cultivate mettā (as an example) to counterbalance the anger based on that understanding - rather than out of a desire to get rid of the anger? Or would this still be considered a subtle form of aversion?

I can see how, through understanding the mind and its inclinations, abandoning it becomes easier on its own. At the same time, it seems that knowing how an angry mind operates and inclines might make it skillful to cultivate a counter-state, if such cultivation is appropriate.

Thank you very much for your time and for all that you offer to the community.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-24 09:01:03

> Suppose an angry mind has arisen. I recognize that anger is present, and through practice I understand the dangers and consequences of an angry mind. In that case, is it appropriate to intentionally cultivate mettā (for example) to counterbalance the anger on the basis of that understanding, rather than out of a desire to get rid of the anger? Or would this still amount to a subtle form of aversion?

The implication that cultivating mettā is a separate undertaking from recognizing the presence of anger, etc., suggests that it remains a form of aversion or management. Even if you do not think of it as trying to get rid of the anger, you are still just “turning the page” on it rather than addressing its causes, much like distracting yourself with a worldly unrelated activity. That does nothing to alter the underlying tendency toward aversion when attention is *not* being closely managed, which is precisely the only time that counts as a criterion for development (AN 5.200).

*Mettā* is the natural result of the absence of aversion. It is no more contrived than the friendliness you already experience towards people for whom you have no ill-will (which are the majority) By contrast, the common, misguided fabrication of mettā requires ignoring certain unpleasant aspects and selectively focusing on pleasant ones, and for as long as that's at all required, you're still just continuing to take ill-will for granted.

Hence, the ordinary friendliness of an undeveloped puthujjana toward *some* people is actually far closer to genuine *mettā* than what many Buddhists today take it to be. The difference between ordinary friendliness and the liberation of mind through *mettā* is simply that the latter is boundless/infinite. That's the same as saying that it involves no effort or even anchor, since anything conditioned by an activity implies the possibility of its absence under certain circumstances, hence it's not boundless. Mettā depends only on the absence of something, namely ill-will, and that absence is universal when the mind has been well cultivated.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-24 16:50:27 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> This sutta 5.200 contains the exact method that HH argues against,

Where? It talks about mettā, sure, but it doesn't vindicate the modern interpretations of what that means, which is what we criticize.

What I intended to highlight with that Sutta is that the actual escape from ill-will is when the mind doesn't want to go there even if you tried to send it there. Whereas the modern practices revolve around holding back the mind from what it still prefers by fabricating the opposite, without ever addressing the causes for why it in principle *could* want to go towards ill-will (or sensuality).

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-24 18:11:21 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> I agree that trying to use wholesome as a means of controlling the unwholesome, is just clinging.

That's not quite the point. The modern interpretation of mettā is just a cover-up, and cover-ups are themselves unwholesome. It's replacing ill-will with delusion, which is like switching the side of a cube you're facing while the cube remains equally close to your face.

> This is what I believe can quickly happen with non-resistance, non-doing, endurance methods: We understand that aversion to discomfort is the problem, but that we are supposed to not resist it. We end up mindlessly "thinking" and never really get objective perspective, it's just a perpetual thinking "Aversion", "I'm supposed to not let this aversion take over"

> "Now I'm controlling" "oh no I shouldn't control" "ok stop controlling" "ok allow even that to be", and maybe it stops. Also aversion becomes the center of gravity, like we know aversion is the problem, so we automatically start 1. subconsciously looking for aversion 2. We start identifying (clinging) to aversion. We end up kinda chasing displeasure to solve our aversion, but we are now identified to some extent to aversion.

That's what happens when even what we're describing is still being implemented as a mechanical technique. That tendency might take time to calm down, and those considerations aren't of much value anyway unless you're already fully steadied in the eight precepts. If you're not, you're not going to clearly see what any defilement is no matter how hard you try.

> For example: I can feel peaceful while feeling quite a lot of pain IF I stay mindful, ardent and fully aware, fully comprehending what is going on. However, if I just drift into the pain/aversion, I feel like I quickly identify with it and sink into more aversion.

Right, and the fact that the latter can still happen means that the mind is not being developed. No amount of time of cultivating such "mindfulness" will remove the need for itself. It's just learning how to cope, however successfully and skillfully, and never removing the causes for disturbance. In fact it makes the problem worse; if after getting used to that you have to face discomfort without crutches, you will be even less able to do so than before. Hence the Buddha said that a person who attains wrong liberation through wrong view … wrong samādhi is *worse* off on that account. It's not a "transitional stage" or a "skillful means." It's a complete deviation that requires you to unlearn everything you learned.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-24 18:56:23 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> You're essentially telling me that on account of that, I cannot even attain Sottapanna, and even that is contradicting the Buddha, as thousands of laypeople who indulged in sex, entertainement etc etc, did attain stream entry.

The Buddha did say that such activities are an obstruction to both right view and right *samādhi*. He also listed things that need to be given up in order to practice *satipaṭṭhāna*, and the things you mention are covered by the items in that list (AN 6.118). Elsewhere he said one can't progress in the Dhamma while maintaining delight in sensuality.

> In your view, from what I interpret, I'm better off just giving up meditation practice, unless I can follow all 8 precepts and probably also live in calm environment.

Yes, you should give up the meditation you've been doing so far and anything that re-

sembles it because it's actively taking you even further away from the right samādhi and peace. Giving it up will show you how your mind actually isn't tamed; how it still resists and craves for things just as strongly, if not worse, when you stop managing the scenery internally.

As for the eight precepts, it's not all or nothing.

First of all it's about being honest to yourself regarding what the goal is, i.e., freedom from craving, and the fact that you can't claim to be practicing towards that goal while you still engage in obvious acts of craving. That's probably not going to be all that obvious if you've been following contemporary teachings, and the precepts need to be supported by that simple but important recognition to be effective.

With that perspective, even though you might not be formally committed to the eight precepts all the time, there will be a lingering sense of shame each time you intentionally break them and remember your desire to train your mind, and that will allow you to grow in the precepts as quickly as you can handle. For some people that's overnight, for others it takes longer.

If you're not choosing entertainment yourself then that's not really a concern.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-26 05:32:46 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

That's a widespread misunderstanding.

If you have to shield and control your mind to prevent unwholesome reactions, it is not even temporarily liberated or composed. The need for suppression or redirection is itself a product of the hindrances. If that feels calming, it will be the same kind of "calm" produced by sensuality, which also depends on averting attention from what is unpleasant. Thus, it's wrong calm.

The notion that *samatha* can be developed independently of understanding is refuted by Suttas like AN 6.73 and AN 9.41.

> in order to come to the experiential understanding that clinging to ill-will is unproductive?

This supposed "experiential understanding" never actually comes. Anyone who relies on these practices neither has nor will reach a point where defilements cannot arise without them. That's because they are not just tangential; they actively manifest the same problem.

# Why is business/trading in meat & living beings Wrong Livelihood?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: ToLazyToPickName *2026-01-22 17:33:18*

If buying & eating meat is not wrong action, why is trading in meat & living beings wrong livelihood?

A cook who make a living off of cooking meat, a grocery store cashier, or a pet store owner who makes a living off of selling pets, why is that wrong livelihood but consuming the cooked meat or buying/having the pet is not wrong action?

I don't see how there is wrong intention in the livelihood of being a meat cooker or pet supplier. Maybe the meat cooker is encouraging more people to kill animals and the pet supplier is encouraging crueling towards animals? But then why isn't the end consumer also doing that?

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-24 04:49:33

> A cook who make a living off of cooking meat, a grocery store cashier, or a pet store owner who makes a living off of selling pets

Only the last one is wrong livelihood. Cooking meat and being a cashier at a general grocery store are too far removed from the act of killing to matter.

The issue is how gaining a living from these things carries a welcoming attitude towards the acts of killing and, with pets, undesired imprisonment. Even when you're not the one physically perpetrating either, internally your intentions are pointing in that direction to a degree simply by working in those industries.

With weapons and intoxicants, you'd be condoning the intended usage of those things by selling them (though not if you're a cashier where those are among many of the items sold and customers take them without your involvement).

Some people think that in buying meat you are also condoning killing, but that's a fabricated connection and not true in any sense that's relevant for the training of the mind. You can totally maintain the attitude that you would never intentionally kill a living being or encourage another to do so, even to save your own life, despite buying and consuming meat. That attitude is what you have to cultivate, and abstaining from meat as a rule contributes nothing to that per se. It usually takes away from it by distracting you.

The Buddha could've easily made at least monks vegetarian and thereby prevented a lot of meat purchasing. But not only did he not have that initiative; he explicitly refused when asked by Devadatta. It would've cemented a wrong view about what virtue is.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-26 04:34:51 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> To me, it seems like by relying on the death of animals to continue for their livelihood of selling or helping to sell meat

Because unless they're working directly with a butcher, the connection is abstract. They wouldn't have to be open to killing or encouraging another to kill in order to do it.

> Which jobs in the meat industry would be included in wrong livelihood besides the job of doing/commanding the killing?

It depends on the closeness of the association. If the job involves any dealings with the people who do the killing, it would be wrong livelihood. Not because you're explicitly telling them to kill, but because there is automatically going to be a sense of cooperation.

## Beautiful and Ugly ()

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Formal_Breath_2026 *2026-01-16 18:22:33*

I have heard Ajahn Ñānamoli say several times about how the ugly is a more fundamental context than the beautiful, and I was thinking about how to understand this concretely. What I have arrived at is that the ugly is more fundamental because that is exactly how sensuality is there at all — if things were more beautiful than ugly, it would just be a matter of avoiding the ugly; there would be no drive to go towards the beautiful. But it is the interplay between the signs/features of the beautiful and the broader context of the ugly — and the resulting *pressure* to engage with the beautiful — that makes sensual being (kāmabhava) what it is as opposed to a mere pleasant abiding (rūpabhava). This is why sensuality, being driven by that pressure to get away from the ugly, is always unwholesome, whereas material states (Jhānas) can be experienced wholesomely. This is also why sensuality is insatiable and unsatisfactory, as the ugly is always there 'waiting' as the broader context whenever the less fundamental beauty runs out. Similarly, if you were put in harsh enough conditions, you would start finding sensual appeal in less and less pleasant things, like an animal that enjoys eating filth. But when you develop the theme that whatever beauty in sensuality there is is only there because the broader context of the ugly gives it its appeal, it all becomes ugly and loses its pressure, and ironically that is what ultimately brings peace. The ugly is only a problem relative to the value you place in beauty, but when it's all ugly, it becomes basically neutral. The more I think about it, the more it seems to me that this interplay between the signs of the beautiful, and the broader context of the ugly, are what make up the entirety of human existence, and developing that context is also how one can surmount it.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-17 17:15:00

> The more I think about it, the more it seems to me that this interplay between the signs of the beautiful, and the broader context of the ugly, are what make up the entirety of human existence, and developing that context is also how one can surmount it.

Yes, exactly—granted one has stopped acting on desire for the beautiful no matter how invisible its more fundamental ugliness is.

The disgusting nature of your own body (the contemplation of organs often given in the Suttas) is the most acute and inescapable type of ugliness, but the principle extends to everything that you wouldn't want to look at because it would ruin your enjoyment/anticipation of something pleasant. Anything of that nature is by default more fundamental, since it's what stands out when desire isn't there to obscure it.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-17 16:59:29 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

The implication here that "jhāna is a subtler form of sensuality" is wrong. Jhāna definitionally is the complete cessation of sensuality (through dispassion, not replacement of objects).

There's no good reason to extend the word "sensuality" to everything.

## Practice advice

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Embarrassed-Box6857 *2026-01-15 11:04:55*

Hi everyone,

Looking for some guidance and correction regarding my practice. I have been living a semi-monastic life for the past year (seclusion, simplicity, minimal stimulation) and on the 8 precepts.

I've been practicing seriously for about a year overall(used to meditate earlier from mantra to open awareness or "do nothing" meditation ), but the last 1-2 months have been much more endurance based, basically dropping my meditation completely .

Current practice:

I have been at a monastery for about 50 days now and my main practice is avoiding acting out of cravings, aversion etc as much as possible. The days are often neutral/flat, I am fairly calm and used to living a restrained life without seeking much relief or stimulation.

What I notice changing after endurance :

• Cravings are weaker and less convincing

• Much greater tolerance of boredom, neutrality and less emotional reactivity overall

• Less interest in pleasure, anticipation, or planning

• Can be awake and inactive for long periods without panic

At the same time, there's dryness, grief for the past, and uncertainty. Relief feels largely unavailable, because i am not seeking it(yet at some level i still want it)but not in an urgent way, just a constant "ahh that would be nice". You could say a continuous dissatisfaction throughout.

I know endurance is not sufficient for right view/stream entry, and I'm unsure how to integrate contemplation correctly. So here are some questions to things I am trying to discern.

- How do I know whether I'm truly "letting things endure" versus just spacing out or passively waiting?

Im currently "aware" of my experience in a general sense without getting too absorbed in things. Its hard to discern whether I intentionally feed thoughts or fantasise(though my fantasies and interest in them has greatly reduced)its more like I let them do thier thing while I just "watch them". I still get fooled with the content from time to time and I can feel the confinement Ajahn talks about- everywhere my attention goes the thoughts etc follow and there is no "escape". I am not trying to move my attention to avoid them or anything. This would be enduring on the right level?

- Ajahn often emphasizes understanding the context (body sitting, feelings enduring) rather than content.

When I set the context to be mindful of my posture for example, i am supposed to bring up the knowledge that " I am sitting"- which i am aware of in the moment- however this knowledge is just a thought which im attending to, which wouldn't be the actual "body". And same with when i "recognise" i lost the context of the body, i will automatically think "oh i forgot about sitting". But thats also just a thought. As I understand this way I fail to even set the context in the first place and am just playing around with sense objects. How do i work with this?

- Should I reflect on danger/drawbacks, impermanence, etc? At times mind does takes on these topics(not to avoid anything specifically) and it's not just on an intellectual level, I am definitely able to feel the implications of my contemplation. But im still trying to discern when its appropriate, how often to do so etc.

For sense pleasures , ex- longing for something, how do i reflect on the danger in that? The danger must be independent of the content and of sense pleasures as a whole, or specifically relating to the thought? I am still at the stage where I am

just enduring and not steering the mind in the right direction towards dispassion with sense pleasures and making it learn for itself. Sometimes thoughts like “this is impermanent” or other stock phrases will arise, not to push the longing away(or it could be and im mistaken) but as I understand these are still surface level and aren’t actually talking directly to the citta. Any advice for this?

Thank you for any guidance you’re willing to offer.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-16 05:11:52

> Should I reflect on danger/drawbacks, impermanence, etc?

Yes, that should be the main effort. It sounds like you’ve become habituated to the precepts and restraint externally, but without the certainty that your mind wouldn’t return to those things even if you wanted it to. The only relief that’s not unwholesome comes from that certainty, and it’s cultivated by clarifying the danger of what you’re already disengaged from.

Don’t try to contemplate the danger in sensuality in some abstract sense; just clarify the danger in returning specifically to breaking the precepts. By not doing so the mind still remains open to that possibility even if it never comes up, and that’s why it wouldn’t be at ease. Unease doesn’t require explicit confirmation that enemies are coming; it’s enough not to know with full certainty that they’re *not* coming. Factually, they might all be defeated, but unless you *know* that, you will still be subtly anxious.

To be clear, you’re not looking for some positive announcement from your mind that the precepts will never be broken. You simply see that when you bring up the intention never to engage in misconduct again, resistance and reservations no longer arise. That means the citta is obedient to that extent (the internal enemies are defeated).

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-16 11:11:10 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> The only things I still occasionally give in to or have not 100% said no to in terms of never giving in for the rest of my life are using Dhamma as a soothing tool(especially for doubt) and to relax/enjoy, likewise with food.

Sure, but what I’m saying is beyond merely not breaking them. A lot of people haven’t broken any precepts for decades and they’re nowhere near the right practice. What I’m describing is the factual joy that will be felt when having not broken the precepts and become accustomed to them, you mentally establish them as an immovable context that permeates everything you do, say, or think. You actively highlight to yourself the benefit of staying within those boundaries, and the unassailable freedom from danger that it entails. “Unassailable” because nothing and

no one could force you to break the precepts. It's always been your decision, and that decision has become unthinkable because the danger in it is clear.

> About my other questions, about endurance on the "right level" and the body posture context, am I on the right track? And likewise for finding the line with proliferation of thoughts and mere observation.

You can forget about that for now.

The right level is not something you do or create; it's when what you will *not* do (because it's unwholesome) is crystal clear, and abstaining from it is effortless because the mind has been trained to that degree.

## Possibility and eventuality

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Puthujjana381 *2026-01-13 10:51:20*

# Dhamma eye

The insight of the dhamma eye is usually phrased as "whatever has the nature to manifest also has the nature to cease" [yaṁ kiñci samudayadhammaṁ sabbaṁ taṁ nirodhadhammaṁ].

# Stronger statement

However, I think a few times now I've encountered (for example in Right Way of Striving) the seemingly stronger statement that "whatever has the nature of arising, because of that it *will* have to cease".

I don't think the stronger statement that something *will* cease follows from the fact that it *might*. It's possible for something to be perpetually liable to cessation, yet for it never to actually cease.

So I'm trying to understand in what sense the stronger statement is true and how to see it. I'll write down my current thoughts on it, and would like to invite anyone with better clarity to respond and help me understand.

- First of all, I'm not sure if the stronger statement in such a from form appears in the suttas, the closest things I can think of are:
  - It could have not been, and it wouldn't be for me, it won't be, it won't be for me [no cassa no ca me siyā, na bhavissati na me bhavissati] (little hard to translate to English I think, since English mixes up tenses with optative)
  - Impermanent indeed are constituents, of a nature to appear and vanish; having appeared they cease, their settling is happiness [Aniccā vata saṅkhārā, uppādavayadhammino; Uppajjitvā nirujjhanti, tesaṁ vūpasamo sukho]

- I believe Ñāṇavīra Thero addresses this question to some extent in Fundamental Structure II.5. My current takeaway would be that something arisen can endure for only so many eternities (of eternities of eternities…) before it will finally have to cease. This seems feasible, but I only see it to some extent and quite abstractly, and not sure how to make it more directly felt and concrete.
- In fact, in some Dhamma talks, in order to counter the common aversive thought of "oh, this is impermanent, it will cease" to try to soothe one's discomfort, it's recommended to think "no, this is permanent, it will last forever". I see how both of these are aimed at dispassion: seeing the impermanence undermines attachment to the dear, while seeing that something might endure forever undermines the aversion to the disliked. Yet the truth should somehow reconcile the two without contradiction.
- I wonder if the stronger statement is actually only true *for a sotāpanna*? Since they are said to know a phenomenon (e.g. feeling), its condition, its cessation and the path leading to its cessation. The puthujjana, not knowing the way leading to its cessation, is subject to the possibility of feeling for eternity. Until that eternity ceases?

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-16 04:55:34

> I believe Ñāṇavīra Thero addresses this question to some extent in Fundamental Structure II.5. My current takeaway would be that something arisen can endure for only so many eternities (of eternities of eternities…) before it will finally have to cease. This seems feasible, but I only see it to some extent and quite abstractly, and not sure how to make it more directly felt and concrete.

Yes, I wouldn't recommend going that route.

> I see how both of these are aimed at dispassion: seeing the impermanence undermines attachment to the dear, while seeing that something might endure forever undermines the aversion to the disliked. Yet the truth should somehow reconcile the two without contradiction.

And it does. Impermanence means that things both could end next moment or last "forever," as in far longer than however long you expect them to last. So whether you hope for novelty or permanence, your hopes are undercut by *anicca.*

> I wonder if the stronger statement is actually only true for a sotāpanna? Since they are said to know a phenomenon (e.g. feeling), its condition, its cessation and the path leading to its cessation. The puthujjana, not knowing the way leading to its cessation, is subject to the possibility of feeling for eternity.

No, no quite. That would assume that there is some overall situation of being subject to feeling independent of what is currently being felt, and that's not how it works. A puthujjana remains subject to one of the three specific feelings (MN 74), and there

is no stability to be found there. Even if they wanted to experience nothing but displeasure and dismay (e.g. at being puthujjana), pleasure or neutrality would take over sooner or later.

## Mittasutta: satipaṭṭhāna practice for puthujjanas?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Solip123 *2026-01-12 21:27:36*

In the Mittasutta (SN 47.48) the Buddha tells the monks to teach “friends and colleagues, relatives and family” the four satipaṭṭhānas.

What do you make of this?

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-13 05:08:41

It doesn’t negate the prerequisites for *satipatthāna* established by a multitude of other Suttas, such as the one right before.

Try as you may, you will not be able to get someone who still looks for pleasure in the world to subdue longing and aversion in regard to the world. It’s like asking them to jump off a cliff.

At best, they will be able to shift their longing to a new thing in the world, and that, though very common today, is not *satipaṭṭhāna.*

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-13 08:09:15 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

That would only be possible if yoniso manasikāra was a quality independent of one’s choices, but it isn’t. Engaging and intending to engage in sensuality *is* ayoniso manasikāra.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-13 08:17:59 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

Neither. They’re identical.

## Yoniso Manasikara in practice

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Silatigi1 *2026-01-12 00:41:45*

Dear @Bhante Anigha

I have a very practical question about yoniso manasikara.

Let's say a pressure comes and I have trained to let it be, to let it exists, aka not acting out of body (grab food, look at things to buy) and speech (swearing at the pain of sustaining the unpleasant pressure, crying at the difficulty of sustaining it), but not yet by mind (not sure yet about the signs and features, at the moment more trying to survive the wave of the screaming pressure, but with the cigarette that I stop smoking many many years ago I kind of get an inkling of what this could feel like).

Now the question is how do you practically apply yoniso manasikara, what is it that you discern from a first person perspective?

So the pressure is there, say a restlessness, and you let it be without acting, then thanks to that pressure being here and remaining here there is something that I can discern that I could not discern if it was not there, if I (seemingly) got rid of it by acting.

So in the metaphor it would be suddenly I feel the lead of the dog pulling me when I stand my ground. I can also relate to the dog differently for the first time, I experience the dog and the lead whereas before both were invisible together to me as a pair.

Or the current of the river, and the pole I hold on to. Without the pole, no current is felt. Or the spoiled child putting on a tantrum and my resolution not to give in.

So my question is what is it that you discern from a first person perspective when the pressure is present? What is that thing that could not be seen without that pressure?

Anything concrete you could point to would be very helpful e.g ideally several different practical examples of pressure and what one could discern while enduring patiently the pressure.

Because unfortunately when I hear "with this, this" I don't need necessarily concretely understand what the second "this" is when the first "this" is the pressure...

Thanks in advance for your help

Sil

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-13 04:56:19

> So my question is what is it that you discern from a first person perspective when the pressure is present? What is that thing that could not be seen without that pressure?

The fact that all satisfaction of the pressure is actually still within suffering. You get to see first-hand that the presence of craving, not the lack of its fulfillment, is what suffering is.

# How Should Buddhist Cosmology be Interpreted?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Additional_Fix8417 *2026-01-09 15:24:05*

Currently reading AN and noticed how characters such as “King Yama” and “wardens of hell” inflict pain on the man who in the past performed “bad kamma”.

Assuming the former two characters were true, would they have the choice (of action; kamma) to punish or not to punish the “evil doer,” thereby abandoning kamma for themselves? As such stories if taken literally may just undermine the legitimacy of the law of kamma in relation to re-becoming, since characters such as “King Yama” and “wardens of hell” may not have the choice not to act in a way that inflicts pain on another, whether or not that other individual “deserves” it).

Should these stories be regarded metaphorically and that these characters are in a way manifestations of one’s own kamma? Mere lores largely inherited by preceding cultures and traditions?

Sutta reference: AN 3:36

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-11 10:29:29

> Assuming the former two characters were true, would they have the choice (of action; kamma) to punish or not to punish the “evil doer,” thereby abandoning kamma for themselves? As such stories if taken literally may just undermine the legitimacy of the law of kamma in relation to re-becoming, since characters such as “King Yama” and “wardens of hell” may not have the choice not to act in a way that inflicts pain on another, whether or not that other individual “deserves” it).

No, that doesn’t follow at all. A soldier may have an extreme pressure on him to kill for his country, potentially facing severe consequences for refusing to do so. That doesn’t in any way diminish his accountability for killing.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-11 11:56:23 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

Yes, that’s what I’m referring to as well. Them being born to perform those roles doesn’t mean they’re not responsible for actually performing them. So the principle of kamma still applies.

It’s no different than how human existence is made for sensuality and reproduction. If you want liberation, you don’t do what your birth is meant for.

# What should I do if I struggle to discern intentions of greed, aversion, or delusion?

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: Solip123 *2026-01-07 06:06:35*

Will this become easier to do as I become established in the precepts?

I've been trying to keep the precepts and gradually add more of them, but I find myself largely unable to tell when my intentions are rooted in craving. I can sort of look at the amount of pressure, the overall hedonic tone, and question the content of the intentions in an attempt to 'triangulate' it, but I sense that this is not the right way of going about it. This is also often doesn't work. I will often ask myself "why do I want to do this?" or "why am I doing this / why did I do that?" and in response there will be nothing, just a blank mind.

Also, I have an additional (and somewhat related) question: what am I supposed to do when I am trying to keep the eight precepts (or something near that)? The boredom kicks in very quickly.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-10 20:17:07

> I can sort of look at the amount of pressure, the overall hedonic tone, and question the content of the intentions in an attempt to 'triangulate' it, but I sense that this is not the right way of going about it.

Yes, that's going to be abstract.

What you have to do is (1) not be breaking the eight precepts currently, (2) not forget that you will not do so no matter what happens (this means avoiding anything that obfuscates that conscious commitment even when it aids external restraint, chiefly meditation techniques). That's it. The mind will certainly try to sneak out of that confinement in the beginning, but there will be no opening if those two things are maintained. Eventually it will calm down and start to genuinely prefer staying within the boundaries.

> Also, I have an additional (and somewhat related) question: what am I supposed to do when I am trying to keep the eight precepts (or something near that)? The boredom kicks in very quickly.

As part of the effort to keep the precepts, you *can't* do anything besides not forgetting that you won't intentionally break them under any circumstances. Finding something additional to do in the name of practice would compromise point #2 above. As for things unrelated to the practice that you might do, you can't decide that in advance. It's whatever comes up despite the deliberate commitment to the precepts remaining ironclad.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-12 05:49:15 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

The problem is that you're still thinking in terms of what to do. That's inevitably going to leave you susceptible to doubt. If you know what you're not going to do, you will completely stop caring about what you will do. And what you're not going to do is break any of the precepts.

If the intention never to pursue unwholesome content like TV, movies, etc. is crystal clear, then whatever intention there is to consume Dhamma content will not be problematic because it won't be leaning towards entertainment. It's because the boundary is unclear, not because of any neutral actions, that there is still pressure towards the full breach (if you were to abstain from consuming Dhamma content and just stare at the wall, the same pressure towards entertainment would be felt because you're still not clear about what you won't do).

As for the peril of sensuality, breaking the precepts is what sensuality is, so the peril is discerned in regard to those specific actions. When their danger is evident, there is no way to maintain even the most fleeting intentions towards them. Instead of hunting for those fleeting intentions, which will be an endless and ultimately unsuccessful task, you ruin the appeal of what all of them point towards, so they all wither away.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-13 08:15:39 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

There's no word missing. I meant that keeping the precepts is done by choosing to keep the precepts. Any other choice has to be done with that primary choice enduring as background, not in place of it.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-14 05:16:00 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> So, I should stop indulging in less coarse forms of entertainment/ distraction first and then consuming the Dhamma content shouldn't be an issue anymore?

No, you don't take for granted that you will consume Dhamma content. You maintain the context that you won't be pursuing the obvious forms of entertainment, and if the pursuit of Dhamma content had an intention leaning in the direction of those coarser things then it will be clear and you won't be engaging with Dhamma at that time. Intention is the leaning towards the obvious action even if it never ends up being done.

> So, if I understand correctly, the mental withdrawal from (read: devaluing of) sensuality will occur naturally as a result of abstaining from sen-

> suality for a long enough period of time?

No, physically abstaining from it won't do much by itself. Within the physical withdrawal, you have to contemplate the peril and communicate to your mind that it should under no circumstances go there. The point is that that contemplation is in relation to the specific actions and situations outlined by the precepts, not in regard to some abstract idea of sensuality that extends to everything and nothing.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-16 05:29:49 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> There is still, though, a certain sense that sensuality has to be something more than merely the leaning towards breaking the precepts.

It is. The root of sensuality is the lack of internal clarity that sensuality will not be returned to. If there's unclarity (muddledness/delusion), then sensuality still looms even if no explicit intentions towards it are present now. By itself, the latter is just the state of an infant (MN 78).

See also this comment.

### Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-16 05:39:29 *(in reply to a comment not included)*

> Is this a reasonable way of going about it, or is this style of contemplation faulty?

Yes, because it's edging towards an undefined result. What you have to do is simply reflect on your intention to keep the precepts unconditionally, and if the mind's reaction to that is at least neutral, your work is done for now, and you just have to make sure that you don't obfuscate that intention (which is how the opposite intentions begin to take root). If there is internal push-back against that intention of restraint (including in the form of doubt, not just coarse desire), *then* you make the effort to clarify the danger in breaking the precepts.

## After Recognizing Sensuality as Bait for Hindrances : Right Effort to protect one from that sinking feeling.

**Subreddit**: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by**: rs_87_78 *2026-01-06 07:27:37*

Hello fellow practitioners,

Through first hand experience, I understand that Gross Sensuality is a trap. It is the gateway to craving which leaves one vulnerable to the other 4 hindrances.

However, I now find myself overly vigilant, guilty and a little helpless and restless. If conditional experiences are unsatisfactory and impermanent, what am I to extract a subtler more refined form of peace (Joy) from ?

Are there any interesting hobbies you guys have inculcated that reinforce wholesome states of mind ? Something that mitigates dependent behavior tendencies while also reinforcing a sense of meaning.

Which brings me to another query : If one is through conduct, abandon the aggregates, with the intention of abandoning ownership of a self, is there no room for Self-Worth ? Wouldn't this line of thinking create a void that exacerbates vulnerability to the hindrances ?

Warm regards.

## Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-06 17:04:29

> However, I now find myself overly vigilant, guilty and a little helpless and restless. If conditional experiences are unsatisfactory and impermanent, what am I to extract a subtler more refined form of peace (Joy) from ?

That's normal, and the solution is not to find something to relieve that confinement; it's to get used to it, which requires not going outside of it, i.e., breaking the precepts. When it gets used to it the mind will stop resisting it, and it will cease to be unpleasant. That cessation of resistance to restraint, without anything added on top, is the only type of joy that is in line with the Dhamma, since it comes craving falling away, not from fulfilling the same need in a more refined way.

The latter keeps the mind from protesting in the immediate present, but it also means no internal training will occur even if the precepts are kept externally.